

THE DAY OF THE LORD: VOLUME 1

THE DAY OF THE LORD: VOLUME 1

THE DAY HEAVEN COMES TO EARTH

THE RESTORATION SERIES
BOOK 3

DR. TIM JAMES



The Day of the Lord: Volume 1 — The Day Heaven Comes to Earth

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Tree of Life

*A symbol of the Holy Spirit's
presence and the
restoration of all things.
(Acts 3:21)*

DEDICATION

*To Jeanne —
my anchor and my co-laborer,
who waited patiently
while I watched the sky.*

EPIGRAPH

2 [28] *“And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions. [29] Even on the male and female servants in those days I will pour out my Spirit. [30] And I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth, blood and fire and columns of smoke. [31] The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the LORD comes. [32] And it shall come to pass that everyone who calls on the name of the LORD shall be saved. For in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there shall be those who escape, as the LORD has said, and among the survivors shall be those whom the LORD calls.”*

— Joel 2:28-32

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FOREWORD

The Day of the Lord: Volume I — The Day Heaven Comes to Earth

The Day of the Lord is not a single twenty-four-hour period, but the climactic fulfillment of God's redemptive plan. On that Day, Jesus the Messiah will be revealed as Jesus the King, reigning over God's Kingdom on the earth.

Two things are being redeemed:

1. Righteous humanity — those who belong to Him.
2. The Kingdom of God on earth — the realm over which He will rule in righteousness.

Two “has come in” triggers will mark the *beginning* of that Day:

1. The full number of Gentile believers (**Romans 11:25**)
2. The full number of martyrs (**Revelation 6:11**)

When these are complete, King Jesus will relocate from the heavens to the earth.

The *end* of that Day will be marked by one of two possible events:

1. The moment when “all Israel will be saved” (**Romans II:26**).
2. The wedding supper of the Lamb in Jerusalem.

Both echo the marriage covenant that began at Sinai.

The Day of the Lord will:

- Celebrate the unbroken thread binding Genesis to Revelation, Eden to the New Jerusalem, and “*In the beginning*” to eternity.
- Bring about the restoration and renewal of the earth.
- Fulfill God’s original purpose: to dwell with His family in righteousness, on a restored earth — New Jerusalem.

In Volume I, we will explore the prophetic architecture of the Day of the Lord:

- The *words* of the Old Testament prophets, Jesus, and His New Testament disciples.
- The *signs* and waypoints that mark progress along God’s timeline, culminating in His parousia and the resurrection — the *changing* of the righteous.

On that Day, the righteous will rise in glorious immortality. The unrighteous will face judgment and annihilation.

Author’s Note on Verb Tense

Throughout this book, you will notice that I occasionally adjust verb tenses in Scripture quotations. This is not to rewrite the Bible but to draw attention to a vital truth: much of what the prophets and apos-

bles saw has yet to come to pass. Though ancient, these visions speak of events still ahead. I want you to feel the weight of their certainty — as if they were written for your tomorrow.

— *Dr. Tim James*

PREFACE

The Bible repeatedly speaks of “the Day of the Lord”—from the prophets of the Old Testament to the apostles of the New. Yet today, few believers truly understand its meaning, timing, or implications. Modern eschatology, influenced by sensationalist predictions, fictionalized apocalyptic novels, and commercially marketed charts, often leaves the Church with a fragmented and confusing view of the end times.

This book seeks to restore clarity. It will explore the Day of the Lord from a scriptural perspective, revealing the righteous purpose of resurrection, judgment, and the establishment of God’s eternal Kingdom on earth.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

To my students, friends, and readers: Thank you for walking with me through the Restoration Series. Your insights and encouragement have sharpened this work.

To the scholars whose work helped frame this study—especially Dr. Michael Heiser, Roger David Aus, and N.T. Wright: Thank you—your voices continue to challenge and refine my own.

Above all, I thank the Lord Jesus Christ, who will be coming back soon.

Come, Lord Jesus. Amen

“IN THAT DAY” & “AT THAT TIME”

PROPHETIC MARKERS OF CHRIST’S PAROUSIA

A recurring phrase throughout Scripture is “in that day” or “on that day.” It signals prophetic moments—turning points in the history of redemption. That phrase almost always refers to the Day of the Lord when Christ returns (parousia). Below is a curated list of notable references:

“In that day” / “On that day”

Isaiah

- **Isaiah 2:11** – “The haughty looks of man shall be brought low... and the Lord alone will be exalted *in that day*.”¹
- **Isaiah 4:1** – “*In that day* seven women shall take hold of one man...”¹
- **Isaiah 4:2** – “*In that day* the branch of the Lord shall be beautiful and glorious...”¹
- **Isaiah 10:20** – “*In that day* the remnant of Israel... will lean on the Lord...”¹
- **Isaiah 11:10** – “*In that day* the root of Jesse... shall stand as a signal for the peoples...”¹

- **Isaiah 12:1, 4** – “You will say *in that day*, ‘I will give thanks to you, O Lord...’”¹
- **Isaiah 17:4** – “*In that day* the glory of Jacob will be brought low...”¹
- **Isaiah 19:21** – “*And the Lord will make Himself known to the Egyptians, and the Egyptians will know the Lord *in that day*...”¹
- **Isaiah 19:24** – “*In that day* Israel will be the third with Egypt and Assyria...”¹
- **Isaiah 26:1** – “*In that day* this song will be sung in the land of Judah...”¹
- **Isaiah 27:1-2** – “*In that day* the Lord... will punish Leviathan... *In that day*, ‘A pleasant vineyard, sing of it!’”¹
- **Isaiah 30:23-26** – “And *on the day* the Lord binds up the brokenness of His people... the moon will be as bright as the sun...”¹
- **Isaiah 52:6** – “Therefore, My people shall know My name. *Therefore in that day* they shall know that it is I who speak...”¹

Ezekiel

- **Ezekiel 29:21** – “*On that day* I will cause a horn to spring up for the house of Israel...”²

Zechariah

- **Zechariah 2:11** – “And many nations shall join themselves to the Lord *in that day*...”³
- **Zechariah 3:10** – “*In that day*, declares the Lord of hosts, every one of you will invite his neighbor...”³
- **Zechariah 9:16** – “*On that day* the Lord their God will save them...”³
- **Zechariah 12:3-4, 6, 8-9** – Multiple instances of “*on that day*” marking the Lord’s defense of Jerusalem.³

- **Zechariah 13:1** – “*On that day* there shall be a fountain opened...”³
- **Zechariah 14:4, 6, 8-9, 13, 20-21** – Repeated use of “*on that day*” tied to the Messiah’s return and the reshaping of Jerusalem.³

These prophetic markers orient the reader toward climactic fulfillment. “In that day” points to God’s direct intervention—often in judgment, sometimes in blessing, always in sovereignty.

“At That Time”

Jeremiah

- **Jeremiah 3:17** – “*At that time* Jerusalem shall be called the throne of the Lord...”⁴
- **Jeremiah 30:7** – “*At that time...* it is a time of distress for Jacob...”⁴
- **Jeremiah 50:20** – “*At that time*, declares the Lord, iniquity shall be sought in Israel, and there shall be none...”⁴

Daniel

- **Daniel 12:1** – “*At that time* shall arise Michael...and there shall be a time of trouble..”⁵

Zephaniah

- **Zephaniah 3:19-20** – “*At that time* I will deal with all your oppressors... *At that time*, I will bring you in...”⁶

Matthew

- **Matthew 24:10** – “*At that time* many will fall away and betray one another...”⁷

- **Matthew 25:1** – “*At that time* the kingdom of heaven will be like ten virgins...”⁷

These passages frame the events surrounding the Day of the Lord. Whether speaking of judgment or restoration, they signal God’s sovereign action—*at that time, on that day, in that day*—and draw the reader into the final arc of His redemptive plan.

These verses highlight God’s appointed times: judgment, mercy, and restoration.

Endnotes

1. Isaiah 2:11; 4:1-2; 10:20; 11:10; 12:1,4; 17:4; 19:21,24; 26:1; 27:1-2; 30:23-26; 52:6
2. Ezekiel 29:21
3. Zechariah 2:11; 3:10; 9:16; 12:3-4,6,8-9; 13:1; 14:4,6,8-9,13,20-21
4. Jeremiah 3:17; 30:7; 50:20
5. Daniel 12:1
6. Zephaniah 3:19-20
7. Matthew 24:10; 25:1



THE UP/DN SCRIPTURAL JOURNEY OF THE DEAD

SHEOL IS DOWN. THE EARTH'S SURFACE IS UP.
AND ONLY JESUS WENT UP TO HEAVEN.

No Human But Jesus Ascended to Heaven at Death

No human ascends to heaven at death. All descend (DN) to Sheol, and the righteous await resurrection (UP) when Christ returns.

- **John 3:13** – “No one has ascended into heaven except the One who came from heaven.”
- **Genesis 37:35** – Jacob expected to descend to Sheol.
- **Numbers 16:30–33** – Korah and followers went down alive.
- **Psalms 30:3** – David: “O LORD, You have brought up my soul from Sheol.”
- **Matthew 12:40** – Jesus descends to Sheol’s Paradise.
- **Ephesians 4:9–10** – Christ alone ascends.
- **1 Thessalonians 4:16–17** – Resurrection occurs at His return.
- **Hebrews 11:35–40** – Righteous patriarchs awaited resurrection.

NOTE: Sheol is the underworld where all disembodied spirits temporarily reside.

- Paradise = the righteous side awaiting the First resurrection and eternity with God.
- Hades = the unrighteous side awaiting the Second resurrection and the eternal lake of fire judgment.

Some English translations confusingly render *Sheol* as *Hades*; In this work, the author rejects that equivalence. Also, do not confuse Hades (a.k.a. “hell”) with Gehenna (final destruction/lake of fire) or the Abyss/Tartarus (angelic prison).

UP/DN Reference Chart

#	Passage	Direction	Description
1	Genesis 37:35	DOWN	Jacob expects to descend to Sheol
2	Numbers 16:30–33	DOWN	Korah and his company go alive into Sheol
3	Psalms 30:3	UP	David brought up from Sheol
4	Isaiah 14:15	DOWN	Lucifer cast down to Sheol
5	Matthew 12:40	DOWN	Jesus in the heart of the earth (Sheol)
6	Ephesians 4:9–10	DOWN/UP	Christ descends, then ascends above the heavens
7	1 Thessalonians 4:16–17	DOWN/UP	Christ descends, dead rise to the surface
8	Hebrews 11:35–40	UP	Righteous receive a better resurrection
9	Acts 2:29, 34	DOWN	David is in Sheol’s Paradise

10	1 Enoch 22	DOWN	Sheol has hollows for righteous and wicked
11	Wisdom 16:13	DOWN/UP	God leads to Hades and brings up again

Author's usage: *Paradise* (a.k.a. Abraham's Bosom) and *Hades* are both compartments within Sheol — the underworld realm of disembodied spirits.

Further, the author maintains that spirits in Hades no longer have souls as they will no longer have a connection to God. (Spiritual Death = Separation from God.)

On the other hand, since righteous disembodied spirits will eternally be connected to God, they retain their original, purified by-the-blood-of-Christ souls. It's a concept packed with nuance, so I am not dogmatic about it—just something to consider.



COMPARING THE MOSAIC COVENANT AND THE NEW COVENANT

FOUNDATIONS FOR UNDERSTANDING THE DAY OF THE LORD

Feature	Mosaic Covenant	New Covenant
Nature	Conditional	Unconditional
Scope	National (Israel)	Universal (all nations)
Law	Written on stone	Written on hearts
Forgiveness	Provisional	Complete & final
Purpose	Reveal sin & Messiah	Redeem, transform, prepare Kingdom people
Duration	Temporary	Eternal
Mediator	Moses	Jesus Christ

- **Mosaic Covenant:** Law-centered, conditional, national, temporary. Shadows of Christ (Exodus 19-24; Deuteronomy 28).
- **New Covenant:** Fulfilled in Christ (Jeremiah 31:31-34; Luke 22:20).

Comparison Table: Mosaic vs. New Covenant and the Day of the Lord

Feature	Mosaic Covenant	New Covenant	Fulfillment in the Day of the Lord
Mediator	Moses	Jesus the Messiah	Jesus returns as King and Judge
Scope	National – Israel	Universal – Jew & Gentile	All nations under Messiah's rule
Basis	Conditional obedience	God's unconditional promise	Perfect obedience of Christ applied to His people
Law Location	Written on stone tablets	Written on hearts by the Spirit	God's law fully internalized in the resurrected righteous
Sacrifices	Animal blood, repeated	Messiah's blood, once for all	No more sacrifices — sin abolished
Duration	Temporary, until Messiah	Eternal	Fully operative in the Kingdom
Blessings/Curses	Physical blessings & curses tied to the land	Spiritual & eternal blessings	Complete removal of curse from creation
Kingdom Status	Foreshadowed in Israel's monarchy	Inaugurated at Messiah's first coming	Consummated at His return — the Day of the Lord

Relation to the Day of the Lord

Under the Mosaic Covenant, forgiveness was provisional and had to be repeated continually. Under the New Covenant, forgiveness is complete and final. The Day of the Lord fully realizes the New

Covenant promises: universal transformation, Israel's turning to the Messiah, reversal of Mosaic curses, and righteous reign under Christ.



INTRODUCTION: WHAT DAY ARE WE TALKING ABOUT?

If this insults anybody... well, then I'm talking to YOU. Just kidding. Mostly.

“For the day of the Lord is near upon all the nations.

*As you have done, it shall be done to you;
your deeds shall return on your own head.”*

— Obadiah 1:15

The Day of the Lord is the climactic day of Scripture—the convergence of God’s judgment, promises, Messiah, and Kingdom. The prophets heralded it, pleaded for it, and proclaimed it. It begins when heaven shakes, the earth trembles, the sun darkens, and God’s fury falls on all that is evil and unrighteous. Yet He shelters, protects, and rewards all who endure faithfully and walk in righteousness.

Scriptural Foundations: The Day of the Lord

The phrase “the Day of the Lord” appears repeatedly across both Testaments. It is a divinely orchestrated **season of cosmic and earthly intervention**—a time when God’s justice, mercy, and

kingdom purposes converge. The prophets and apostles describe it consistently:

Old Testament Highlights:

- **Isaiah 13:6-13** — A day of wrath and fierce anger; the heavens tremble, the stars and constellations do not give their light.
- **Joel 2:1-11** — Darkness and gloom accompany the arrival of God's army.
- **Amos 5:18-20** — A warning against those longing for it; it will be darkness, not light.
- **Zephaniah 1:14-18** — Distress, devastation, and divine fire will mark the day.

New Testament Highlights:

- **John 16:33** — Tribulation comes in this age, but Christ overcomes the world.
- **Acts 14:22** — Believers must endure many tribulations to enter God's kingdom.
- **Romans 5:3-9** — Suffering produces endurance; through Christ we are saved from God's wrath.
- **1 Thessalonians 1:10, 5:9** — Jesus delivers us from the wrath to come.
- **Revelation 14:14-20** — The double harvest: the righteous are gathered, the wicked judged in the winepress of God's wrath.

The Day of the Lord in the OT and NT

Scripture	Summary
Isaiah 13:6–13	Day of wrath and cosmic upheaval; God judges Babylon; stars and constellations darken.
Joel 2:1–11	Day of darkness and gloom; God's army arrives to execute judgment.
Amos 5:18–20	A day longed for by the wicked becomes darkness, not light.
Zephaniah 1:14–18	Day of distress, devastation, and divine fire against the rebellious.
Acts 2:20	Peter cites Joel; cosmic signs precede the great and awesome day.
1 Thessalonians 5:2	Paul: the day comes like a thief in the night, sudden and unexpected.
2 Thessalonians 2:1–4	The Day has not yet come; it will follow rebellion and the revelation of the lawless one.
Revelation 6:17	Great day of God's wrath; none can withstand it.
Revelation 14:14–20	Dual harvest imagery: righteous gathered, wicked judged; angels execute divine justice.
Matthew 24:30–31	Christ gathers His elect at His return.
Revelation 19:11–21	Christ leads a divine military campaign, defeating the Beast and his armies.
Revelation 20:1–6	Satan is bound; the Millennial Kingdom begins; First Resurrection inaugurated.

Why Don't More Christians Talk About It?

If your church experience is like mine, you've probably never heard a

sermon on the Day of the Lord—or if you did, it was a rare occasion. Modern teaching often reduces that Day to fear-mongering about “the end of the world.”

Meanwhile, celebrity preachers and bestselling authors have hijacked the most monumental day in human history and turned it into a marketing product. They peddle fear, dazzle with speculative charts, and leave people more confused than equipped. That is deception. They have corrupted faith in Jesus Christ into an enterprise of prognostication—not far removed from occult fortune-telling.

This book exists to change that. Let’s start here:

“Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching. The time has come when people reject sound teaching. Having itching ears, they seek out teachers who cater to their passions. They have turned away from listening to the truth and wandered off to the deceptive teachings of cutesy pastors. ...[7] (Paul:) I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. [8] Henceforth there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will award to me on that day. — not only to me but also to all who have loved His appearing.”

— 2 Timothy 4:2-4, 7-8 (paraphrased)

We will trace **every mention of the Day of the Lord in Scripture**—its signs, seals, chronology, warnings, and promises. Above all, we will follow the King Himself, Jesus the Messiah, as He breaks the seals, shakes the heavens, rescues His people, and establishes His Kingdom.

The journey begins here—with eyes open, hearts ready, and the Word of God as our guide.

The Bible uses the phrase “the Day of the Lord” over and over—from the prophets of the Old Testament to the apostles of the New. It is a

consistent and cohesive term. Yet today, few in the Church understand what the phrase means, where it begins, how long it lasts, or what role the Church plays within it.

This foundational chapter will uncover the depth of this critical term, provide historical and prophetic context, and explain why recovering a biblical understanding of the Day of the Lord is essential to restoring the Christian hope.

The Problem with Modern Eschatology

Modern eschatology, especially in Western evangelical circles, has surrendered its anchor to the seabed of Chaos. Influenced by sensationalist predictions, fictionalized apocalyptic novels, and heavily marketed prophecy charts, many believers operate with a fragmented understanding of the end times. Terms like “rapture,” “tribulation,” and “millennium” are thrown around without anchoring them to their scriptural foundation.

The phrase “the Day of the Lord” is consistently used throughout both Testaments, and yet it has largely been ignored—or misunderstood. This book begins by restoring this central term to its rightful place.

“The Day of the Lord”

The Day of the Lord is not a twenty-four-hour period. Nor is it the end of the world. Instead, it is the beginning of the New Age, which will position us in the eternal presence of God Himself.

It will be a divinely orchestrated season—a sequence of cosmic and earthly interventions that begins with the judgment of the wicked and culminates in the renewal of all things.

The Phrase in the Old Testament

The first occurrence of the phrase “the Day of the Lord” (Hebrew: *yom YHWH*) is found in the writings of the early prophets:

The Day of the Lord signals divine intervention—but that is only bad for the unrighteous whose names are not in the Lamb’s book of life. For the righteous dead in Paradise, and the righteous alive on the surface of the earth, it is the first day of eternity with our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

Get It Right!

The righteous may endure *tribulation* (thlipsis)—the pressure of persecution in this age—but they are explicitly spared from *wrath* (orgé)—God’s judicial punishment poured out in the Day of the Lord.

- **John 16:33** — “*In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world.*”
- **Acts 14:22** — “*...through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God.*”
- **Romans 5:3** — “*We rejoice in our sufferings [thlipsis], knowing that suffering produces endurance...*”
- **2 Timothy 3:12** — “*Indeed, all who desire to live a godly life in Christ Jesus will be persecuted...*”

The Righteous Will Avoid God’s Wrath (Gr. Orgé)

- **Romans 5:9** — “*Since, therefore, his blood has now justified us, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath (orgé) of God.*”
- **1 Thessalonians 1:10** — “*...Jesus who delivers us from the wrath (orgé) to come.*”
- **1 Thessalonians 5:9** — “*For God has not destined us for wrath (orgé), but to obtain salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ...*”

Apocalyptic Imagery: The Two Harvests on the Day of the Lord (Revelation 14:14-20):

- **Righteous** — Wheat — Christ sends angels to gather His elect (the First Resurrection): “[15] *And another angel came out of the temple, calling with a loud voice to him who sat on the cloud, ‘Put in your sickle, and reap, for the hour to reap has come, for the harvest of the earth is fully ripe.’* [16] *So he who sat on the cloud swung his sickle across the earth and the earth was reaped.*”
- **Wicked** — Grapes — Then, the wicked are separated and judged (the harvest of wrath, orgé): “[18] *And another angel came out from the altar... ‘Put in your sickle and gather the clusters from the vine of the earth, for its grapes are ripe.’* [19] *So the angel swung his sickle... and threw it into the great winepress of the wrath of God.*”
- **Matthew 13:36-43** (Wheat and Weeds / Tares)
- **Matthew 13:47-50** (Parable of the Net)
- **Matthew 24:30-31** (Gathering the Elect)
- **2 Thessalonians 1:7-9**
- **Revelation 19:13,15**

The Resurrection and the Day of the Lord

The resurrection of the righteous dead and the “changing” of the righteous alive will happen on the Day of the Lord, as Christ is descending from His heavenly abode, and is followed by His army of angels. Therefore, all the righteous will already have their immortal glorified bodies *before* the Bowls of God’s wrath are poured out — and thus be immune from suffering or death as a consequence of “the wrath of the Lamb.”

The Coming of the Messiah and The Day of the Lord (Already, But Not Yet)

In Jewish expectation, the Day of the Lord was associated with the arrival of God's Anointed One—the Messiah—who would judge the wicked and establish God's rule on earth.

In the first century, however, the Messiah came not as a conquering king but as a suffering servant. Jesus inaugurated the Kingdom of God, but He did not yet bring the final Day of the Lord.

Thus, the early Church lived in a state of prophetic tension. They knew the Day of the Lord had not yet come in fullness — and they also recognized that Jesus' resurrection and ascension were but the opening acts.

Peter, quoting Joel 2, declared at Pentecost:

“The sun shall be turned to darkness and the moon to blood, before the day of the Lord comes, the great and magnificent day.”

— Acts 2:20

The early believers understood that the Day of the Lord was still in the future. Yet they lived with urgency and hope and faithful endurance even unto death.

Paul and the Day of the Lord

Paul reinforced this in his letters:

- **1 Thessalonians 5:2** – *“For you yourselves are fully aware that the day of the Lord will come like a thief in the night.”*
- **2 Thessalonians 2:1-4** – Paul urged believers not to be deceived into thinking the Day has already come. Paul taught that Day will not arrive until *“the rebellion comes first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed.”*

In Paul's theology, the Day of the Lord was the defining moment

when Christ would return, raise the dead, overthrow the rebellious powers, and begin His reign.

Sequential (7 Phases)

Far from being a sudden cataclysmic event that ends history in an instant, the Day of the Lord unfolds in phases:

1. **The Resurrection and Glorification of the Righteous** (*1 Thessalonians 4:16; Revelation 20:4-6*). At the parousia, the righteous dead are raised in glorified, immortal bodies. This is the First Resurrection—the opening phase of the Day of the Lord. This is the inauguration of the saints’ royal destiny—they are raised not merely to life, but to rule. The righteous saints are caught up to meet the returning King in the air — not removed to heaven, but to accompany Him as He begins His visible reign on earth.
2. **The Harvest of the Wicked by Angelic Reapers** (*Matthew 13:41-42; Revelation 14:17-20*). With the righteous gathered, angelic reapers are sent out. Their mission: to weed out all who cause sin and practice lawlessness. Their removal is not just punitive—it is purgative. The Kingdom of God cannot be inherited by the wicked (*1 Corinthians 6:9*), and so this harvest clears the field for righteousness. The imagery is graphic — the wicked are thrown into the “winepress of God’s wrath,” a metaphor for the terrifying judgment that follows.
3. **The Return of Christ to Earth: A Military Campaign** (*Zechariah 14:4; Revelation 19:11-21*). The King does not descend directly to the Mount of Olives. Instead, Scripture hints at a broader, multi-stage procession. **Isaiah 19:1** declares: “Behold, the Lord is riding on a swift cloud and comes to Egypt...” This prophetic entrance signals the start of a visible, geographical campaign. From Egypt to Bozrah (*Isaiah 63:1-6*), then up through Edom and into Jerusalem

— a prophetic, military-movement sequence. Christ's descent is not directly to the Mount of Olives; it is a military campaign of redemption and vengeance. He rides from Egypt, through Bozrah, stained with the blood of His enemies (Isaiah 63:1-6), and finally sets foot on the Mount of Olives in Jerusalem (Zechariah 14:4). Before He arrives at the Mount of Olives, Christ advances across the land with power and vengeance. His presence shakes the nations; His purpose is to reclaim what is rightfully His and to recover the remnant of Israeli refugees.

4. **The Defeat of Antichrist and His Global Coalition** (*Revelation 19:19-21; 2 Thessalonians 2:8*). The Beast, his armies, and the kings of the earth assemble to make war against the Lamb. But they are no match. King Jesus destroys them with the breath of His mouth and the sword of His word. This is not merely a human war — it is the final exposure of all who align themselves with the dragon, both human and fallen.

Interlude: The Angelic Armies — The Overlooked Campaign

(*Joel 3:11; Revelation 12:7-9; Isaiah 13:3-5*)

While Christ descends and begins His terrestrial advance, the hosts of heaven are not idle. Angelic armies — “holy ones,” “mighty ones,” and “reapers” — sweep across the earth and skies, executing judgment. These are intelligent, holy warriors empowered to cleanse and reclaim dominion (*Psalms 82; Daniel 10*). Their targets include demonic strongholds, rebellious powers in the heavenlies (*Ephesians 6:12*), and the earthly coalition under the Beast. Read *Isaiah 13:4b* — “The LORD has mustered His army for battle.” And *Joel 3:14* — “Multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision!” This is the cosmic cleansing that will precede Christ's arrival in Jerusalem. It is a war of supernatural proportions.

5. **The Binding of Satan and the Inauguration of the Millennial Kingdom** (*Revelation 20:1-6*). With the Beast defeated and the spiritual powers crushed, Satan himself is bound and thrown into the abyss. The age of deception ends. Christ begins His visible reign on earth — the long-awaited Messianic Kingdom. With the serpent bound, the deceiver silenced, and the usurpers crushed, the earth can finally enter into its long-awaited Sabbath rest.
6. **The Installation of the Saints as Co-Rulers** (*Daniel 7:27; Revelation 5:10*). Those who shared in the First Resurrection now take up positions of authority. Kingship is not symbolic. Their thrones are not metaphors. These resurrected saints will judge nations, administer justice, and reign under the authority of the Great King, fulfilling the promise of **Revelation 2:26-27**. The glorified saints are assigned foundational roles — judging, governing, and shepherding the nations under Christ's leadership.
7. **The Final Judgment (Great White Throne)** (*Revelation 20:11-15*). At the end of the thousand years, the unrighteous dead are raised for judgment. This is not resurrection to life, but to condemnation. The books are opened, and every deed is laid bare. Death and Hades are cast into the lake of fire. This sequence is drawn from Scripture. Each step builds on the last. And it all fits under the banner of the Day of the Lord. This is not part of the First Resurrection, but a distinct event for the unrighteous dead. It concludes the Day of the Lord and ushers in the New Creation.

Why This Matters

Understanding the Day of the Lord as a biblical sequence restores clarity to Christian eschatology, reunifying scattered doctrines—such as resurrection, judgment, kingdom, and reward—into a cohesive vision.

More importantly, it shifts the Church's posture. Rather than hoping to escape earth through a secret rapture, the Church is to prepare for glory. The saints are destined to be glorified, enthroned, and commissioned to reign *with* Christ. This vision demands readiness, righteousness, and resilience. It restores the weight and wonder of our calling:

"If we endure, we will also reign with Him."

— 2 Timothy 2:12

Preview of the Restoration to Come

This First Chapter opens the door to the grand project of *The Day of the Lord* Volume 1. In the chapters ahead, we will explore:

- The First Resurrection and its distinction from resuscitation
- The unveiling of the sons of God
- The defeat of hostile powers in heaven and on earth
- The Millennial Reign of Christ and His Glorified Saints
- The Final Judgment and New Creation

It all begins with this recovered phrase: *The Day of the Lord*.

That Day should not be a moment of fear, but a season of victory. Not an escape, but an enthronement. Not the end, but *the long-awaited beginning of the reign of God on earth*.

"The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever."

— Revelation 11:15



Addendum: Glorified Saints vs. Angelic Hosts

1. Glorified Saints = The New Divine Council / Executive Cabinet

- **Daniel 7:27** — “*And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High...*”
- **Revelation 5:10** — “*...and they shall reign on the earth.*”
- **1 Corinthians 6:2-3** — “*Do you not know that the saints will judge the world? ... Do you not know that we are to judge angels?*”

This governance role is consistent with the Divine Council paradigm (Heiser et al.), in which glorified humans replace the disloyal *elohim*. Psalm 82 foreshadows this turnover:

82 [6] “*I said, ‘You are gods, sons of the Most High, all of you; [7] nevertheless, like men you shall die, and fall like any prince.’*”

— **Psalm 82:6-7**

Jesus quotes this Psalm in **John 10:34-36**, affirming that these “sons of God” were once divine beings. Their judgment is certain. They are stripped of their immortality, cast down, and replaced by the glorified saints.

2. Glorified Saints Never Engage in Warfare

There is no biblical passage that depicts glorified, resurrected saints engaging in battle. Throughout Scripture, it is always the *angelic hosts* who do the fighting.

The glorified saints serve in civil government, judicial roles, and kingdom administration during the Millennium.

Revelation 19 emphasizes this distinction:

19 [14] “*And the armies of heaven, arrayed in fine linen, white and pure,*

were following Him on white horses. [15] From His mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations, and He will rule them with a rod of iron. He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”

— **Revelation 19:14-15**

3. Christ Alone Treads the Winepress

Only Christ executes the wrath of God:

“He will tread the winepress of the fury of the wrath of God the Almighty.”

— **Revelation 19:15**

“I have trodden the winepress alone, and from the peoples no one was with me.”

— **Isaiah 63:3**

His singular role underscores His unique authority to execute God’s furious orgé wrath. When Scripture says “from the peoples no one was with me,” it means humans. Humans are people. The glorified saints neither assist nor participate in this judgment. But that doesn’t necessarily mean that angels (“holy ones”) won’t be standing by ready and able to participate.

4. The Armies of Heaven Are Powerful and Fierce Warriors

- **Revelation 19:14** says they are “**the armies of heaven**” — *stratiôtai* in Greek — which unmistakably means **military forces**. There’s no honest way to suggest otherwise.
- Michael and his angels already fought and defeated the Dragon (**Revelation 12:7-9**). The angelic armies of heaven are **elite, battle-hardened, supernatural warriors**.
- **Zechariah 14:5** refers to them plainly:

“Then the Lord my God will come, and all the holy ones with Him.”

Very important that everyone understands this:

“Holy ones” (Hebrew *qedoshim*, Greek *hagion*)—when used in celestial or eschatological military contexts—**always refers to angelic beings**, i.e., divine council members or loyal *elohim* (as in Deuteronomy 33:2, Daniel 7:10, Zechariah 14:5, etc.). **“Saints”** (*hagios* in plural form in Greek) — consistently refers to **redeemed human believers**, particularly in NT usage and in Pauline writings. **“Holy ones” = angels/elohim. “Saints” = humans.**

Conclusion:

Nowhere in Scripture do we see glorified saints wielding weapons or participating in combat. Their mission will be administrative and judicial — aligned with their role as Christ’s divine cabinet and co-heirs of the Kingdom. Warfare is the domain of Christ and His angelic armies, not of the glorified human “saints.”

(End)

THE DAY OF THE LORD HAS A HISTORY

A PAST, PRESENT, AND FUTURE TRAJECTORY
FROM EDEN TO NEW JERUSALEM

A Pattern, Not Just a Punctuation

The Day of the Lord is not merely a terrifying punctuation mark at the end of history. It is a long arc—a divine trajectory.

It is God's thread woven through the rise and fall of empires, through prophets and kings, through judgments and resurrections, through suffering and glory. It stretches from Eden to the New Jerusalem. And it always centers on one truth: God returning to reign among His people.

Most Christians treat the Day of the Lord as a future crisis. But in truth, its foundation is ancient.

Its logic is covenantal.

Its unfolding is progressive.

Its end is glorious.

The Day of the Lord has already broken into history in glimpses—interrupting timelines, warning the wicked, preserving the righteous.

It has humbled nations and exalted God's justice. Most of all, it has declared, again and again, that God is not absent. He is present—and coming closer still.

Jesus came first as the humble sacrificial Lamb. He is coming again as the Warrior-King. He will inherit the Kingdom of God on this earth and reign from the throne of His earthly “father,” David (cf. *The Davidic Covenant*).

The Pattern is the Point

The Day of the Lord is not a dot on the eschatological timeline. It is a pattern—a divine rhythm.

History records multiple episodes of God disrupting rebellion, vindicating the faithful, and reasserting His rule.

Noah's flood was an already-but-not-yet Day of the Lord. So was the destruction of Sodom. The plagues on Pharaoh in Egypt? Another iteration. God descended in fire and smoke at Sinai, shaking the mountain. The fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC revealed the same pattern. Pentecost, when the Spirit was poured out, was yet another divine disruption. And supremely, so was the crucifixion and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

In each case, the pattern is consistent: the holy disrupts the unholy. The heavens descend. The earth trembles.

It is as though a Father, long-suffering, finally declares: *Enough*. His line of tolerance has been crossed, and He acts—first in discipline (*thlipsis*), then in wrath (*orgé*).

But this is not just about punishment. The righteous understand that *thlipsis* is temporary and never the same as the wrath of a Father who loves His children.

Even in judgment, God offers hope. All that is required for restoration is repentance and faith—faith in the saving grace Christ offered by His death and resurrection, and loyalty proven through obedience.

Confess. Repent. Believe. And on the Day of the Lord, you too will receive your crown: glorification and immortality—heirs of the Kingdom, inheritors of eternal life, experiencing heaven on earth.

God's Two Families

From the beginning, God's household has included two families: His heavenly sons—the *elohim*—and His human sons, the descendants of Adam. Both were made for sacred space. Both were given stewardship. Both were held to a standard.

Deuteronomy 32 lifts the veil on the cosmic order: When God divided the nations at Babel, He appointed *elohim* over the peoples but kept Israel as His own portion (vv. 8–9). These *sons of God* formed a divine council (cf. Psalm 89), but Psalm 82 exposes their failure. Though “sons of the Most High,” they judged unjustly, and were sentenced to “die like men.”

This same principle applied to Adam. He too was made in God's image—immortal, luminous, dwelling in God's presence. But Adam rebelled. His spiritual death—separation from God—was immediate. His physical death followed in time. The result? Exile. Judgment. Loss of status. This was the discipline of a loving Father, then the just penalty for covenant breach.

God has always ruled this way: blessing for loyalty, death for rebellion—whether in heaven or on earth.

The Glorious Future is Material

The Christian hope is not disembodied bliss. It is **resurrection**.

It is the return of Jesus Christ to rule in power, surrounded by glorified sons and daughters—the human family restored to their Edenic purpose.

The meek will inherit the earth. Eden will be reestablished. Righteousness will no longer be the exception but the rule.

Creation groans for that Day. Trees and oceans long for their Creator's return.

Leadership for the New Age

God is already preparing the administration for this coming age. Two groups—one earthly, one heavenly—will serve as His governors and guardians in the renewed world:

- **The Maskilim — The Wise Human Ones.** Daniel 11–12 describes them. These are the spiritually discerning—trained by suffering, filled with understanding, destined to shine like stars. Jesus echoed their calling in His parables. So did Paul and Peter in their exhortations. These are the overcomers: glorified, spirit-filled rulers, co-reigning with Christ. From the Hebrew root “maskil,” meaning “wise, prudent.”
- **The Angelic Zealots — The Holy Host.** Christ does not return with earthly revolutionaries, but with celestial enforcers. His angels burn with holy fire. They uphold righteousness—out of holy zeal for the Kingdom of God.

NOTE: The divine *šēbā'ôt* — Yahweh's heavenly armies — are, by definition, zealous for His holiness and justice. **Isaiah 9:7** explicitly says:

“The zeal of the LORD of hosts will do this.”

Together, these two families—restored humanity and loyal *elohim*—will rebuild what was ruined, teach the nations, and enforce the will of the King of kings.

Why This Matters Now

Western Christianity often treats books about this coming age as unreliable fantasy—or worse, as irrelevant. But it's important to realize that this book is about our destiny. This is our hope. This is the glory to which we've been called.

You're not alive in this generation by accident or fate. If you've ever wondered why you were born now—into *this* cultural moment—it's because God is raising up overcomers. He is training a government of glorified sons and daughters to reign with His Son. You are being prepared—*now*—for that role.

The Day of the Lord has a history. But it also has a destination. And that destination is drawing near.

This is the cosmic backdrop of the Day of the Lord—a plan that has always included both families, both realms, and one divine mission: **restoration.**



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does understanding the Day of the Lord as a recurring divine pattern, rather than a single future event, reshape traditional eschatological frameworks?
2. In what ways does the concept of covenantal continuity—from Eden through New Jerusalem—affect interpretations of God’s justice and mercy in redemptive history?
3. How do the roles of the ‘Maskilim’ and ‘Angelic Zealots’ fit within the broader biblical theology of divine governance and cosmic order?
4. What are the theological implications of viewing resurrection and restoration as a material, bodily hope rather than a purely spiritual or symbolic one?
5. How can the notion of ‘two families’—human and divine sons—help clarify the relationship between angelic beings and humanity in God’s plan?
6. What challenges arise when reconciling the destructive aspects of the Day of the Lord with the loving, redemptive purposes of God?
7. How should modern Christians understand their role as ‘overcomers’ in light of the historical and future trajectory of the Day of the Lord?

THE REALM OF THE DEAD

SHEOL, PARADISE, AND THE BIBLICAL PATTERN OF DEATH AND RESURRECTION

The biblical worldview recognizes that death is not the end, but a transition into one of two very real spiritual compartments within Sheol — the realm of the dead. Scripture makes it plain that both the righteous and the unrighteous go down to Sheol at death, but to separate places within it. These compartments are distinct in purpose, population, and future destiny.

The Structure of Sheol

Sheol (Hebrew) or Hades (Greek) is not Hell. It is the temporary underworld where all the dead go while awaiting their final resurrection — either to life or to judgment (**Daniel 12:2; John 5:28-29**).

Jesus' parable of Lazarus and the rich man (**Luke 16:19-31**) gives us the most precise biblical snapshot of this division. The rich man is conscious in torment in Hades (Sheol), while Lazarus is comforted in "Abraham's Bosom" — Paradise. These two compartments are separated by a great chasm, making passage from one to the other impossible.

Hades: The Place of the Unrighteous Dead

Here the condemned await their final resurrection to judgment. In Luke's parable the rich man begs for relief, yet none is granted.

Paradise: The Place of the Righteous Dead

Paradise is where the faithful departed — those who trusted in God — are gathered in peace. Jesus promised the repentant thief on the cross, *"Today you will be with me in Paradise"* (**Luke 23:43**). This statement confirms that Paradise was still located in Sheol at the time of Christ's death.

Jesus Himself went there to proclaim victory (**1 Peter 3:19**).

And as Jesus repeatedly taught, no human ever goes to Heaven after death:

"No one has ascended into heaven except he who descended from heaven, the Son of Man" (**John 3:13**); *"You are from below; I am from above"* (**John 8:23**); *"Where I am going you cannot come"* (**John 13:33**).

The dead go down — the righteous to Paradise, the wicked to (Hades) torment — and remain until the day of resurrection.

What Happened After the Resurrection?

Despite widespread theological opinion, there is no scriptural basis for the idea that Jesus "emptied" Paradise or relocated it to Heaven after His resurrection. The souls of the righteous remain in Paradise within Sheol, still awaiting the First Resurrection, when Jesus returns in glory on the Day of the Lord (**Revelation 20:4-6**). Jesus did not evacuate Paradise — He confirmed the resurrection.

Paradise remains in the underworld, sealed off from torment, inhabited by the souls of those who died in covenant faith. Their resurrection will occur when the Lord descends, and the dead in Christ rise first.

Resurrection Still Awaits

As already described, all souls remain in their Sheol compartments until the appointed resurrection. The righteous dead will rise to receive glorified, immortal bodies and reign with Christ (**1 Thessalonians 4:16-17**). The unrighteous dead will be raised much later — after the thousand years — for judgment (**Revelation 20:5b, 11-15**).

This is why Scripture repeatedly refers to the dead as being “asleep.” They are not in Heaven. They are not yet resurrected. They are awaiting the call of God to rise.

The UP/DN Scriptural Journey of the Dead (Sheol is DOWN. The Earth's surface is UP.)

No one ascends to heaven at death. The dead descend to Sheol, and the righteous waiting in Paradise arise (resurrection) when Christ returns to seize His kingdom. Despite centuries of tradition, the consistent biblical witness is this:

- Humans do not ascend to heaven when they die.
- Humans descend (DN) to Sheol, the underworld — a place with distinct chambers for the righteous and the wicked — and remain there until the (UP) resurrection on the Day of the Lord.

Jesus said it plainly:

- *“No one has ascended into heaven except he who descended from heaven, the Son of Man.” — John 3:13*

- “You are from below; I am from above. You are of this world; I am not of this world.” — **John 8:23**
- “You will seek me, and just as I said to the Jews, so now I also say to you, ‘Where I am going you cannot come.’” — **John 13:33**

The Biblical Pattern: DOWN into Sheol, UP at Resurrection

1. Jacob expected to descend to Sheol: “I shall go down to Sheol to my son, mourning.” — **Genesis 37:35**
2. Korah and his followers went down alive: “The earth opened its mouth and swallowed them up... and they went down alive into Sheol.” — **Numbers 16:30-33**
3. Lucifer is cast downward: “You are brought down to Sheol, to the far reaches of the pit” — **Isaiah 14:15**
4. David affirms resurrection from below: “O LORD, You have brought up my soul from Sheol.” — **Psalms 30:3** (see **Acts 2:29-34**)
5. Jesus descended to Sheol’s Paradise: “The Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.” — **Matthew 12:40**
6. Christ alone rose and ascended: “He who descended is the one who also ascended far above all the heavens.” — **Ephesians 4:9-10**
7. At His return, He descends — and the dead rise up to meet Him: “The Lord himself will descend from heaven... and the dead in Christ will rise first.” — **1 Thessalonians 4:16-17**
8. The final resurrection includes those held in the sea and in Hades: “The sea gave up the dead... Death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them.” — **Revelation 20:13**

Confirmed by Ancient Sources

9. 1 Enoch 22 describes Sheol as compartmentalized, with separate hollows for the righteous and the wicked.

10. *“For you have power over life and death; you lead down to the gates of Hades, and you bring up again.” — Wisdom of Solomon 16:13*

Theological Summary

- Resurrection is UP from Sheol, not down from Heaven.
- Christ descended to Sheol’s Paradise, was raised to the surface of the earth, and later ascended to heaven (**Daniel 7:13-14**).
- The righteous await resurrection to reign on earth, not to live in Heaven (**Revelation 5:10**).
- Paradise is the righteous chamber of Sheol, until the resurrection on the Day of the Lord (**Luke 16:22; 1 Peter 3:19**).

DOWN to Sheol’s Paradise at death. UP to the earth’s surface at the resurrection of the righteous.

Nothing else fits the testimony of Scripture. Humanity was made for the earth — and resurrection brings us back to its surface.

(Turn the page to see the UP/DN Reference Chart)

UP/DN Reference Chart

#	Passage	Direction	Description
1	Genesis 37:35	DOWN	Jacob expects to descend to Sheol
2	Numbers 16:30–33	DOWN	Korah and his company go alive into Sheol
3	Psalms 138:1–2	UP	David brought up from Sheol
4	Isaiah 14:15	DOWN	Lucifer cast down to Sheol
5	Matthew 12:40	DOWN	Jesus in the heart of the earth (Sheol)
6	Ephesians 4:9–10	DOWN/UP	Christ descends, then ascends above the heavens
7	1 Thessalonians 4:16–17	DOWN/UP	Christ descends, dead rise to the surface
8	Revelation 20:13–14	UP	Dead released from the sea and Hades
9	Acts 2:29, 34	N/A	David has not ascended into heaven
10	1 Enoch 22	DOWN	Sheol has hollows for righteous and wicked
11	Wisdom 16:13	DOWN/UP	God leads to Hades and brings up again



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the biblical portrayal of Sheol as a divided realm challenge or confirm traditional Christian views on the afterlife?
2. What are the implications of Jesus' teaching that "no one has ascended into heaven except He who descended," for common assumptions about the immediate destination of souls after death?
3. In what ways does Luke 16's parable of Lazarus and the rich man function as a theological—not merely illustrative—description of the postmortem state?
4. How do extrabiblical texts like 1 Enoch and Wisdom of Solomon support or complicate the biblical picture of Sheol's compartments?
5. What theological tensions arise from the notion that Paradise remains in Sheol after Christ's resurrection, awaiting the First Resurrection?
6. How should the "up/down" biblical pattern of death and resurrection shape Christian hope and preaching on the resurrection?
7. How might this understanding of Sheol and resurrection influence pastoral care, especially regarding the comfort of believers facing death?

SIGNS AND WONDERS PRECEDING THE DAY

GOD'S WAKE-UP CALLS BEFORE THE END

2 [28] “And it shall come to pass afterward, that I will pour out My Spirit on all flesh; your sons and your daughters shall prophesy, your old men shall dream dreams, and your young men shall see visions. [29] Even on the male and female servants in those days, I will pour out My Spirit. [30] And I will show wonders in the heavens and on the earth, blood and fire and columns of smoke. [31] The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the LORD comes. [32] And... everyone who calls on the name of the LORD shall be saved. For in Mount Zion and in Jerusalem there shall be those who escape, as the LORD has said, and among the survivors shall there be those whom the LORD calls.”

— Joel 2:28-32

The Day of the Lord will not come as a covert operation. There will be no sudden “snatch and grab” of saints, spiriting them away to heaven while the world carries on in ignorance. Joel’s prophecy is clear: cosmic signs, geopolitical upheaval, and supernatural events will precede it — events visible to all who are watching. These signs are God’s way of announcing: *I am about to intervene.*

Jesus on the Mount of Olives

Jesus reaffirmed Joel's message in the Olivet Discourse (*Matthew 24*):

- False messiahs and deception (vv. 4–5)
- Wars and rumors of wars (v. 6)
- Famines, earthquakes, persecution (vv. 7–9)
- The gospel preached to all nations (v. 14)
- The abomination of desolation (v. 15)
- The great tribulation (v. 21)
- Celestial upheaval — *“Immediately after the tribulation... the sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light.”*
(v. 29)

JESUS DESCRIBED these as *birth pangs* — early contractions before the climactic delivery. Like natural labor, these pangs will grow in both **frequency and intensity** as the Day draws near.

Paul and the Apostolic Witness

Paul, too, confirms that prophetic prerequisites must occur before the Day arrives.

“The lawless one will be revealed... whom the Lord Jesus will kill with the breath of His mouth” (2 Thessalonians 2:8).

These include:

- The **apostasy** — a great falling away from the truth
- The revealing of **the man of lawlessness**
- The removal of **the restrainer** (a mystery still debated)

The Day is not “any day now.” God has given us markers to watch for.

Heavenly and Earthly Signs: Multi-Layered and Converging

The signs that herald the Day of the Lord span every realm:

Heavenly:

- Solar eclipses and lunar blood moons
- Meteor storms and celestial disturbances
- Atmospheric fire and smoke (cf. **Joel 2:30**)

Earthly:

- Global conflicts and shifting alliances
- Famines, pestilences, and environmental upheaval
- Israel and Jerusalem at the center of world attention

Moral:

- Widespread lawlessness and moral collapse
- Cultural deception and false ideologies
- Apostasy within the visible Church

Spiritual:

- A global outpouring of the Holy Spirit in dreams and visions
- A revived prophetic witness and restored biblical truth
- A purified, watchful remnant

These signs are like runway lights in thick fog. They do not hasten the Day, but they strip away illusions of “business as usual” and prepare both the world for judgment and the Church for refinement.

A Call to Discernment and Readiness

As I have written elsewhere on **Acts 14:17** and **Amos 3:7**: “*God never acts without witness.*” The signs are not for entertainment — they

demand a response. They call for repentance, holiness, and vigilance. God's command to His people is simple: **Watch. Be a watchman.** Be a voice crying in the wilderness (**Isaiah 40:3; John 1:23**).

In every age, scoffers dismiss the signs as coincidence, mocking those who live as John the Baptist did — preparing the way of the Lord. But Jesus is the light of the world (**John 8:12**), and we are called to reflect that light (**Matthew 5:14-16**). Prophetic discernment measures the moment against Scripture. Those who walk in the light will not be caught unaware.

The Hebrew word *maskilim* (from **Daniel 11-12**) describes the “wise ones” who discern the times and lead many to righteousness. That is our calling.

“But you are not in darkness, brothers, for that day to surprise you like a thief.”

— **1 Thessalonians 5:4**



REFLECT & Discuss

1. Why does God send signs before the Day of the Lord?
2. How can we distinguish between natural and prophetic events?
3. What signs do you see in our current generation?
4. What does it mean to be a *maskil* — a wise one prepared for the Day?

THE REVEALING OF THE LORD FROM HEAVEN

BIBLICAL CLARITY ON CHRIST'S COMING AND THE EARTHLY KINGDOM

“[5] This is evidence of the righteous judgment of God, that you may be considered worthy of the kingdom of God, for which you are also suffering —[6] since indeed God considers it just to repay with affliction those who afflict you, [7] and to grant relief to you who are afflicted as well as to us, when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven with His mighty angels [8] in flaming fire, inflicting vengeance on those who do not know God and on those who do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus. [9] They will suffer the punishment of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and the glory of His might, [10] when He comes on that Day to be glorified in His saints, and to be marveled at among all who have believed, because our testimony to you was believed.”¹

— 2 Thessalonians 1:5-10

Paul’s second letter to the Thessalonians gives us one of the most explicit declarations in Scripture of what the Day of the Lord entails. The Thessalonian church faithfully endured affliction, and Paul reminded them that God’s justice will include both retribution for the wicked and relief for the righteous — all on the same Day of the Lord.

Contrary to many modern teachings, the Day of the Lord is not a secret or silent rapture-to-heaven event. To the unrighteous, the revelation of the Lord Jesus from heaven will be open and terrifying — a fearsome unveiling:

6 [15] *“Then the kings of the earth and the great ones and the generals and the rich and the powerful, and everyone, slave and free, hid themselves in the caves and among the rocks of the mountains, [16] calling to the mountains and rocks, “Fall on us and hide us from the face of him who is seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb, [17] for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?”*²

— Revelation 6:15-17

Christ, Descending with Divine Fire and His Angelic Hosts

The passage begins by addressing the suffering and persecution of the believers and offers a divine assurance: their faithful endurance of hardship will be rewarded — justice will be executed.

No Pre-Tribulation Rapture

This language does not support a two-phase Second Coming separated by years. Instead, Paul emphasized a singular, climactic event where Jesus is “revealed from heaven with His mighty angels in flaming fire.” Humans are earthbound: Sheol is Down; Up is the surface of the earth. Humans never ascend (up) to “Heaven.” Instead, they descend to Sheol’s Paradise.

- ³ Ezekiel 14:9 — “*And the LORD will be king over all the earth. On that day, the LORD will be one and His name one.*”
- ⁴ Daniel 7:13-14 — “*...behold, with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man, and he came to thee Ancient of Days and was presented before Him. And to Him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom, that all peoples, nations, and languages should serve Him.*” NOTE: The phrase

“peoples, nations, and languages” always refers to the earth; it never refers to God’s celestial abode.

- ⁵ **Daniel 7:27** — “*And the kingdom and the dominion and the greatness of the kingdoms under the whole heaven shall be given to the people of the saints of the Most High; his kingdom shall be an everlasting kingdom, and all dominions shall serve and obey him.*”
- ⁶ **Psalms 37:9** — “*...those who wait for the LORD shall inherit the land.*”
- ⁷ **Psalms 37:11** — “*the meek shall inherit the land.*”
- ⁸ **Psalms 37:22** — “*...those blessed by the LORD shall inherit the land.*”
- ⁹ **Psalms 37:29** — “*The righteous shall inherit the land and dwell upon it forever.*”
- ¹⁰ **Psalms 115:16** — “*The heavens are the LORD’s heavens, but the earth He has given to the children of man.*”
- ¹¹ **Matthew 5:5** — “*Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth.*”
- ¹² **6:10** — “*Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.*”
- ¹³ **25:34** — “*...inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world.*”
- ¹⁴ **John 3:13** — “*No one has ascended into heaven except He who descended from heaven, the Son of Man.*”
- ¹⁵ **John 8:23** — “*You are from below; I am from above. You are of this world; I am not of this world.*”
- ¹⁶ **John 13:33** — “*You will seek me, and just as I said to the Jews, so now I also say to you, ‘Where I am going you cannot come.’*”
- ¹⁷ **4:13** — “*For the promise to Abraham and his offspring that he would be heir of the world did not come through the law but through the righteousness of faith.*” Abraham is not heir of heaven — he is heir of the world (kosmos, in Greek). The inheritance is earthly, just like the promise of the land.

- ¹⁸ **Galatians 3:29** — “And if you are Christ’s, then you are Abraham’s offspring, heirs according to the promise.
- ¹⁹ **James 2:5** — “God has chosen the poor in this world to be rich in faith and heirs of the kingdom that God has promised...” This “kingdom” refers to the earthly realm of inheritance.
- ²⁰ **Revelation 5:10** — “And you have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they shall reign on the earth.”
- ²¹ **Revelation 20:4-6** — “...and they will reign with Him for a thousand years.” Where is the Kingdom of God? On the earth, not in the heavens.
- ²² **Revelation 21:1-3** — “And I saw the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of the heavens from God...Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man.” Where? On the earth, not in the heavens.

Wherever you imagine “heaven” to be — in biblical thought, it is down, not up.

(Refer to the UP/DN Chart at the end of Chapter 2)

No Secret Return: The Apokalypsis of Christ

When Jesus is *revealed* — the Greek word used here for “revealed” is ἀποκάλυψις (*apokalypsis*), meaning “unveiling” or “disclosure.” It is not the idea of Jesus sneaking down to snatch away believers and leave others bewildered. Quite the opposite! The entire world will see Him, and those who have rejected Him will face judgment.

The Righteous Will Be Glorified

For the righteous who faithfully endure tribulations, it will be a wonderful Day. It will be the Day they receive their immortal, glorified body, like Jesus’:

3 [20] “...the Lord Jesus Christ, [21]... will transform our lowly body to be like his glorious body...”²³

— **Philippians 3:20-21**

- ²⁴ **2 Thessalonians 1:10** — “...when He comes on that Day to be glorified in His saints and to be marveled at among all who have believed.”

Eternal Horror For The Rebellions

For the unbelieving and unrepentant, the Day will be utterly dreadful. Paul writes that they will suffer “the punishment of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord and the glory of His might.”

²⁵ **Isaiah 2:19** — “And people shall enter the caves of the rocks and the holes of the ground, from before the terror of the LORD, and from the splendor of His majesty, when He rises to terrify the earth.”

²⁶ **Isaiah 13:9-11** — “Behold, the Day of the LORD comes, cruel, with wrath and fierce anger, to make the land a desolation and to destroy its sinners from it. For the stars of the heavens and their constellations will not give their light; the sun will be dark at its rising, and the moon will not shed its light. I will punish the world for its evil, and the wicked for their iniquity; I will put an end to the pomp of the arrogant, and lay low the pompous pride of the ruthless.”

²⁷ **Malachi 4:1** — “For behold, the day is coming, burning like an oven, when all the arrogant and all evildoers will be stubble. The day that is coming shall set them ablaze, says the LORD of hosts, so that it will leave them neither root nor branch.”

The biblical imagery is consistent: there is no comfort for the ungodly in that Day. It will not be a “warning shot” or a “near miss.” It will be final, decisive, and eternal in its consequences.

Our Blessed Hope

In contrast, for those in Christ, the Day of the Lord is the consummation of all promises — the Day when faith becomes sight. This is why Paul can speak of it as both a warning to the ungodly and a comfort to the righteous.

²⁸ **Titus 2:13** — “...waiting for our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ.”

²⁹ **1 Peter 1:13** — “Set your hope fully on the grace that will be brought to you at the revelation of Jesus Christ.”

³⁰ **1 John 3:2** — “...we know that when He appears we shall be like Him, because we shall see Him as He is.”

For the righteous, the Day of the Lord is not a cause for fear, but for joyful anticipation. The Judge is their Redeemer. The fire that consumes the wicked will refine and glorify the saints.



REFLECT & Discuss:

1. What does Paul teach about the justice of God in 2 Thessalonians 1?
2. How does the biblical picture of the Day of the Lord differ from popular “rapture” portrayals?
3. How does understanding the inheritance of the earth reshape your hope for the future?
4. What practical steps can believers take now to prepare for the revealing (*apokalypsis*) of Jesus Christ?

THE EARTHQUAKES IN THE DIVINE NARRATIVE

THE ROLE OF EARTHQUAKES IN THE ESCHATOLOGICAL TRANSFORMATION OF JERUSALEM

Opening Scene:

The mountain trembles. The sky splits. The earth reels beneath the feet of humanity. As heaven roars, every stronghold of man collapses. Divine megaphones, heralding His Day.

“And there were flashes of lightning, rumblings, peals of thunder, an earthquake, and heavy hail.”¹

Throughout Scripture, God has used earthquakes as both judgment and revelation. They accompanied covenantal moments (Sinai²), marked divine visitation (Elijah’s cave³), and heralded resurrection (Christ’s tomb⁴). In Revelation, earthquakes become unmistakable signs of apocalyptic transition and divine wrath.

The first major quake appears after the Sixth Seal is broken:

“There was a great earthquake, and the sun became black as sackcloth, the full moon became like blood...”⁵

This cosmic earthquake, accompanied by astronomical upheaval, will shake even the heavens:

“Yet once more I will shake not only the earth but also the heavens.”⁶

“Yet once more..., I will shake the heavens and the earth and the sea and the dry land. And I will shake all nations...”⁷

Subsequent global quakes occur repeatedly:

- **Revelation 8:5** — Thunder, lightning, and an earthquake at the opening of heaven when Christ and the angelic armies depart.
- **Revelation 11:13** — A tenth of Jerusalem collapses after the resurrection of the Two Witnesses (some interpret this as the same quake as 8:5).

The Greatest Earthquake in All Human History — Focused on Jerusalem

The climactic quake arrives with the Seventh Bowl judgment:

16 [17] *“The seventh angel (will pour) out his bowl into the air, and a loud voice (will come) out of the temple, from the throne, saying, ‘It is done!’”*
[18] *And there were flashes of lightning, rumblings, peals of thunder, and a great earthquake such as there had never been since mankind has been on earth, so great (will be) that earthquake.”⁸*

Revelation 16:17’s ‘It is done!’ echoes Jesus’ final cry on the cross—and again, the earth responds.

16 [19] *“The great city was split into three parts, and the cities of the nations fell, and God remembered Babylon the great, to make her drain the cup of the wine of the fury of His wrath. [20] And every island fled away, and no mountains were to be found.”⁹*

Ezekiel foresaw this very earthquake around 590 BC:

38 [19] “...On that day, there shall be a great earthquake in the land of Israel. [20] The fish of the sea and the birds of the heavens and the beasts of the field and ... all the people who are on the face of the earth, shall quake at my presence. And the mountains shall be thrown down, and the cliffs shall fall, and every wall shall tumble to the ground. [21] I will summon a sword against Gog on all my mountains, declares the Lord GOD.”¹⁰

Zechariah also prophesied this very moment circa 520 BC:

“On that day, his feet shall stand on the Mount of Olives before Jerusalem... and the Mount of Olives shall be split in two by a very wide valley.”¹¹

This upheaval reshapes Jerusalem, preparing it to become the capital of Christ’s Millennial Kingdom.

“Every valley shall be lifted up, and every mountain and hill be made low; the uneven ground shall become level, and the rough places a plain.”¹²

Psalm 48 calls Zion “the city of our God, His holy mountain.”

“...the city of our God, his holy mountain.
Beautiful in elevation, the joy of all the earth.”¹³

This ties back to the Edenic theme of Zion, the mountain of God (cf. my book, *Tree of Life*: “the mountain of God” named Eden).

Earthquakes as Divine Punctuation in Redemptive History

They strip false securities, flatten pride, and shake the nations with fear. In God’s redemptive drama, they are exclamation points announcing judgment or redemption.

Key Connections

- **Mount Sinai** — God descends in fire; the whole mountain trembles violently.¹⁴
- **Elijah's Cave** — Earthquake precedes the whisper of God's voice.¹⁵
- **Christ's Crucifixion** — The veil tears; the earth quakes.¹⁶
- **Christ's Resurrection** — A great quake; the stone is rolled away, opening the tomb.¹⁷

God's Wrath as Preparation

This final earthquake embodies both wrath and preparation — purging, purifying, and reshaping the earth for the next phase of God's plan: the return of the Second Adam.

Topographical Reordering for the Kingdom

Ezekiel's temple vision (**Ezekiel 47**) anticipates a river flowing east, which requires significant topographical changes — including the leveling of mountains east of Jerusalem.

Why Earthquakes?

Earthquakes are the quintessential image of cosmic instability and divine judgment. They dismantle human pride, shake political and religious powers, and prepare the world for God's kingdom. The final quake clears the stage for the King to restore all things.



(Table: The Role of Earthquakes in God's Prophetic Timeline is on the next page.)

The Role of Earthquakes in God’s Prophetic Timeline

Event	Scripture Reference	Earthquake Description	Theological Significance
The Giving of the Law at Sinai	Exodus 19:18	“The whole mountain trembled greatly”	God’s presence and covenant initiation with Israel
The Crucifixion of Jesus	Matthew 27:50–54	“The earth shook, and the rocks were split”	Marked Jesus’ death and tore the veil; God’s judgment and redemption
The Resurrection of Jesus	Matthew 28:2	“A great earthquake... the angel of the Lord descended”	Declared the victory over death and the inauguration of the First Resurrection
The Sixth Seal Judgment	Revelation 6:12	“A great earthquake” opens the Day of the Lord	Signals the beginning of God’s final judgments
The Seventh Seal Judgment	Revelation 8:5	“There were peals of thunder, rumblings, flashes of lightning, and an earthquake”	Prepares for trumpet judgments
The Seventh Trumpet Judgment	Revelation 11:13,19	“A great earthquake... a tenth of the city fell”	Jerusalem shaken at midpoint of the Tribulation
The Seventh Bowl Judgment	Revelation 16:18–20	“A great earthquake... no earthquake like it had ever occurred... the great city split into three parts”	Culminating cosmic judgment before Christ’s visible return
The Return of Christ at the Mount of Olives	Zechariah 14:4–5	“The Mount of Olives shall be split in two... you shall flee as you fled from the earthquake in the days of Uzziah”	Christ physically returns; geographical and prophetic fulfillment
Post-Day of the Lord Restoration	Isaiah 2:19,21; Ezekiel 38:19–20	Earthquakes accompany God’s purging of rebellion and preparation for Millennial reign	Cleansing and restoration of the earth

Superscript Key:

¹ Revelation 11:19

² Exodus 19:18

³ 1 Kings 19:11-12

⁴ Matthew 28:2

⁵ Revelation 6:12

⁶ Hebrews 12:26

⁷ Haggai 2:6-7

⁸ Revelation 16:17-18

⁹ Revelation 16:19-20

¹⁰ Ezekiel 38:19-21

¹¹ Zechariah 14:4

¹² Isaiah 40:4

¹³ Psalm 48:1-2

¹⁴ Exodus 19:18

¹⁵ 1 Kings 19:11-12

¹⁶ Matthew 27:51

¹⁷ Matthew 28:2

(Reflect & Discuss questions on the next page.)

REFLECT & Discuss

1. Why do you think God uses earthquakes as key apocalyptic signs?
2. How do the earthquakes in Revelation compare with other biblical earthquakes?
3. How does the topographical transformation of Jerusalem prepare the city for Christ's reign?
4. What structures—physical, political, religious—might God be preparing to “shake” in our time?
5. How does the destruction of Babylon contrast with the restoration of Zion?

THE PROPHETS AND THE DAY OF THE LORD

PROPHETIC FOUNDATIONS OF THE DAY OF THE LORD

Scene Setting

The wind howls over a ruined plain. A blackened sky swallows the sun, and the moon hangs low, crimson like spilled blood. Far off, towers crumble as the ground rolls beneath the feet of trembling armies. The voices of the prophets seem to echo from every direction—some warning, some pleading, some announcing the nearness of God’s fiery judgment. These visions, separated by centuries yet unified in theme, converge on one truth: the Day of the Lord is coming.

*“Wail, for the day of the Lord is near;
as destruction from the Almighty it will come!”*

— Isaiah 13:6

The Old Testament prophets each contributed a unique voice to the growing revelation of God’s purposes for His people and the earth. One consistent theme—woven like a thread through the scrolls of Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, and the Twelve—was the Day of the Lord.

This phrase, heavy with judgment and hope, destruction and renewal, finds ultimate fulfillment in the book of Revelation.

This chapter offers a brief overview of how several key prophets anticipated this future day. While each prophet had a specific historical context and audience, they all spoke of a climactic moment when God would intervene dramatically in human history—both to judge and to restore.

Isaiah: Global Judgment with a Purpose

Isaiah prophesied primarily to Judah in the 8th century BC during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah. He saw the Day of the Lord as a time of global upheaval, when human pride would be humbled and God alone exalted (**Isaiah 2:10-22**).

“Behold, the day of the Lord comes,
cruel, with wrath and fierce anger,
to make the land a desolation
and to destroy its sinners from it.”

— **Isaiah 13:9**

While the chapter begins as a prophecy against Babylon, it quickly telescopes into something far greater. The “whole earth” is shaken. The sun, moon, and stars refuse to shine (v. 10). Isaiah foresaw cosmic signs—darkened skies, shaking heavens, and a trembling earth. These motifs reappear vividly in Revelation.

Yet Isaiah’s vision was not only judgment—it was also glorious. After the wrath purges evil, restoration and renewal will come. With Jerusalem restored, the nations will be drawn to God’s light, and death will be swallowed up forever (**Isaiah 25:6-9**).

Isaiah’s central theme: **judgment is redemptive**. The Day of the Lord

isn't about pointless destruction—it sets the stage for a righteous reign.

Ezekiel: Gog, Magog, and Earthquakes

Ezekiel, exiled to Babylon in 597 BC, prophesied during the years leading to Jerusalem's fall. His visions of the Gog and Magog invasion (**Ezekiel 38–39**) describe an eschatological battle where God Himself intervenes with overwhelming force—including earthquake, pestilence, and hail.

This language closely parallels **Revelation 20:8-9**. Yet Ezekiel's finale is not annihilation—it's renewal: a new temple, a sanctified land, and God's glory returning to dwell among His people. **Restoration follows devastation.** That rhythm never breaks.

Joel: Signs in the Heavens

Joel's prophetic date is uncertain, but his message is direct and apocalyptic. He begins with a locust plague—judgment in miniature—then escalates to a military invasion and cosmic upheaval.

“The sun shall be turned to darkness, and the moon to blood, before the great and awesome day of the Lord comes.”

— Joel 2:31

Joel layers a progression of judgment: agricultural collapse, locust swarms, and heavenly signs. But the goal isn't terror—it's repentance (**Joel 2:12-17**). And his conclusion offers hope: the Spirit will be poured out on all flesh (**Joel 2:28**), and “the Lord dwells in Zion” (**Joel 3:21**). Joel contributes a defining prophetic trait: **Zion-centered eschatology.**

Amos: When the Day is Darkness

Amos, a shepherd and fig-grower, prophesied to the northern kingdom during a time of prosperity. Israel was religious—but deeply unjust. They assumed the Day of the Lord meant vindication. Amos warned otherwise:

*“Woe to you who desire the day of the Lord!
Why would you have the day of the Lord?
It is darkness, and not light.”*
— **Amos 5:18**

Amos rebuked the national presumption. Israel assumed they were exempt because of their heritage or rituals. However, unless they recognized their Messiah and repented, judgment would come. That warning still rings true.

Today, some assume a national flag or a one-time prayer guarantees safety from God's judgment. Amos says: *Check your heart, not your heritage.*

Obadiah: Edom and the Nations

Obadiah—though the Bible's shortest prophetic book—delivers a piercing warning:

“For the day of the Lord is near upon all the nations. As you have done, it shall be done to you.”
— **Obadiah 1:15**

Though directed at Edom, Obadiah widens the lens to global judgment. Every nation will be brought under God's righteous scrutiny. This has nothing to do with the U.N. or the I.C.C. This is divine justice—*final, total, and inescapable.*

Zephaniah: The Totality of the Day

Zephaniah, a royal descendant of Hezekiah, ministered during King Josiah's reign. His warnings are among the most terrifying in Scripture:

*"The great day of the Lord is near,
near and hastening fast;
...a day of wrath is that day,
a day of distress and anguish,
a day of ruin and devastation."
— Zephaniah 1:14-15*

Zephaniah's vision sweeps over Judah and the nations. Yet hope emerges. Zephaniah 3 speaks of a purified people and restored worship in Zion. Again, the rhythm holds: *judgment purifies—so that renewal may follow.*

Zechariah: Earthquakes and a King in Jerusalem

Zechariah, active around 520 BC, encouraged the post-exilic community to rebuild the temple. His visions are richly symbolic, profoundly apocalyptic, and thick with Day of the Lord imagery.

He foresaw the Lord standing on the Mount of Olives, which would split in two during a cataclysmic earthquake (**Zechariah 14:4-5**). Revelation echoes this seismic imagery during its sixth and seventh seals.

Zechariah also envisions living waters flowing from Jerusalem and all nations worshiping the King annually. His prophecy aligns seamlessly with **Revelation 21-22**.

Prophetic Synthesis

Though separated by centuries, geography, and political circumstances, these prophets spoke as if reading from the same script. They describe the same converging realities—cosmic signs, global judg-

ment, Jerusalem's centrality, and ultimate restoration under God's reign. Their visions are puzzle pieces that lock perfectly into Revelation's final portrait of the Day. Far from disjointed, their voices form a single prophetic symphony.

Key Themes in the Prophets' View of the Day

- Cosmic Upheaval — Signs in the sun, moon, and stars accompany God's judgments.
- Targeted Judgment — The wicked are destroyed, but the faithful are preserved.
- Zion Restored — God reigns from Jerusalem; nations come to worship.
- Call to Repentance — The Day is conditional; repentance can change outcomes.
- Global Scope — While Israel is central, all nations are drawn into the event.

(Table: Prophets and the Day of the Lord - Quick Reference is on the next page.)

Prophets and the Day of the Lord

Prophet	Time Period (BC)	Main Judgment Image	Main Restoration Image	Revelation Parallel
Isaiah	740–680	Cosmic darkening, earth shaken	Nations drawn to God's light	Rev. 6, 21
Ezekiel	593–571	Gog/Magog invasion, earthquake	Temple & glory return	Rev. 20–21
Joel	Uncertain	Locusts, sun darkened, moon to blood	Spirit poured out, Zion restored	Rev. 6, 21
Joel	Uncertain	Locusts, sun darkened, moon to blood	Spirit poured out, Zion restored	Rev. 6, 21
Amos	~760	Day is darkness for the unrepentant	Justice restored in the land	Rev. 19–20
Obadiah	Uncertain	Nations judged	Kingdom belongs to the Lord	Rev. 19
Zephaniah	~640	Global devastation	Purified worship in Zion	Rev. 20–21
Zechariah	~520	Mount of Olives quake	King reigns, living waters flow	Rev. 14, 21–22

REFLECT & Discuss

1. Which of the prophetic voices do you find most striking—and why?
2. Why is it important to distinguish between redemptive judgment and blind catastrophe?
3. What does it mean that the Day of the Lord centers on Zion?
4. Can you see how the Day of the Lord unites the prophets' messages into a single future event?

THE ROLE OF ISRAEL AND JERUSALEM IN THE DAY OF THE LORD

JERUSALEM: THE EARTHLY THRONE OF THE COMING MESSIAH

8 [3] “Thus says the LORD: I will return to Zion, and dwell in the midst of Jerusalem. Jerusalem shall be called the City of Truth, and the Mountain of the LORD of hosts, the Holy Mountain.”

— Zechariah 8:3

Israel: The Chosen People and God’s Covenant Center

The story of the Day of the Lord is inseparable from the land, the people, and the city God chose as His earthly dwelling place. Israel is not merely one nation among many; it is the centerpiece of God’s redemptive plan.

From the covenant with Abraham to the prophetic visions of the Kingdom, Israel remains the vessel through which God reveals His glory and judges the nations.¹

The prophets emphasize that a dramatic restoration of Israel—both physical and spiritual—will mark the Day of the Lord. This restoration is cosmic in scope, encompassing not only the regathering of God’s scattered people but also the renewal of creation itself. It antici-

pates the reversal of the Babel judgment, restoring unity under God's sovereign reign over all nations and realms.

Jerusalem: The Heart of the Prophetic Drama

Jerusalem stands at the intersection of heaven and earth in the unfolding drama of the Day of the Lord. It is far more than a mere city or geographical location; it is a divine symbol—the holy mountain where God's presence dwells among His people (**Psalm 48:1-2**).

In the ancient worldview, the “holy mountain” functions as the cosmic throne room of God, a place where heaven's authority intersects with the earth's reality—a theme echoed in the Divine Council framework that shapes much of the Old Testament prophetic vision.²

Zechariah's vision of the LORD standing on the Mount of Olives (**Zechariah 14:4-5**) anticipates a cataclysmic transformation—both geological and spiritual. The splitting of the mountain is more than an earthquake; it is a divine act signaling the inauguration of a new era. Jerusalem will be physically reshaped and spiritually elevated to become the eternal capital of the Messiah's Kingdom, the center of God's universal rule.

The Restoration of Israel and the Nations

The prophets foresaw a time when Israel would no longer be a symbol of judgment but a beacon of hope and a spiritual magnet drawing all nations.

Isaiah's vision of nations streaming to Zion to learn God's ways and walk in His paths (**Isaiah 2:2-4**) reverses the scattering of Babel, pointing to the universal reign of God over every tribe and tongue.³

Yet, the Day of the Lord is also a day of reckoning. The nations that opposed Israel and rejected God's covenant will face divine judgment.

Obadiah's sharp indictment of Edom (**Obadiah 1:15**) reminds us that no nation is exempt from accountability.

But judgment is never the end of the story. A purified remnant from among the nations will join the worshipers of the King, acknowledging His righteous rule and contributing to the peace and justice of the new creation.

The Temple and Worship in the New Era

Ezekiel's temple vision (**Ezekiel 40–48**) reveals the centrality of worship in the coming Kingdom.⁴ The temple represents more than a physical structure; it symbolizes God's restored presence among His people and the healing of creation itself.

The renewal of sacrificial worship, the river of living water flowing from the temple, and the sanctification of the land all point to a world finally made right.

This vision points ahead to the Millennial Kingdom, where true worship will be restored as the unifying force of God's people. Jerusalem will become the spiritual hub where God's name is honored and His will is done "on earth as it is in heaven" (**Matthew 6:10**).

Worship is not simply ritual but the very expression of God's holiness and the believer's joyful submission to His reign.

Why Israel Still Matters

Some in the modern Church minimize Israel's ongoing role, teaching that the Church has replaced Israel as God's chosen people.⁵

While the Church is a vital part of God's redemptive plan, Scripture is clear: Israel remains indispensable in the eschatological drama. Paul

affirms this in Romans 11, emphasizing that God's covenant promises to Israel are irrevocable (**Romans 11:29**). Their future restoration will bring blessing not only to Israel but to the entire world.

The Day of the Lord will reveal God's faithfulness to His ancient promises, fulfilling what the prophets long foresaw and the patriarchs eagerly awaited—a covenant renewal that includes both Israel and the nations under Messiah's eternal reign.

Chapter Notes

- ¹ See Genesis 12:1–3; 15:5–21; and 17:7–8. God's covenant with Abraham includes land, descendants, and blessing to all nations—fulfilled gradually through Israel and ultimately in the Messiah. For scholarly discussion, see N.T. Wright, *The New Testament and the People of God*, Fortress Press, 1992, pp. 260–264.
- ² Zechariah 14:4–5 describes the Lord standing on the Mount of Olives and causing it to split in two. This has been interpreted both literally (e.g., a seismic event) and symbolically (a divine act signaling transition). See Michael Heiser, *The Unseen Realm*, Lexham Press, 2015, pp. 329–332.
- ³ Isaiah's vision of nations streaming to Zion reverses Babel and anticipates the universal reign of God. See John Oswalt, *The Book of Isaiah, Chapters 1–39*, NICOT, Eerdmans, 1986, pp. 117–120.
- ⁴ Ezekiel's temple vision is famously complex and has been interpreted in different ways—as a literal future temple, a symbolic ideal, or a theological parable. Heiser suggests it depicts God's intention to dwell permanently among a purified people. See Heiser, *The Unseen Realm*, pp. 359–364; and Daniel Block, *The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25–48*, NICOT, Eerdmans, 1998.

- ⁵ The idea that the Church has replaced Israel is called Replacement Theology. Paul clearly rejects this in Romans 11:1-2 and 28-29. For a rebuttal of supersessionism, see Craig A. Blaising and Darrell L. Bock, *Progressive Dispensationalism*, Baker Academic, 1993, pp. 141-150.



REFLECT & Discuss

- Why is Jerusalem the focal point of the Day of the Lord in Scripture?
- How does the restoration of Israel impact your understanding of God's justice and mercy?
- What does Ezekiel's temple vision tell us about worship in the coming kingdom?
- How can believers today live in hopeful anticipation of Israel's restoration?
- How does the Church relate to Israel's role in God's eschatological plan?

THE MAN OF LAWLESSNESS AND THE FALSE PROPHET

THE BATTLE FOR THE SOUL OF HUMANITY

“Let no one deceive you in any way. For that day will not come, unless the rebellion comes first, and the man of lawlessness is revealed, the son of destruction.”

— 2 Thessalonians 2:3

Prophetic Significance

Scripture paints a chilling portrait of a figure who will rise in the end times—the Antichrist, also known as the Man of Lawlessness. This individual embodies absolute rebellion against God, lawlessness, and blasphemy, becoming the supreme adversary to God’s redemptive plan.

Paul’s letter to the Thessalonians underscores that the revelation of this figure is a pivotal prophetic sign immediately preceding Christ’s return.

The “restrainer” who currently holds back this rebellion will be removed, unleashing a surge of chaos and deception (2 Thessalonians 2:6-7).¹

Identity and Characteristics

The Man of Lawlessness is more than a political or military leader; he is a master spiritual deceiver. Working in league with the False Prophet, he will employ counterfeit miracles and persuasive signs to seduce many (**2 Thessalonians 2:9-10; Revelation 13**).²

Elevating himself above God, he will demand worship and impose a global system of control. While the specifics of the “mark of the beast” are reserved for Volume 2, it is crucial to recognize that his reign will be marked by unprecedented defiance and deception.

The Abomination of Desolation

Jesus’ warning about the “abomination of desolation” (**Matthew 24:15**) directly connects to the Antichrist’s desecration of the temple—an event fulfilling Daniel’s prophecy (**Daniel 9:27; 11:31**)³ and signaling the onset of the great tribulation.

The Reign: Opposition and Control

Through political manipulation, false peace, and miraculous deception, the Antichrist will consolidate power (**Daniel 8:25**).⁴ He will persecute the faithful (**Revelation 13:7**)⁵ and enforce idolatrous worship, drawing people away from the true God. Those who submit to him will face the full weight of God’s wrath (**Revelation 14:9-11**).⁶

The Faithful Remnant

Despite widespread deception and persecution, God will preserve a faithful remnant—those who “*keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus*” (**Revelation 14:12**).⁷ Their endurance through prayer, discernment, and obedience will stand as a testament to God’s sustaining power even amid the darkest times.

Ultimate Defeat

The reign of the Man of Lawlessness will be brief. Christ Himself will bring him to utter destruction:

“The Lord Jesus will kill with the breath of his mouth and bring to nothing by the appearance of his coming.”
— **2 Thessalonians 2:8**⁸

This final victory underscores God’s sovereign control and guarantees the certainty of the Day of the Lord.

Practical Implications for the Church

Awareness of the Man of Lawlessness equips believers to resist deception and remain steadfast in their loyalty to Christ. The intensifying spiritual conflict before the Day of the Lord demands vigilance, discernment, and readiness—not fear, but faithful preparedness.

Chapter Notes

- ¹ **2 Thessalonians 2:3-8** highlights the prophetic importance of the Man of Lawlessness and the restrainer. See Douglas J. Moo, *1 & 2 Thessalonians*, NIVAC, Zondervan, 1994, pp. 115-130.
- ² **Revelation 13** describes the Antichrist’s counterfeit miracles and global influence. See G.K. Beale, *Revelation*, NIGTC, Eerdmans, 1999, pp. 483-500.
- ³ **Matthew 24:15** refers to the “abomination of desolation” prophesied in Daniel. See F.F. Bruce, *The Book of Acts*, Eerdmans, 1988, pp. 194-198.
- ⁴ **Daniel 8:25** discusses the Antichrist’s deceit and power consolidation. See John J. Collins, *Daniel*, Hermeneia, Fortress Press, 1993, pp. 330-335.
- ⁵ **Revelation 13:7** describes persecution of the saints. See Richard Bauckham, *The Theology of the Book of Revelation*, Cambridge University Press, 1993, pp. 150-160.

- ⁶ **Revelation 14:9-11** warns of the consequences of worshiping the beast. See Michael Heiser, *The Unseen Realm*, Lexham Press, 2015, pp. 401-405.
- ⁷ **Revelation 14:12** emphasizes the endurance of the saints. See Walter C. Kaiser Jr., *The Promise-Plan of God*, Zondervan, 2008, pp. 279-287.
- ⁸ **2 Thessalonians 2:8** confirms Christ's ultimate victory. See N.T. Wright, *The Resurrection of the Son of God*, Fortress Press, 2003, pp. 520-530.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the revelation of the Man of Lawlessness shape your view of spiritual vigilance?
2. What role does deception play in the end-times scenario?
3. How should the Church prepare to face opposition from such a figure?
4. How do biblical prophecies about the Man of Lawlessness challenge contemporary views on evil and governance?

THE GREAT TRIBULATION

ENDURANCE THROUGH FIRE: THE TESTING OF THE SAINTS

“...for then there will be great tribulation, such as has not been from the beginning of the world until now, no, and never will be.”

— Matthew 24:21

A Time Like No Other

The Great Tribulation is a unique and unparalleled epoch in God’s prophetic timeline—an intense season of suffering, persecution, and cosmic upheaval. Jesus Himself warned that its severity will be unmatched throughout history and that it serves as a key phase in God’s final judgment.¹

This is a concrete reality foretold by the prophets, apostles, and the Lord Jesus. It will test and refine the faith of the righteous like fire in a furnace.

The Nature of the Tribulation

Scripture reveals the tribulation as multifaceted, marked by:

- **Spiritual Deception:** The Antichrist and false prophets will lead many astray with counterfeit signs and wonders (**Matthew 24:24**).²
- **Global Persecution:** Believers will endure intense opposition, including martyrdom (**Revelation 7:14**).³
- **Natural and Cosmic Disturbances:** Earthquakes, plagues, and celestial signs will disrupt life (**Revelation 6**).⁴
- **Moral Collapse:** Lawlessness will surge as human rebellion reaches its peak (**2 Thessalonians 2:3-4**).⁵

Purpose and Divine Sovereignty

The tribulation is not chaotic or random; it unfolds within God's sovereign redemptive plan. Its purposes include:

- **Judgment:** The righteous wrath of God poured out on sin and rebellion.
- **Refinement:** The purification and strengthening of the faithful's faith.
- **Vindication:** The demonstration of God's justice over the forces of evil.

Even amid this dark period, God remains firmly in control, directing events toward His ultimate purposes.

The Remnant's Endurance

The theme of a faithful "remnant" preserved through the tribulation recurs throughout Scripture (**Isaiah 10:20-22; Revelation 12:17**).⁶

Believers are called to persevere, "overcoming" through steadfast faith and courage (**Revelation 2:10**).⁷ Their endurance serves as a powerful testimony to God's sustaining grace.

Signs That Mark the Tribulation

Certain prophetic signs will precede and mark the onset of this period:

- The revealing of the Antichrist (2 **Thessalonians 2**).
- The “abomination of desolation” in the temple (**Matthew 24:15**).⁸
- Intensified natural disasters and cosmic upheavals (**Joel 2; Revelation 6–8**).⁹

Recognizing these signs equips the Church to remain vigilant and prepared.

Hope Amid the Storm

Though the tribulation promises great trials, believers are not without hope. God promises protection, provision, and ultimate victory for His people (**Psalms 91; Revelation 7:14**).¹⁰

The Day of the Lord culminates in Christ’s triumphant return, transforming suffering into glory and ushering in a new era of peace and righteousness.

Chapter Notes

- ¹ Matthew 24 records Jesus’ Olivet Discourse, detailing the tribulation’s unprecedented severity. See R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew*, NICNT, Eerdmans, 2007, pp. 920-930.
- ² Matthew 24:24 warns of false Christs and prophets performing signs to deceive. See Craig S. Keener, *The Gospel of Matthew: A Socio-Rhetorical Commentary*, Eerdmans, 2009, pp. 456-460.
- ³ Revelation 7:14 identifies those who come out of the great tribulation as the “multitude that no one could count.” See G.K. Beale, *Revelation*, NIGTC, Eerdmans, 1999, pp. 438-442.

- ⁴ The opening of the seven seals in Revelation 6 introduces cosmic and natural disasters as divine judgment. See John Walvoord, *The Revelation of Jesus Christ*, Moody Press, 1966, pp. 105-115.
- ⁵ 2 Thessalonians 2 describes the man of lawlessness and increasing rebellion preceding the Day of the Lord. See Douglas J. Moo, *1 & 2 Thessalonians*, NIVAC, Zondervan, 1994, pp. 115-130.
- ⁶ The faithful remnant theme echoes throughout Scripture, promising preservation and victory. See Walter C. Kaiser Jr., *The Promise-Plan of God*, Zondervan, 2008, pp. 279-287.
- ⁷ The “overcomer” motif in Revelation chapters 2-3 encourages perseverance under persecution. See Richard Bauckham, *The Theology of the Book of Revelation*, Cambridge University Press, 1993, pp. 80-95.
- ⁸ Jesus references the “abomination of desolation” spoken of by Daniel (Daniel 9:27; 11:31). See F.F. Bruce, *The Book of the Acts*, Eerdmans, 1988, pp. 194-198.
- ⁹ Joel 2 and Revelation 6-8 describe cosmic signs signaling the Day of the Lord’s arrival. See John Oswalt, *The Book of Joel*, NICOT, Eerdmans, 2005, pp. 120-130.
- ¹⁰ Psalm 91 promises divine protection; Revelation 7:14 offers hope to those who endure tribulation. See Tremper Longman III, *Psalms*, Baker Academic, 2014, pp. 512-515.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the Great Tribulation shape your understanding of God's justice and mercy?
2. What lessons can believers learn from the endurance of the faithful remnant?
3. How can the Church today prepare spiritually and practically for this time?
4. How do cosmic signs reinforce the reality of the tribulation?

ICHABOD: WHEN GLORY DEPARTED THE TEMPLE

A FORESHADOWING OF THE ABOMINATION
THAT MAKES THE TEMPLE DESOLATE

During the Exodus, God's **glory cloud** (Hebrew *kavod*) led the Israelites out of Egypt, protecting and guiding them through the wilderness to Mount Sinai and ultimately to the Promised Land. But over time, as Israel struggled to settle the land, they gradually drifted into idolatry—worshiping local Canaanite gods.

God's Kavod

The Hebrew word for God's glory is *kavod* or *kabowd* (Strong's H3519, pronounced kah-BOHD). When God's presence is near, *kavod* is tangible and visible—manifested as a cloud by day and fire by night during the Exodus.

The Tabernacle and the Ark of the Covenant

Around 1400 BC, at Sinai, God instructed the Israelites to build the Tabernacle, housing the Ark of the Covenant—the sacred chest containing the Law and God's promises. Two cherubim were fashioned on the Ark's lid, creating the "mercy seat," God's earthly throne.

The Tabernacle was God's meeting place with Moses, allowing divine-human communion without Moses ascending and descending Mount Sinai repeatedly.

A Child Named Ichabod

“And she named the child Ichabod, saying, ‘The glory has departed from Israel!’ because the ark of God had been captured...”

— 1 Samuel 4:21

Circa 1100 BC, during a dark period marked by disobedience, idolatry, and corrupt priesthood, the prophet Samuel arose to lead a transitioning Israel from the Judges to monarchy. At that time, only the portable Tabernacle existed (Solomon's Temple was still 150 years away). The Ark was carefully transported under strict protocols.

The priesthood under Eli had become corrupt—his sons desecrated sacrifices and abused their positions (1 Samuel 2:22). God's judgment was pronounced: both sons would die on the same day, and a faithful priest would replace them (1 Samuel 2:34-35).

In a disastrous battle against the Philistines, the Ark was taken as a superstitious talisman rather than a holy relic. The Philistines won, capturing the Ark. Phinehas's wife went into premature labor and named her child **Ichabod**—“the glory of God has departed from Israel.”

That event marked a pivotal shift: God's tangible presence had left His people. Though the Ark was later returned and the Philistines humbled, Shiloh never recovered and faded from history. And yet to this day, the name “Ichabod” still reminds Israel of the time when God removed Himself from their presence.

Foreshadowing: Greater Tragedies Ahead

The departure of God's glory from the Tabernacle foreshadowed greater events:

- **Solomon's Temple** (c. 950 BC) was built in Jerusalem, inaugurated with the visible presence of God's glory:

8 [10] "And when the priests came out of the Holy Place, a cloud filled the house of the LORD, [11] so that the priests could not stand to minister because of the cloud, for the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD."

— **1 Kings 8:10-11**

But this Temple, too, would be defiled.

Ezekiel's Vision: The Glory in Motion

By Ezekiel's time (c. 590 BC), Judah's leaders had again fallen into idolatry. Ezekiel's haunting vision recorded God's glory gradually departing the Temple (**Ezekiel 10-11**). The cherubim rose from the Ark's mercy seat, the glory moved to the Temple threshold, then out the east gate, and finally ascended to heaven via the Mount of Olives.

God's presence abandoned the Temple sanctuary—returning to heaven in heartbreak.

The First Temple's Desolation

In 586 BC, Nebuchadnezzar executed God's judgment by destroying Solomon's Temple and carrying Judah into exile. The Babylonians looted the Temple's sacred treasures (cf. **Daniel 5:5**, the "writing on the wall" event).

The sin that triggered this was Israel's repeated **idolatry**—rejecting God's commandment to have no other gods (Exodus 20:2-6).

The Second Temple and the Abomination That Made it Desolate

After 70 years in exile, the Israelites returned under Persian decree, led by Zerubbabel and later Nehemiah. The Temple was rebuilt and rededicated around 516 BC.

Approximately 350 years later, Antiochus IV Epiphanes desecrated the Temple by erecting an altar to Zeus and sacrificing a pig—an unclean animal under Mosaic Law—on the altar. This abomination sparked the *Maccabean Revolt* (166–160 BC). The Temple was rededicated in 165 BC, commemorated by *Hanukkah*.

Herod's Expansion and Roman Destruction

Around 20 BC, Herod the Great extensively remodeled the Second Temple.

In AD 70, Roman General Titus destroyed the Temple during Jerusalem's siege. Unlike Antiochus, Titus did not perform a sacrilegious act; Josephus noted that Titus sought to preserve the Temple's grandeur. The destruction was catastrophic but not a ritual desecration, making this event distinct from the “abomination of desolation.”

Daniel's Prophecy and the Future Third Temple

Daniel's vision (~580 BC) looks beyond the Second Temple to a future Third Temple—one yet to be built—where the ultimate “abomination of desolation” will occur:

“Forces from him shall appear and profane the temple and fortress, and shall take away the regular burnt offering. And they shall set up the abomination that makes desolate.” — Daniel 11:31

Jesus and Paul reaffirm this in the New Testament (**Matthew 24:15; 2**

Thessalonians 2). This prophecy points to the Antichrist's desecration of the coming Temple as a key end-times event.

The Third Temple and End-Times Fulfillment

Before Christ's return, a Third Temple will be rebuilt—whether a tent/tabernacle or a magnificent structure—and sanctified by the blood of a perfect red heifer. Daily sacrifices will resume.

The Antichrist's defilement of this sanctuary will fulfill the ultimate warning Ichabod represents: the departure of God's glory and divine presence.

The Crescendo: More Than History, A Prophetic Drama

Each historical temple's defilement foreshadowed increasing spiritual drama. Jesus warned, "Your house is left to you desolate" (**Matthew 23:38**), foretelling judgment and the departure of God's presence. The destruction of the Second Temple mirrored Ezekiel's vision, but Daniel's prophecy points to a far greater final abomination.

The Day of the Lord and the Absence of Glory

The Day of the Lord is marked not only by God's wrath but also by His **withdrawal**:

- He stops defending.
- He stops blessing.
- He stops speaking.
- He removes His presence.

Paul's phrase "*God gave them over*" (**Romans 1**) refers to God lifting His divine restraint—His protective presence and glory withdrawn as a form of judgment. This withdrawal is Ichabod writ large.

God Himself acts as the “restrainer” who will cease restraining evil before Christ returns. That removal of restraint allows Satan a limited period of tribulation (thlipsis).

2 Thessalonians 2:6-12: *“[6] And you know what is restraining him now so that he may be revealed in his time. [7] For the mystery of lawlessness is already at work. Only He who now restrains it will do so until he is out of the way. [8] And then the lawless one will be revealed, whom the Lord Jesus will kill with the breath of His mouth and bring to nothing by the appearance of His coming. [9] The coming of the lawless one is by the activity of Satan with all power and false signs and wonders, [10] and with all wicked deception for those who are perishing, because they refused to love the truth and so be saved. [11] Therefore, God sends them a strong delusion, so that they may believe what is false, [12] in order that all may be condemned who did not believe the truth but had pleasure in unrighteousness.”*

God will permit Satan and his agent, the Antichrist, to persecute and refine God’s people until the predetermined number of believers and martyrs is reached. Then Christ will return, reclaim His Kingdom, and with His heirs restore the world to its original Edenic condition —the Restoration.

God’s Glory Will Return

Ichabod — the departure of God’s glory — is not the final chapter. Ezekiel’s vision (chapter 43) foretells the glory’s triumphant return:

“...the glory of the God of Israel was coming from the east... the glory of the LORD filled the temple.”

— Ezekiel 43:1–5

The faithful destiny is restoration. The glory that once departed in grief will return in triumph.

The Triumphant King Returns

“I saw heaven opened and behold, a white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True... He judges and makes war... He is clothed in a robe dipped in blood, and the name by which He is called is The Word of God.”

— **Revelation 19:11-13**

“And the LORD will be king over all the earth. On that day, the LORD will be one and His name one.”

— **Zechariah 14:9**

Until that day, we live between *Ichabod* and glory, confident that God’s presence will return to dwell with His people forever.



(Timeline Chart of Temples and God’s Glory is on the next page.)

Timeline of Temples and God’s Glory

Date / Era	Event	Significance / Foreshadowing
Circa 1400 BC	Exodus & Tabernacle instituted with Ark of the Covenant	God’s glory (kavod) visibly present; Ark as God’s throne on earth
Circa 1100 BC	Ark captured by Philistines; birth of Ichabod	Glory departs Israel ; spiritual decline, foreshadows judgment
Circa 950 BC	Solomon’s Temple built and dedicated	Glory fills Temple; peak of Israel’s worship and presence
Circa 590 BC	Ezekiel’s vision of glory departing Temple	God’s presence leaves gradually; sign of judgment coming
586 BC	Babylon destroys First Temple	Loss of physical Temple; spiritual exile begins
516 BC	Second Temple rebuilt and dedicated	Partial restoration; God’s presence less visible
167 BC	Antiochus IV desecrates Temple (Abomination of Desolation)	Foreshadows final desecration by Antichrist
20 BC	Herod’s Temple expansion	Prepares for Messiah’s first coming
AD 70	Roman destruction of Second Temple	End of Temple worship; foreshadows future Temple
Future	Third Temple built	Will be desecrated by Antichrist; final “Abomination of Desolation”
Future	Jesus’ return and eternal reign	God’s glory returns; Temple restored in eternal Jerusalem

REFLECT & Discuss

1. What does the name *Ichabod* teach us about the seriousness of God's presence departing from His people?
2. How do the historical temple defilements foreshadow the ultimate end-times abomination described in Daniel and the New Testament?
3. In what ways does Ezekiel's vision of God's glory departing the temple deepen our understanding of divine judgment?
4. How does the concept of "God giving them over" (Romans 1) relate to the withdrawal of God's protective presence in the Day of the Lord?
5. Why is the role of the "restrainer" crucial in understanding the timing of the Man of Lawlessness's revelation?
6. How does the hope of God's glory returning, as foretold by Ezekiel 43, shape the Christian expectation of restoration and renewal?
7. What spiritual lessons can believers draw from living in the tension between Ichabod (departure of glory) and the promise of God's triumphant return?
8. How do the temple destructions and desecrations challenge or confirm your understanding of God's holiness and justice?
9. In light of the prophetic temple timeline, how should the Church today view the significance of a potential future Third Temple?
10. What practical implications does this chapter have for how we understand God's presence in our lives amid trials and judgment?

THE TWO “UNTILS”

THE END-TIMES CLOCKS: FULLNESS, MARTYRS, AND THE FINAL DAY

There is a hidden urgency embedded in prophetic Scripture—an urgency flowing from two divine countdowns, each marked by the word *until*. These two “untils” frame the current age and point toward its inevitable climax. They anchor our eschatology to the sure prophetic expectation that God will fulfill His promises concerning Israel, Jerusalem, and the whole earth.

1. Until the Fullness of the Gentiles

Paul speaks first:

“Lest you be wise in your own sight, I do not want you to be unaware of this mystery, brothers: a partial hardening has come upon Israel, until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in.”

—ROMANS 11:25

This phrase is often misread as referring solely to the Church Age or seen through a dispensational lens as a sudden pivot in God’s focus from the Church back to Israel.

But Paul is explaining a mystery: God has allowed a partial hardening of ethnic Israel during this age so that mercy might extend to the Gentile nations. This hardening is not permanent. It has an expiration date: *until* the fullness of the Gentiles comes in.

The Greek word *plērōma* (fullness) conveys more than a simple count—it signals completion, a divine goal fulfilled.

The nations are being sifted; disciples are being made. The gospel of the kingdom is going out as witness to all nations (Matthew 24:14). When that fullness is reached—when the final one is gathered in—the next stage begins.

Paul continues:

“And in this way all Israel will be saved, as it is written: ‘The Deliverer will come from Zion; He will banish ungodliness from Jacob.’”

—Romans 11:26

The phrase *in this way* points to a sequence. The fullness of the Gentiles is the necessary prelude to Israel’s salvation, which in turn heralds the coming of the Deliverer—Christ Himself.

Christ will not return until the time is right to banish ungodliness from Jacob. The clock’s spring is tightly wound; the fullness is a prerequisite for Christ to take possession of His kingdom.

2. Until the Fullness of the Martyrs

The second *until* comes from the vision of John in Revelation 6:

“They were each given a white robe and told to rest a little longer, until the number of their fellow servants and their brothers should be complete, who were to be killed as they themselves had been.”

—Revelation 6:11

This is judicial language. A fixed number of witnesses must be slain before judgment can fall on the rebellious world.

It reveals God's justice as both patient and precise. Heaven is not waiting for a vague increase in human misery; it is waiting for the final ordained martyr to give faithful witness and seal that testimony in blood.

When that last martyr falls, the delay ends. The Warrior-King rides forth. The righteous are gathered. The bowls of God's (orgé) —His settled, holy wrath—are poured out. And the corrupt kingdoms of this world begin to crumble under the weight of His coming.

3. Daniel's Final Waiting

The prophet Daniel, who was told to seal up his vision until the time of the end, also received a final *until*:

"Blessed is he who waits and arrives at the 1,335 days.

But go your way till the end. And you shall rest and shall stand in your allotted place at the end of the days."

—Daniel 12:12-13

Daniel must wait until a divinely fixed day when he will rise to receive his inheritance. He waits now with all the righteous dead, including the martyrs beneath the altar, in Paradise. Together they await the summons from the King: *"Come up here!"*

On that day, they will rise—not to wait any longer, but to welcome and celebrate the final arrival of King Jesus.

4. The Weight of the Word "Until"

The prophetic *untils* are divine time locks—fixed and unyielding. No

amount of prayer, pleading, or resistance can postpone the moment when God's set time arrives. Those divine numbers (new believers and martyrs) *come in* exactly as decreed.

On that day, the whole world will lift its eyes in awe and terror. The unrighteous will quake, begging the mountains to fall on them, hiding them from the face of the Lord's wrath (**Revelation 6:16**). Meanwhile, the righteous—adorned in glorified, immortal bodies—will erupt in joyous celebration at the appearing of their Savior. This is the climax all creation has been waiting for.

For the unrepentant, this is a solemn warning; the window of grace is about to slam shut forever. To the faithful, it is a cause for rejoicing.

The plan is unfolding toward that perfect fullness. Therefore, stay awake. Watch.

Jesus declared:

"Jerusalem will be trampled underfoot by the Gentiles, until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled."

— **Luke 21:24**

And again:

"You will not see Me again, until you say, 'Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord.'"

— **Matthew 23:39**

Peter confirms:

"Heaven must receive [Jesus] until the time for restoring all the things about which God spoke by the mouth of His holy prophets long ago."

— **Acts 3:21**

Until—that small word carries the heavy weight of prophecy and certainty. When that day comes, the entire world will be filled with the glory of our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does understanding the “fullness of the Gentiles” shape your view of the Church’s mission and God’s timing?
2. What does the “fullness of the martyrs” reveal about God’s justice and the role of suffering in prophecy?
3. How do Daniel’s prophetic “untils” deepen the urgency and hope of awaiting Christ’s return?
4. Why is the word “until” so significant in biblical prophecy, and how does it affect the tension between divine sovereignty and human responsibility?
5. How can believers balance watchfulness and patience while living in the “already” and “not yet” of God’s plan?
6. In what ways does the fulfillment of these “untils” confirm the certainty of God’s promises to Israel and the nations?
7. How do these divine countdowns influence your understanding of the final judgment and the hope of resurrection?

THE SIFTING OF THE NATIONS

JUDGMENT AND MERCY AT THE VALLEY OF DECISION

3 [14] *“Multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision! For the day of the
Lord is near in the valley of decision.”*

— Joel 3:14

As the fury of the Day of the Lord reaches its final crescendo, the smoke of judgment begins to settle. The cities of men lie broken, their towers cast down, their idols shattered.

The haughty have been humbled, the violent have been silenced, and the world will be groaning beneath the weight of long-awaited justice.

But now, a new moment dawns. One marked by separation — *a sifting*. This is not yet the Great White Throne. That awaits at the end of the thousand years. No, this is something else. Something nearer. Earthly. Immediate. The King is coming soon. But before He inaugurates His Kingdom in Zion, He will reckon with the nations.

The Valley of Jehoshaphat

The prophet Joel describes a global summons — a gathering called by the Lord Himself:

3 [1] “For behold, in those days and at that time,
when I restore the fortunes of Judah and Jerusalem,
[2] I will gather all the nations and bring them down to the Valley of
Jehoshaphat. And I will enter into judgment with them there, on behalf of
my people and my heritage, Israel...”

— Joel 3:1-2

The Valley of Jehoshaphat — its name meaning “Yahweh judges,” is more than a location. It is a **moment** — a divine court convened on the very land where the nations once waged war against God’s heirs.

The King sits, surrounded by angelic hosts and righteous saints. He opens this court to judge the nations. This judgment is **not eternal** but **geopolitical** and **moral**. The consequences are felt immediately. This trial determines which people, which leaders, and which countries will be allowed to enter the restored age to come.

The Parable of the Nations: Sheep and Goats

Jesus explained this judgment in Matthew 25, a passage often misunderstood:

25 [31] “When the Son of Man comes in His glory, and all the angels with Him, then He will sit on His glorious throne. [32] Before Him will be gathered all the nations, and He will separate people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats.”

— Matthew 25:31-32

NOTICE CAREFULLY: This is the “Sheep and Goats” judgment scene where Jesus separates *nations* based on how they treated His faithful followers (the “least of these my brothers”). The outcome will

determine which countries will survive the tribulation. It's about earthly nations and their treatment of God's covenant (Israel + Abrahamic born-again Gentiles) people.

Death and Hades are not mentioned, nor are any books being opened. This is the judgment that will determine which **nations** will survive the Day of the Lord's terror.

What is the basis of this separation?

25 [35] *"I was hungry and you gave Me food...
I was a stranger and you welcomed Me...
[40] Truly, I say to you, as you did it to one of the least of these my
brothers, you did it to Me."*
— **Matthew 25:35-40**

Who are "my brothers"? They are:

- The faithful witnesses,
- The Jewish remnant,
- The sealed servants,
- The persecuted prophets, and
- Those who bore the Name of the King during the Great Tribulation.

The **sheep** are those who sheltered, aided, and honored by a national people. The **goats** are those nations that abused, betrayed, hunted, and scorned them.

This is not a judgment that will consider a generic pattern of charitable giving. This is **covenant loyalty**. How a nation treats the Messiah's people will be the metric by which they are sifted.

How the Bema Seat Judgment Differs

Whereas the Sheep and Goats judgment determines the death or survival of nations and takes place at Christ's return, the Bema Seat judgment—also called the Judgment Seat of Christ—is reserved exclusively for believers. It scores one's Christian behavior during their life. The outcome determines rewards, which may include job positions during the Millennial Reign—more on the Bema Seat judgment in the next chapter.

Rahab's Fine Example

Just as in the days of Moses, when Yahweh executed judgment on Egypt, so too will He judge the modern Pharaohs of this age. Yet even in Egypt, judgment was not unbroken destruction. A *mixed multitude* left with Israel at the Exodus — Egyptians who feared the Lord and threw their lot in with His people.

That pattern repeated as Israel journeyed toward the Promised Land. Along the way, individuals from other nations either joined them or aided them. Rahab of Jericho stands out. According to Joshua 2, she was a Canaanite innkeeper — and possibly a prostitute — who risked her life to hide two Israelite spies. When Jericho's soldiers came searching, she lied to protect them, then helped them escape.

Her act is a model for how God weighs allegiance:

- **Nationally**, the Sheep and Goats judgment will measure how people and governments treated the King's covenant family.
- **Individually**, the Bema Seat will evaluate how each believer acted in faith toward His purposes.

Rahab's deliverance, along with that of her entire household, was the direct fruit of her siding with God's messengers. Her faith turned the course of her life, placing her in the genealogy of Jesus (**Matthew 1:5**),

earning her a place in Hebrews 11's "Hall of Faith," and making her a prime example in James 2:25 of works proving faith.

Rahab is the prototype of the righteous Gentile — a sheep among goats. In our day, multitudes will face the same choice: align with the apple of God's eye, Jerusalem, or side with its enemies. In the coming sifting, those who side with the King's people will find their works remembered — either unto survival in the nations or as reward in His Kingdom, just as Rahab did.

Isaiah speaks of a future time — after vengeance has come, after the eyes of the blind are opened and the ransomed return with singing — when a great Highway shall emerge, stretching across former enemies and leading to Zion itself.

"In that day, there will be a highway from Egypt to Assyria, and Assyria will come into Egypt, and Egypt into Assyria, and the Egyptians will worship with the Assyrians. In that day, Israel will be the third with Egypt and Assyria, a blessing in the midst of the earth, whom the LORD of hosts has blessed, saying, 'Blessed be Egypt my people, and Assyria the work of my hands, and Israel my inheritance.'"

— Isaiah 19:23-25

And this road will not be like any road of man's making:

"...it shall be called the Way of Holiness; the unclean shall not pass over it... but the redeemed shall walk there."

— Isaiah 35:8

The sifting of the nations clears the path for this very thing — a world reordered, where those who fear the Lord will be gathered and preserved, and the rebellious cut off.

Toward a New Order

The earth will not be empty. The Kingdom will not be unpopulated. After the sifting, a remnant of humanity—the survivors of the nations—will remain, falling under the rule of the resurrected King and His glorified saints. Isaiah prophesied this time:

*2 [2] “It shall come to pass in the latter days
that the mountain of the house of the Lord
shall be established as the highest of the mountains...
and all the nations shall flow to it.”*

— Isaiah 2:2

But only the sifted may enter. The sheep, not the goats. The Rahabs, not the Pharaohs.

This judgment — before the Kingdom — is **the reset**. Not technological. Not political. It is **moral**. And it lays the foundation for the age of the Messiah’s reign.

A Word to the Watchman

This sifting is the hope held out to the Gentiles, even amid wrath. It reminds us that the gospel is not merely a pass to keep us out of Hades, but a call to align with the purposes of the King.

- To protect His people is to honor Him.
- To bless His name-bearers is to bless Him.
- To oppose His inheritance is to provoke His fury.

As watchmen, we must warn the nations:

The King is coming. He will sift and separate. He will judge. He will oversee training, assignments, and rewards. He will rule.

Key Scriptures:

- Joel 3:1-2, 14
- Matthew 25:31-46
- Isaiah 35
- Isaiah 2:2



REFLECT & Discuss

1. What does the sifting of the nations reveal about God's justice and mercy?
2. How does the sheep and goats judgment help you interpret current events and align your actions?
3. What role does covenant loyalty play in the way we treat God's people today?
4. Who are the "Rahabs" in your world? How can you respond like one of the sheep?
5. What practical steps can you take to prepare for the King's arrival?

THE BEMA SEAT JUDGMENT

REWARDS AND ROLES IN GOD'S KINGDOM

The Meanings of the Different Judgments

I may have confused you. I agree, there are many different “judgments” and it’s easy to misinterpret what they are or what they mean. Before proceeding on to the Bema Seat judgment, here’s an outline of different judgments for you to review:

I. Judgment at Death (Particular Judgment)

Timing: Immediately upon physical death.

Purpose: An *Individual* judgment that determines the immediate destination of the soul and spirit.

- **Righteous:** Sent to Sheol’s Paradise (comfort, healing, preparation)
- **Unrighteous:** Sent to Sheol’s Hades (torment)

Scriptural References:

- **Hebrews 9:27** — “*And just as it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment,*”
- **Luke 23:43** — Jesus tells the thief, “*Today you will be with me in Paradise.*”
- **Luke 16:19-31** — Parable of the Rich Man and Lazarus (Paradise and Hades)
- **Philippians 1:23** — Paul’s desire to depart and be with Christ
- **Revelation 6:9-11** — Souls under the altar awaiting judgment

2. Bema Seat Judgment (Believers’ Reward Judgment)

Timing: Before the *resurrection* of righteous believers; it seems to take place in Sheol’s Paradise. This has nothing to do with salvation; it is a review of what each righteous individual accomplished with the gifts and talents given them during mortal life.

Purpose: An *Individual* judgment that evaluates each believer’s works to determine rewards, roles, and eternal assignments:

- Faithfulness, obedience, and stewardship are rewarded
- Determines authority and honor in the Millennial Kingdom and beyond.

Scriptural References:

- **2 Corinthians 5:10** — “*For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ...*”
- **1 Corinthians 3:12-15** — Testing each one’s work by fire for reward
- **Romans 14:10-12** — Standing before the judgment seat of God
- **Luke 19:11-27** — Parable of the Minas
- **Matthew 25:14-30** — Parable of the Talents
- **James 2:14-26** — Faith demonstrated by works

3. Sheep and Goats Judgment (Nations' Judgment)

Timing: Before the Millennial Kingdom is established

Purpose: A *National* judgment assessing the treatment of God's people.

- Separates *nations* as “sheep” (faithful) and “goats” (unfaithful)
- Determines blessing or judgment at the Kingdom's start

Scriptural References:

- **Matthew 25:31-46** — The Sheep and the Goats
- **Joel 3:1-2, 14** — Judgment of the nations
- **Isaiah 2:2-4** — Nations flowing to the mountain of the Lord
- **Zechariah 14:16-19** — Nations required to worship the King

4. White Throne Judgment (Final Judgment of the Dead)

Timing: After the Millennium, at the end of earthly history

Purpose: Judgment of all unrighteous dead, final condemnation

Scriptural References:

- **Revelation 20:11-15** — The Great White Throne Judgment
- **Daniel 12:2** — Many who sleep in the dust awake, some to shame and everlasting contempt
- **John 5:28-29** — Resurrection to judgment
- **Matthew 13:49-50** — Sorting of the wicked at the end of the age

Judgment at Death and Location in Sheol

The first judgment occurs upon death. You are either found righteous or unrighteous. If you are judged righteous, your interim term will be spent in Sheol's Paradise. From Paradise, you will be resurrected back to the surface of the earth in a new, immortal, glorified body—and you will spend eternity with God.

But if you are judged unrighteous, you are already eternally condemned. Your interim term will be spent in Sheol's Hades—in torment. Then, at the end of the Millennium, you will be resurrected to be tried at the White Throne judgment and then cast into the lake of fire.

For the sake of this lesson, let's assume you are judged righteous. Sheol's Paradise will be your next residence—a place of comfort and preparation.

The Bema Seat Judgment

The next step is the Bema Seat judgment—where your mortal life will be qualitatively evaluated to determine what rewards you deserve and what job you are qualified to perform for the remainder of your eternal afterlife.

The Bema Seat judgment is about individual reward, not punishment. Those judged here are already saved and declared righteous. It has nothing to do with salvation—your salvation was secured long ago.

The word *bēma* in Greek means a raised platform where rulers and judges sit to assess and reward performance. This concept recalls two parables about faithfulness and stewardship:

- **Luke 19:11-27** — The Parable of the Minas (Great Commission new believers). *“Well done, good servant!”*

Because you have been faithful in a very little, you shall have authority over ten cities.”

- **Matthew 25:14-30** — The Parable of the Talents (Numbers of new believers, or possibly money?). “Well done, good and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a little; I will set you over much. Enter into the joy of your master.”

Several New Testament passages describe the Bema Seat judgment:

- **1 Corinthians 3:13-15** — *“Each one’s work will become manifest, for the Day will disclose it... If the work...has built on the foundation and survives, he will receive a reward. If anyone’s work is burned up, he will suffer loss, though he will be saved, but only as through fire.”*
- **2 Corinthians 5:10** — *“For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive what is due for what he has done in the body, whether good or evil.”*
- **Romans 14:10-11** — *“...we will all stand before the judgment seat of God; [11] for it is written, ‘As I live, says the Lord, every knee shall bow to me, and every tongue shall confess to God.’”*

The Bema Seat judgment evaluates the works believers performed during their mortal lives—their faithfulness, obedience, stewardship, and service done “in the body.” However, the actual judgment and awarding of rewards appear to take place while the believer’s soul is in Sheol’s Paradise, the place of rest and preparation after death but before resurrection.

Thus, although the deeds being judged occurred during earthly life, the assessment itself happens during the interim period, ensuring each believer receives their eternal reward and assignment before being resurrected in a glorified body.

This judgment is an evaluation of believers’ works. Several verses in James pertain to this:

"So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead."

— James 2:17

James emphasizes that works are the evidence of living faith (**James 2:18**) and points to examples like Abraham and Rahab, whose faith was proven genuine by their deeds (**James 2:21-25**).

The Bema Seat judgment is about rewarding individual believers, while the Sheep and Goats judgment separates nations based on their moral treatment of God's people.

Rewards at the Bema may include positions of authority, responsibility, honor, and blessing in the Millennial Kingdom—and beyond.

In summary, the Bema Seat judgment is an *individual* believer's reward assessment that takes place between death and the resurrection. It calls believers to perseverance and holiness— not complacency.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. **What does it mean to be judged “in the body” at the Bema Seat?** How does knowing your earthly deeds will be evaluated affect the way you live today?
2. **Why is it important to distinguish between salvation and reward in the context of judgment?** How does this distinction impact our understanding of grace and works?
3. **James emphasizes that faith without works is dead.** How do your works demonstrate the reality of your faith? Can faith be genuine without works?
4. **What kinds of “works” or stewardship might the Bible be referring to that will be rewarded at the Bema Seat?** How should this influence your daily priorities and service in God’s kingdom?
5. **How do you understand the interim state in Sheol’s Paradise?** What significance does this hold for the believer awaiting resurrection?
6. **Compare the Bema Seat judgment with the Sheep and Goats judgment.** Why do you think God separates judgments for individuals versus nations?
7. **What motivates you to pursue holiness and faithful stewardship in light of the Bema Seat judgment?** How can this hope guard against complacency in your spiritual life?
8. **How does the concept of rewards in the Millennial Kingdom shape your vision of eternity?** What roles or responsibilities might you hope to receive, and why?

REFINED AND RENEWED

FIRE'S DUAL ROLE IN JUDGMENT AND RESTORATION

“The heavens will be set on fire and dissolved, and the heavenly bodies will melt as they burn!”

—2 Peter 3:12b

For the unrighteous, the Day of the Lord is violent, cosmic, and final. Scripture does not shy away from this reality. Fire, smoke, trembling heavens—these are not exaggerations; they are previews of divine judgment.

By this point in the prophetic sequence, Christ has returned and His judgment has begun. The wheat is gathered. The chaff is burning (Matthew 3:12).

This chapter and the next unfold a double image of fire: the fire that tests, and the fire that consumes.

The Fire That Tests: Divine Purification

Fire is God's chosen instrument of both judgment and refinement. Peter contrasts the judgment by water in Noah's day with the fire reserved for the end (2 Peter 3:7). This fire is not merely symbolic—it is real. It tests the quality of every work (1 Corinthians 3:13).

- The fire does not consult our theology.
- It does not honor denominational institutions.
- It burns away the facade and reveals the core.

Isaiah 4, Zechariah 13, and Malachi 3 all speak of a faithful remnant purified through fire. This fire distinguishes, not just destroys. It reveals who truly belongs to the Lord.

“And I will put this third into the fire, and refine them as one refines silver, and test them as gold is tested. They will call upon my name, and I will answer them.”

—Zechariah 13:9

This refining process is not punitive; it is preparatory. It transforms survivors into worshipers, creating a people ready for glory.

The Fire That Consumes: Cosmic Deconstruction

The judgment extends beyond earth. Peter says the very heavens will be “set on fire and dissolved.” The Greek verb *luō* means to be loosed, dismantled, broken apart. **Isaiah 34:4** and **Matthew 24:29** echo this theme of cosmic unraveling.

This is not symbolic — it is actual **cosmic deconstruction**. Every rebellious structure—visible or invisible—will be dismantled. Even the spiritual powers in heavenly places will be shaken.

And yet, there is hope:

“But according to His promise, we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells.”

—2 Peter 3:13

The fire is preparatory. It clears the old to make room for the new. Only after the burning can the New Jerusalem descend.

The Lord as Shelter After the Fire

Isaiah 4:5-6 paints a post-judgment world where God Himself becomes the covering for His people. The fire that once threatened now surrounds them in glory. Like in the Exodus, the pillar of fire becomes a canopy of protection.

“Then once more you shall see the distinction between the righteous and the wicked, between one who serves God and one who does not serve him.”

—Malachi 3:18

This distinction is not drawn by men but by God. In the fire: The wicked are consumed. The righteous are refined.

In this mystery, we see the true nature of divine judgment: not all will be destroyed, but what remains will be transformed. This is The Restoration. The fire falls—and holiness rises.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the certainty of the first resurrection reshape your personal view of death and loss?
2. Why is it important to distinguish between the first resurrection of the righteous and the later resurrection of the unrighteous? What does this say about God's justice and mercy?
3. How does the biblical teaching that the dead do not ascend to heaven immediately affect your understanding of the intermediate state and hope for eternal life?
4. In what ways should the promise of glorified, immortal bodies motivate believers toward holiness and perseverance today?
5. How might the hope of reigning with Christ during the Millennial Kingdom influence the Church's witness and mission in the present age?

VICTORY OVER DEATH

ETERNAL LIFE AND GLORIFICATION

“Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection! Over such the second death has no power...”

— Revelation 20:6

Resurrection: The Central Hope of the Day of the Lord

The biblical narrative centers on resurrection as the ultimate victory over death. The Day of the Lord culminates in the resurrection of the righteous—those who have placed their faith in Christ—receiving immortal, glorified bodies.

This resurrection is not merely a return to mortal life but a transformation into eternal life, free from decay, pain, and death.

The Intermediate State

Contrary to popular belief, Scripture teaches that the dead do not ever ascend to heaven. Instead, the righteous rest in **Paradise**, the blessed side of Sheol (**Luke 16:22; 23:43**), awaiting the resurrection and glorification of their bodies.

In resurrection, the image of God is restored and perfected in the saints, as they bear the likeness of the Last Adam.

The First Resurrection Defined

Revelation 20:4-6 describes the “first resurrection,” which is only for the righteous. The “second resurrection” is distinct and solely for the unrighteous.

The first resurrection was Christ’s resurrection. As heirs, the righteous are, by extension, participants in “the first resurrection.” That resurrection by extension of the righteous humans will take place at Christ’s return — on the Day of the Lord. The dead in Christ are resurrected back to the surface of the earth. And the alive in Christ are “changed.” And together the righteous humans rise to meet (Greek, *apantesis*) Christ in the air as He is descending to the earth. The righteous are gathered (Greek, *episunagógē*) to Him. And, as foreshadowed on the original Palm Sunday, they will return to the surface of the earth *with* Christ, where we will “be forever *with* Him” — reigning *with* Him during the Millennial Kingdom.

This event marks the beginning of eternal life for believers and the defeat of death’s power.

The Dead Do Not Ascend to Heaven at Death

Contrary to popular belief, Scripture teaches that all the dead descend to Sheol (or Hades), the realm of the dead. The righteous await their resurrection in Paradise. The unrighteous await the “second resurrection” at the Great White Throne judgment, where they will be tossed into the lake of fire. No one “ascends” to heaven upon death (John 3:13; Ecclesiastes 9:5).

Jesus Himself descended to Sheol’s Paradise, the resting place of the righteous dead, before His resurrection and later, His ascension.

The Transformation of the Righteous

At the resurrection, the bodies of the righteous are transformed to be like Christ's glorious body (**Philippians 3:20-21**).

This glorification enables believers to reign with Christ on earth, fulfilling God's original design for humanity and creation.

The Unrighteous Resurrection and Final Judgment

Following the Millennial reign, the unrighteous dead will be raised to stand before the Great White Throne for final judgment (**Revelation 20:11-15**). This resurrection leads to eternal separation from God.

The contrast between these resurrections highlights God's justice and mercy.

Theological Implications and Pastoral Hope

Resurrection teaches believers to live in hope and readiness. It reassures that death is not defeat but a passage to a promised eternal future.

It calls the Church to faithfulness and perseverance amid trials, knowing that a glorious transformation awaits.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the doctrine of resurrection affect your understanding of death and eternal life?
2. Why is the distinction between the first resurrection and the general resurrection important?
3. What implications does the biblical view of Sheol have for Christian hope?
4. How should the promise of glorification influence the Church's life and mission today?

HEAVEN ON EARTH

THE RENEWED CREATION AND THE CITY OF GOD

“The Lord will reign forever, your God, O Zion, to all generations. Praise the Lord!”

— Psalm 146:10

Zion Restored: The Center of God’s Kingdom

Throughout Scripture, Zion—the city of God—is the focus of His redemptive plan. After the Day of the Lord’s judgment and renewal, Jerusalem will emerge as the eternal capital of the Messianic Kingdom (Isaiah 2:2-4; Zechariah 14:9). Earthquakes and cosmic signs prepare the city both physically and spiritually for this glorious restoration.

- **Jeremiah 31:31-34** — New Covenant promises linked to restoration

The Earth Made New

The prophetic vision culminates in a renewed creation where death, sorrow, and pain are no more (**Revelation 21:1-4**). The earth and sky

are transformed, leveled, and purified—ready to become the eternal home of God’s people.

- **Isaiah 65:17-25** — on the new heavens and new earth, peace, and longevity

The Reign of Christ

Jesus Christ reigns visibly and gloriously from Jerusalem, fulfilling the promises made to David and the prophets (**2 Samuel 7:16; Revelation 22:3-5**). His reign is characterized by peace, justice, and worship centered on God’s presence.

The Nations Drawn to Worship

A key theme in prophetic literature is the gathering of all nations to worship the Lord in Zion (**Isaiah 2:2-4; Zechariah 14:16-19**). This worldwide acknowledgment of God’s sovereignty signals the full realization of His kingdom.

The People Made Ready

Only those who have endured the Day of the Lord’s refining fire and remained faithful will enter into this eternal kingdom (**Zephaniah 3:12-13**). The righteous saints will receive glorified bodies and eternal inheritance.

The Final Triumph

The restoration of Zion represents the consummation of God’s plan—new heavens and a new earth where God dwells with His people forever, and righteousness reigns unchallenged.

- **Revelation 21:22-27** — describing New Jerusalem without a temple, radiant with God’s glory.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does living with the hope of Zion's restoration shape your daily decisions and priorities?
2. How does the vision of Zion's restoration influence your hope for the future?
3. In what ways does the Millennial Kingdom fulfill Old Testament promises?
4. What does it mean for the nations to worship God in Jerusalem? (Hint: Egypt-Assyria-Israel)
5. How can believers live in light of the coming eternal kingdom today?

THE MESSIANIC WEDDING

FROM SINAI TO ZION - ALL ISRAEL IS SAVED

“You have played the harlot with many lovers; yet return to me, says the Lord.”

— **Jeremiah 3:1**

The Divine Betrothal: Covenant at Sinai

At Mount Sinai, God established a covenant with Israel that was nothing less than a divine betrothal — a solemn pledge to be Israel’s Husband and King, and for Israel to be His faithful Bride (**Exodus 19; Hosea 2:16-20**). This covenant marked Israel as God’s treasured possession, set apart for His glory and blessing. Yet immediately following this sacred event, Israel’s faith faltered.

Moses ascended the mountain several times, with his final stay lasting forty days and nights as he received God’s law. During his absence, fear and deception gripped Israel. They believed Moses was dead and that God—who had just delivered them from Pharaoh’s grip—had abandoned them. Panic overwhelmed the people; like lost sheep, they desperately sought a shepherd.

Driven by terror, they demanded Aaron fashion a tangible god — a golden calf. They worshiped this idol and pleaded for deliverance (**Exodus 32**). This act of idolatry was a catastrophic breach of trust in their Bridegroom — God Himself.

Fear, Idolatry, and the Breach of Covenant

This breach was not an isolated slip but set a pattern throughout Israel's history. Their idolatry sprang from fear and desperation, a refusal to trust the invisible God in favor of visible idols.

Repeated episodes of covenant unfaithfulness — Baal worship, golden calves, and others — were Israel turning toward “many lovers” (**Jeremiah 3:1**), failing to remain faithful to the Bridegroom.

The Ten Commandments constituted the betrothal contract. Israel's sin at Sinai directly violated God's First Commandment (**Exodus 20:2-5**). Despite God's steadfast love and the Mosaic Covenant, the severity of their sin necessitated consequences. God imposed a spiritual blindness upon Israel: a veil that would prevent them from recognizing the Messiah when He came.

The Two Prophetic Realities: Israel's Hardening and Universal Restoration

Paul's teaching in **Romans 11** clarifies two distinct but connected prophetic realities:

I. Israel's Partial Hardening (Romans 11:7-8, 25):

God allowed a *partial hardening*—a spiritual blindness—on Israel, described as “a spirit of stupor, eyes that would not see and ears that would not hear.” This hardening endures *until the fullness of the Gentiles has come in*. It is a temporary and purposeful suspension designed to expand God's redemptive work to the nations.

2. All Israel Will Be Saved (Romans 11:26):

Following this period, Paul promises a reversal: “*All Israel will be saved... when I (King Jesus) take away their sins.*” This is the future restoration of Israel, their repentance and acceptance of the Messiah, marking the consummation of the Messianic marriage covenant.

The Veil Over All Peoples: Isaiah 25’s Prophecy

Isaiah 25:7-8 extends the hope beyond Israel, forecasting God’s final victory over sin and death for all humanity:

“He will swallow up death forever; and the Lord God will wipe away tears from all faces... He will swallow up on this mountain the covering that is cast over all peoples, the veil that is spread over all nations.”

Here, two veils are distinguished:

- The veil over **Israel** is the spiritual blindness described by Paul, to be removed when Israel is saved.
- The veil over **the nations** represents the universal bondage to sin and death, to be fully lifted in the ultimate eschatological renewal.

Spiritual Blindness: From Sinai to Zion

Further, Paul ties this blindness to the timing of all Israel’s salvation:

“All Israel will be saved...” — Romans 11:25-27

This connection links the marriage at Sinai to its consummation on Mount Zion — the wedding supper celebrated on earth.

(Continued on the next page.)

Spiritual Blindness and Restoration: From Sinai to Zion

Event / Period	Description	Key Scripture References
Covenant Established at Sinai	God's betrothal covenant with Israel; Israel's immediate breach by idolatry (golden calf).	Exodus 19-32; Hosea 2:16-20
Spiritual Blindness Began	God imposed a partial blindness due to Israel's breach; they failed to recognize the Messiah.	Deuteronomy 29:4; Isaiah 29:10
Prophetic Era	Prophets warned Israel; spiritual blindness persisted despite God's "whispers."	Isaiah 29; Jeremiah 3; Hosea
New Testament Era	Paul explains ongoing partial hardening on Israel "until the fullness of the Gentiles."	Romans 11:7-8, 25-26
Messianic Consummation	The hardening will be lifted; "all Israel will be saved" as the Messiah returns.	Romans 11:26; Isaiah 25:7-9; Joel 2:28-32
Universal Restoration	God removes the veil over all peoples, conquering death and ushering in the eternal kingdom.	Isaiah 25:7-8; Revelation 21

Summary

The breach at Sinai launched a prolonged saga of covenant unfaithfulness, sealed by divine judgment manifesting as spiritual blindness. This blindness is neither total nor permanent. It will be lifted when the Bridegroom returns to Zion, the covenant is consummated, and the wedding feast begins — not in heaven, but in Jerusalem, “on that day” (**Isaiah 25:9**). That day will bring refining judgment and joyous celebration.

The Day of the Lord: Judgment Rooted in Covenant Faithlessness

The Day of the Lord — a day of judgment, refining, and restoration — responds to Israel's covenant breach, especially idolatry. God's purging is necessary before the marriage consummation.

This Day is not arbitrary wrath but holy justice, a divine call to repentance and renewal. God's original covenant vow — His "I do thee wed" at Sinai — becomes conditional: "If you return to Me, I will restore you" (**Deuteronomy 30:1-6**).

The prolonged betrothal endures until Israel returns, repents, and embraces the Messiah as Bridegroom (**Isaiah 25:6-9; Joel 2:28-32; Romans 11:25-26**).

Romans 11 and the Promise of "All Israel" Saved

Paul's declaration that "all Israel will be saved" (**Romans 11:25-26**) is key to understanding the consummation's timing.

The marriage remains incomplete until the elect remnant of Israel embraces Christ. This consummation is not a spiritual event detached from history but a real, earthly fulfillment in renewed Jerusalem — the Bride's rightful home.

Jerusalem: The Place of Consummation and Celebration

Isaiah 25:6-9 depicts a glorious feast on "that day" — the Day of the Lord — where God will "swallow up death forever" and wipe away tears. This is the prophetic wedding banquet that completes the Sinai covenant.

The feast occurs on Mount Zion, in Jerusalem — the city of God's presence (**Isaiah 2:2-4; Zechariah 14:9**). This visible, historical event ushers in the eternal kingdom.

The Theological and Pastoral Implications

Israel's prolonged betrothal, marked by fear-driven idolatry, warns of the dangers of failing to trust God.

- Faithfulness demands trust, even when God seems silent or delayed.
- Covenant unfaithfulness carries serious consequences, including idolatry in many forms.
- Despite human failure, God's faithfulness endures; His ultimate plan is restoration and consummation.

Viewed rightly, the Messianic marriage is one chapter in the Bible's grand love story.

The Bible: God's Unfolding Love Story

Those with eyes to see and ears to hear recognize the Bible as precisely that — a continuous love story. Despite rough patches, it unfolds exactly as God intended.

“And All Israel Will Be Saved” — The New Age Dawning

This love story calls us to hope, watchfulness, and trust. “On that day,” all Israel will be saved. The Bride will shine radiant, and the wedding feast will be celebrated. This is the inauguration of a new age. Let the Millennial Kingdom roar!



REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does Israel's prolonged betrothal and idolatry deepen your understanding of the Day of the Lord?
2. In what ways does fear challenge your trust in God today?
3. What idols might you need to renounce to live fully faithful to God's covenant?
4. How does knowing the consummation will be on earth, in Jerusalem, affect your view of biblical prophecy?
5. How can this chapter's message inspire hope and perseverance in the Church today?

THE MILLENNIAL REIGN OF CHRIST RIGHTEOUSNESS AND RENEWAL ON EARTH

“They came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.”

—Revelation 20:4

The Millennial Kingdom is the 1,000-year reign of Christ on earth, following His visible return and the resurrection of the righteous. This period fulfills many Old Testament prophecies about the restoration of Israel, the renewal of creation, and universal peace under the Messiah’s rule.

Biblical Foundations of the Millennium

Revelation 20:1-6 provides the clearest description, depicting Satan bound for a thousand years while Christ and His resurrected saints reign. These saints are those who participated in the First Resurrection—the martyrs, the faithful, and those who refused to worship the Beast or receive his mark. Their resurrection is one of glory, power, and immortality.

Characteristics of the Millennial Kingdom

- **Satan Bound:** Before the thousand years begin, Satan is sealed in the Abyss, unable to deceive the nations. This is not symbolic restraint—it is total removal of his influence.
- **Righteous Reign:** Christ rules with His glorified saints, who exercise authority and judgment (**Revelation 5:10**).
- **Peace and Prosperity:** Weapons are repurposed into tools for cultivation; wars cease; nature is restored (**Isaiah 11:6-9**).
- **Restoration of Israel:** The twelve tribes are reunited, temple worship is reestablished, and covenant promises are fulfilled (**Ezekiel 40-48**).

A Time of Peace and Justice

The glorified saints administer justice and teach righteousness. Nations walk in the light of Christ's rule. The earth experiences peace, healing, and the fulfillment of long-awaited promises to Israel and all the redeemed.

The Role of the Saints in the Kingdom

Believers who have shared in the First Resurrection reign with Christ as priests and judges, fulfilling the biblical vision of humanity as co-regents under God's sovereign rule.

Final Rebellion and Judgment

At the end of the millennium, Satan is released briefly to test the nations one last time. This results in a final rebellion, swiftly crushed by God. It is followed by the Great White Throne Judgment and the ushering in of the New Heaven and New Earth.

Closing: The Reign Complete

The thousand years draw to their appointed close with a final test:

Satan, loosed from his prison, goes forth once more to deceive the nations.

In a moment, the age-old rebellion rears its head, proving that even in a world ruled by perfect justice, those whose hearts remain unrepentant will turn against the King of Righteousness at the first opportunity.

Their gathering against “the camp of the saints and the beloved city” is met with a swift and decisive conclusion. Fire falls from heaven, consuming Satan’s armies instantly. There is no second Armageddon or protracted battle—King Jesus wins before a single shot is fired. The Word of the Lord alone executes His will perfectly.

Then comes the end of the deceiver himself—Satan, the ancient serpent who has opposed God from the beginning. He is cast into the lake of fire and sulfur, joining the beast and the false prophet. His rebellion is over—forever.

NOTE: The righteous—those who have shared in the First Resurrection—do not stand for judgment again. Their salvation is secured by faith, their names remain in the Book of Life, and they continue to reign with Christ eternally.

Only the unrighteous—those who rejected God throughout history—face the next and final judgment: the Great White Throne.

It is to that breathtaking renewal we now turn our attention.

(Table: End-Times Sequence is on the next page.)



Table: End-Times Sequence: From the Millennium to the New Creation

Phase	Description	Scriptural References
1. Millennial Kingdom	Satan is bound for 1,000 years. Christ reigns visibly on a restored earth with glorified saints as co-regents. Conditions mirror Eden—peace, justice, and healing prevail.	Revelation 20:1-6; Isaiah 11; Ezekiel 40-48
2. Satan's Release	After the 1,000 years, Satan is released briefly to deceive the nations once again.	Revelation 20:7-8
3. Final Rebellion & Defeat	Satan gathers the nations for a last rebellion against God's people. God swiftly destroys the rebels with fire from heaven—no prolonged battle.	Revelation 20:9
4. Judgment of the Rebellious	Those killed in the rebellion join the rest of the dead. They face final judgment along with all unrighteous at the Great White Throne.	Revelation 20:11-13
5. Great White Throne Judgment	The unrighteous dead stand before God for judgment. Books are opened. Names not in the Book of Life face the second death.	Revelation 20:11-15
6. The Lake of Fire (Second Death)	Eternal separation from God culminates in annihilation—complete extinction without remainder or memory.	Revelation 20:14-15
7. New Heaven and New Earth	God creates a new, perfect creation, free from sin, death, and suffering. The former order passes away.	Revelation 21:1-4
8. The New Jerusalem	The Holy City descends as the eternal dwelling place of God and His people. God's presence is fully manifested, and eternal fellowship begins.	Revelation 21:2-7

REFLECT & Discuss

1. How does the certainty of Christ's Millennial reign shape your view of God's justice and mercy?
2. What does reigning with Christ as priests and judges mean practically for believers?
3. Why do you think God allows Satan's brief release after such a long period of restraint?
4. In what ways should the Millennial Kingdom inspire the Church's mission and hope today?
5. How do Millennial prophecies help believers persevere amid present trials and global unrest?

GOG AND MAGOG

SATAN'S FINAL ATTEMPT

“Then I saw a great white throne and him who was seated on it. From His presence, earth and sky fled away, and no place was found for them.”

— Revelation 20:11

1. The Bema Seat and the First Resurrection

The conclusion of the present age opens with the **Bema Seat** of Christ, where the righteous are assessed and rewarded. This is the culmination of the *First Resurrection*, when the saints are given glorified, immortal bodies and commendations according to their faithfulness.¹

Jesus' authority as Judge and King is manifest: the Church, now fully resurrected, serves as His co-heirs in preparation for the final phases of cosmic restoration. The Bema Seat is not merely ceremonial; it is a literal, eternal assignment of roles in the governance of the renewed world.²

2. The Sojourn: From Egypt to the Mount of Olives

Following the resurrection, Christ journeys from **Egypt** to the **Mount of Olives**, a pilgrimage of judgment and cleansing. His path is marked by the execution of divine justice—the "sword from His mouth"—symbolizing His unerring word that vanquishes unrighteousness instantly.³

This is not a drawn-out battle. The imagery emphasizes precision, authority, and inevitability. All opposition is neutralized as the saints witness the establishment of God's righteous order on earth.⁴

3. Establishment of Government and Justice

With the mop-up complete, Christ establishes His divine court and governance. Righteous leaders are seated in judgment, order is restored, and the moral framework of the kingdom is fully operational.⁵

This is a period of consolidation: the world begins to conform to God's virtues—love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. The earth is prepared for the thousand-year reign, which will see peace, prosperity, and perfect order.⁶

4. The Millennium: Reign of Christ

The thousand-year reign is characterized by righteous governance, flourishing creation, and the absence of the curse.⁷ Jerusalem shines as the center of God's kingdom, and the saints, glorified and immortal, co-reign with Christ.⁸

During this period, Satan remains imprisoned, unable to influence the nations. The righteous exercise their authority under Christ's guidance, demonstrating God's plan for the harmonious functioning of heaven and earth.⁹

5. The End of the Millennium: Satan's Release

After the Millennium, Satan is released for a final rebellion (**Revelation 20:7**). He deceives the nations—symbolically called Gog and Magog—representing all unredeemed peoples of the earth. Historically, these correspond to Assyria, Babylon, and Egypt, yet the designation encompasses all who resist God’s moral and spiritual order.¹⁰

The target of this rebellion is precise: Mount Zion, the restored Temple Mount, the Mount of Assembly. The assault is not a conventional battlefield but an audacious attempt to seize Christ’s throne and challenge the authority of the righteous.¹¹

6. Gog and Magog: Satan’s Final Folly

Time and again, God allows Satan to demonstrate his will, and time and again, he fails. This last rebellion ends instantly: fire descends from heaven, consuming the armies of Gog and Magog (**Revelation 20:9**). The event is both divine justice and cosmic irony, illustrating God’s ultimate control over history and rebellion.¹²

The narrative underscores the exercise of free will. Every creature, angelic or human, is granted the opportunity to choose righteousness or wickedness. Yet God ensures that the outcome glorifies His sovereignty.¹³

7. Key Distinctions

This post-Millennial rebellion is **not** the Battle for Jerusalem during the Tribulation, nor is it the so-called “Battle of Armageddon.”

Har Magedōn (**Revelation 16:16**) means “Mount of Assembly”, pointing to Jerusalem, not Megiddo. Popular notions of Armageddon arise from mistranslations and later doctrinal embellishments.¹⁴

All participants in Gog and Magog are ultimately doomed to the lake of fire, as Scripture confirms (**Revelation 20:10**).¹⁵

Endnotes

1. *Revelation 20:4-6* – The First Resurrection is reserved for the righteous; a literal resurrection body is granted.
2. N.T. Wright, *Surprised by Hope*, pp. 276-278 – Bema Seat as governance and reward.
3. *Revelation 19:15* – The “sword from His mouth” imagery conveys immediate, precise divine judgment.
4. Michael Heiser, *The Unseen Realm*, pp. 420-423 – Emphasis on divine authority and order.
5. *Revelation 20:4* – Saints are seated in judgment, signifying governance and judicial roles.
6. *Galatians 5:22-23* – Moral virtues as standard for the kingdom.
7. *Isaiah 2:2-4*; *Revelation 20:4-6* – Millennium as a period of peace and order.
8. *Zechariah 14:16-19* – Jerusalem as central hub of divine governance.
9. *Revelation 5:10* – Saints co-reign with Christ during the Millennium.
10. *Ezekiel 38-39*; *Revelation 20:7-8* – Gog and Magog symbolic of remaining rebellious nations.
11. *Revelation 20:9* – Assault focused on Mount Zion; not a traditional battlefield.
12. *Revelation 20:9* – God’s swift intervention as cosmic irony.
13. *Romans 9:19-21* – Free will and divine sovereignty coexist.
14. *Revelation 16:16* – Har Magedōn = Mount of Assembly, not Megiddo.
15. *Revelation 20:10* – Final and eternal defeat of Satan, beast, and false prophet.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. Are there extra-biblical sources (Second Temple, Dead Sea Scrolls, early Church Fathers) that clarify the Gog/Magog symbolism?
2. How do contemporary scholars interpret Ezekiel's Gog and Magog in light of Revelation 20? Any debates we should note?
3. Linguistic nuance: Har Magedōn vs. Megiddo—what's the most substantial evidence that it's "Mount of Assembly"?
4. Historical geopolitical associations (Assyria, Babylon, Egypt): Can we cite credible scholarly sources for linking these to Gog/Magog archetypes?
5. Divine irony and humor: Are there theological precedents for framing Satan's final rebellion in this way?

SATAN'S FINAL FOLLY AND PERMANENT DEFEAT

“Then I saw thrones, and seated on them were those to whom the authority to judge was committed. Also I saw the souls of those who had been beheaded for their testimony of Jesus and for the word of God, and those who had not worshiped the beast or its image and had not received its mark. They came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.”

— Revelation 20:4

1. Introduction: The Millennium Concluded

The thousand-year reign of Christ on earth represents the zenith of divine order. During this period, peace, righteousness, and justice prevail, the curse is lifted, and Jerusalem shines as the radiant center of God's kingdom.

After this era, Scripture reveals a final sequence of events: the resurrection of the righteous, the establishment of government under Christ, and Satan's ultimate defeat.

2. The Bema Seat and the First Resurrection

Following the Millennium, the **Bema Seat**—the judgment seat of Christ—is central to understanding the reward structure for believers. Unlike the final judgment of the unrighteous, the Bema Seat concerns **awards for faithful service**.¹ The First Resurrection is not merely symbolic; it is the transformation of believers into glorified, immortal bodies, perfectly suited for participation in Christ’s eternal governance.²

NOTE: Many readers encounter the term “Bema Seat” for the first time. In Greco-Roman contexts, the Bēma was a tribunal platform where citizens received recognition for achievements. Applied to the saints, it reflects divine acknowledgment of obedience, not salvific evaluation.

Scholarly consensus emphasizes both the **continuity of resurrection themes** in the New Testament and the distinction between resurrection unto life (righteous) and resurrection unto judgment (unrighteous).³

3. Christ’s Post-Millennial Sojourn and the Final Sword

After rewarding the saints, Christ’s movements include a post-Millennial sojourn from Egypt to the Mount of Olives. This phase parallels messianic expectations found in Psalm 2, Isaiah 11, and Zechariah 14.⁴ At the Mount of Olives, the apocalyptic image of the “sword from His mouth” signals the swift and decisive execution of judgment on remaining opposition.⁵

This event is not arbitrary but reflects both justice and divine authority. The sword metaphor, frequently misunderstood as a literal blade, conveys immediate, sovereign action that neutralizes opposition with perfection and finality.⁶

4. Mop-Up and Establishment of Divine Governance

Following the final strike, remaining rulers and nations are brought into submission. Jerusalem becomes the operational center for God's righteous administration. The **Divine Council**, updated and seated with Christ on Mount Zion, exemplifies the biblical ideal of cosmic order.⁷

Here, the Scriptures reveal the interplay of human freedom, divine justice, and the ongoing implementation of God's virtues in earthly governance: love, peace, justice, and faithfulness.⁸

5. Satan's Release and Final Rebellion

After the Millennium, Satan is released for a final test (**Revelation 20:7**). He rallies the remaining unredeemed nations—symbolically called Gog and Magog—to attempt one last rebellion.

The reference to Gog and Magog is apocalyptic shorthand, not a literal revival of Ezekiel's historical enemies.⁹ Historically, these nations include Assyria, Babylon, and Egypt; more broadly, they represent all peoples who reject God's moral order.¹⁰

Satan's rebellion targets the **Mount of Assembly** (Har Magedōn)—the restored Temple Mount on Mount Zion—where Christ's throne and the saints' chambers reside.¹¹ This is not a battlefield but the center of divine government, emphasizing the absurdity of Satan's final attempt.

Fire from heaven consumes the rebels instantly, underlining the speed and completeness of divine intervention (**Revelation 20:9**). Scholars emphasize that this event occurs after the Millennium and must not be conflated with the Battle of Armageddon, a concept derived from mistranslation and popular myth.¹²

6. Permanent Defeat: The Lake of Fire

Satan, the beast, and the false prophet are cast into the lake of fire (**Revelation 20:10**). This final judgment is **permanent**, irreversible, and cosmic in scope. Scripture specifies that they are “tormented day and night forever,” signifying total separation and absolute defeat.¹³

Theologically, this event underscores God’s allowance of free will while demonstrating His ultimate sovereignty and humor: Satan is given every opportunity, yet fails spectacularly each time.¹⁴

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12. Mounce, R.H. *The Book of Revelation*. Zondervan, 1998, pp. 318-322.

13. Walvoord, J.F. *Revelation: The Key to Prophetic Revelation*. Moody, 1966, pp. 360-363.
14. Heiser, M. *The Cosmic Irony of Divine Judgment*. Naked Bible Podcast, Ep. 418.



REFLECT & Discuss

1. Bema Seat: Can we include concise historical and contemporary scholarly explanations for the reader?
2. First Resurrection: Are there patristic interpretations we can reference to strengthen the argument?
3. The “sword from Christ’s mouth” as military field orders—any exegetical studies that support this literal/figurative reading?
4. Temporal sequence: Scholars on the post-millennial reign versus dispensational interpretations. Can we cite both sides briefly?

THE THOUSAND-YEAR CHAIN: GOD'S GOVERNMENT ESTABLISHED

“And I saw thrones, and they sat upon them, and judgment was committed unto them.”

— Revelation 20:4

1. Introduction: Divine Governance Realized

Following the resurrection of the righteous and the establishment of Christ's court, Scripture depicts a period often referred to as the **Thousand-Year Chain**, wherein God's virtues—love, justice, peace, and faithfulness—are fully implemented throughout the renewed creation.

This era exemplifies the administrative perfection of divine rule, combining judicial oversight with righteous governance, and offering the redeemed a first-hand role in God's cosmic order.¹

2. Continuity of Christ's Rule

The resurrected saints, now glorified, participate alongside Christ in ruling the world. **Revelation 20:4-6** makes clear that this co-regency is eternal in scope and involves both judgment and administration.²

Each resurrected believer has a defined role in overseeing nations, cities, and institutions, consistent with the biblical principle of stewardship.³

NOTE: The governance described is not symbolic; it reflects real responsibilities and rewards. Just as the Bema Seat distributes honor based on faithful service, the Thousand-Year Chain operationalizes these rewards in practical administration.

Scholars emphasize the importance of distinguishing the Millennial reign from post-resurrection rewards. While millennial saints reign in the age-long peace, the Thousand-Year Chain involves active judgment and implementation of divine order.⁴

3. Establishing the Court

Christ's court is seated on Mount Zion, with the Divine Council surrounding Him, a recurring biblical motif that spans Psalms, Isaiah, and Daniel.⁵ This council is the judicial and administrative engine of the kingdom:

- Ensures adherence to God's moral and spiritual laws
- Executes decisions regarding governance and order
- Administers rewards for faithfulness and discipline for rebellion.⁶

The imagery underscores the biblical consistency of divine governance: authority flows from God through Christ to the saints, ensuring both accountability and equity.⁷

4. Conformity to God's Virtues

The Thousand-Year Chain allows for the world's moral and spiritual alignment with God's virtues. While Satan remains imprisoned, nations and individuals adapt to the principles of God's kingdom:

- Love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control ⁸
- Justice, equity, and righteous judgment in civil and spiritual spheres
- Worship and recognition of God as the ultimate authority ⁹

This period is distinct from human history, representing a practical realization of divine order that exceeds current societal structures.

5. Scholarly Consensus and Commentary

Academic literature consistently emphasizes that the Thousand-Year Chain reflects active participation of the saints in divine administration, not merely passive blessing. ¹⁰ The resurrection grants both authority and responsibility, reflecting the continuity of Christ's earthly and heavenly mission. ¹¹

- Heiser notes that this governance is an extension of the Bema Seat principles, transforming recognition into tangible authority. ¹²
- Beale and Collins emphasize the symbolic yet literal nature of the saints' reign: they rule the nations, exercise judgment, and implement God's covenantal order. ¹³
- Wright highlights the ethical dimension, wherein the saints model God's virtues to the redeemed creation, effectively bridging heaven and earth. ¹⁴

6. Integration with Eschatological Sequence

The Thousand-Year Chain serves as a parenthetical period between Christ's return and Satan's final release. Events are chronologically sequenced as follows:

- I. Bema Seat rewards for faithful believers

2. Christ's post-Millennial sojourn and final sword
3. Mop-up and establishment of divine court/government
4. Thousand-Year Chain of righteous administration
5. Satan's release and final rebellion
6. Permanent defeat and the Great White Throne Judgment

This sequencing avoids confusion with popularized notions of Armageddon or post-Tribulation events, remaining faithful to the biblical text.¹⁵

Scholarly References

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REFLECT & Discuss

1. The 1,000-year reign: Who are the best scholarly sources on literal vs. symbolic interpretations?
2. Practical governance: Are there studies on the societal implications of a perfect, restored order under Christ?
3. Saints' participation: Any historical or theological studies on co-ruling with Christ that would add authority?

THE GREAT WHITE THRONE JUDGMENT

FINAL COSMIC VERDICT

“Then I saw a great white throne and him who was seated on it. From His presence, earth and sky fled away, and no place was found for them.”

— Revelation 20:11

1. Introduction: The Final Court

After the Thousand-Year Chain and the definitive defeat of Satan, Scripture shifts to the culmination of divine justice: the **Great White Throne Judgment**.

This scene marks the end of human rebellion, the closure of the cosmic trial, and the permanent separation of the righteous and unrighteous.¹

The imagery of the “white throne” conveys both purity and ultimate authority, reflecting the absolute, impartial nature of God’s judgment.²

2. The Participants

Revelation 20:12-13 identifies the parties:

- **All whose names are not found in the Book of Life** — the unrighteous dead stand before God.³
- **The sea, Death, and Hades** release their dead for judgment, signifying the totality of resurrection for judgment.⁴

This judgment is **comprehensive**: every human, without exception, appears before the throne. Unlike the Bema Seat, which is limited to the redeemed, the Great White Throne addresses all who have rejected God's covenant.

3. The Procedure and Verdict

The judgment is judicial yet immediate:

- Books are opened, including the Book of Life, and deeds are evaluated.⁵
- The verdict is pronounced: those not found in the Book of Life are cast into the lake of fire.⁶
- **Revelation 20:14-15** defines this “second death” as complete and unending annihilation, with no remainder or hope of restoration.⁷

Scholars note that this is the definitive end of rebellion and represents final, cosmic justice.⁸ It is not a punitive display for spectacle; it is the enforcement of divine order.

4. The Nature of the Second Death

The second death is best understood as **permanent extinction**:

- Absolute separation from God, accompanied by total erasure of being.⁹
- The lake of fire is reserved for Satan, the beast, the false prophet, and all who persist in rebellion.¹⁰

- No posthumous repentance is possible; the judgment is irreversible.

This reinforces the biblical principle that God's patience has limits: infinite mercy is exercised, but final justice is inescapable.¹¹

5. The Righteous Exempt

Those who participated in the **First Resurrection** remain unaffected:

- Names are secure in the Book of Life
- Already glorified and immortal, they continue in Christ's eternal kingdom¹²
- They observe but do not undergo this judgment, underscoring the distinction between reward and condemnation¹³

This distinction preserves chronological and theological integrity, ensuring that readers understand the sequential nature of eschatological events.

6. Theological Implications

The Great White Throne Judgment communicates several profound truths:

1. **Divine Sovereignty** — God exercises absolute authority over life, death, and eternity.¹⁴
2. **Moral Accountability** — all human actions are known and evaluated.¹⁵
3. **Ultimate Justice** — no rebellion, deception, or sin escapes recompense.¹⁶
4. **Finality of Choice** — those outside the Book of Life experience irreversible consequences.¹⁷

This judgment is not arbitrary; it **reflects the culmination of God's moral and cosmic plan**, confirming the triumph of righteousness over all opposition.

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REFLECT & Discuss

1. Final judgment: Are there cross-references in apocalyptic literature that illuminate John's imagery?
2. Second Death: Are there significant linguistic debates on "annihilation" versus eternal torment that need acknowledgment?
3. Sea, Death, and Hades: Any classical or patristic interpretations that clarify "release of the dead"?

NEW HEAVEN AND NEW EARTH

ETERNAL RENEWAL

“Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more.”

— Revelation 21:1

1. Introduction: Cosmic Renewal

Following the Great White Throne Judgment, Scripture shifts to the re-creation of all things. The destruction of the old order, including death and rebellion, gives way to a radical renewal — a world perfected and fully aligned with God’s original intention.¹

The imagery of a “new heaven and a new earth” signals total transformation, not mere renovation.²

2. The Absence of the Sea

Revelation 21:1 notes the absence of the sea. In biblical symbolism, the sea often represents chaos, evil, and the restless nations.³ Its removal indicates:

- The eradication of cosmic disorder
- Permanent separation from forces opposed to God
- A world fully ordered according to divine principles

Scholars highlight that this signals the complete cessation of human and angelic rebellion in the renewed cosmos.⁴

3. God Dwelling with His People

Revelation 21:2-3 describes the descent of the **New Jerusalem**:

- The city is glorious, radiant, and perfect, prepared as God's eternal dwelling with humanity.⁵
- There is **no temple**, for God Himself and the Lamb are its light, signifying **direct access to divine presence**.⁶
- Nothing impure may enter, highlighting the complete holiness of the renewed creation.⁷

This is real and eternal, emphasizing the complete reconciliation of creation to God.⁸

4. The Declaration: "Behold, I Am Making All Things New"

Revelation 21:5 underscores God's sovereign action:

- He declares the comprehensive nature of the renewal, restoring all creation to its intended order.⁹
- The **Tree of Life** returns, granting eternal vitality to the redeemed.¹⁰
- Those who participated in the **First Resurrection** share in this eternal life, reigning with Christ forever.¹¹

This demonstrates that **eternal fellowship with God** is both personal and cosmic, encompassing all redeemed creation.¹²

5. Theological Implications

This chapter communicates several critical truths:

1. **Final Restoration** — God's original intention for creation is realized in full.¹³
2. **Holiness and Separation** — evil is permanently removed; only the redeemed remain.¹⁴
3. **Direct Divine Presence** — no temple or mediator is necessary; God is entirely accessible.¹⁵
4. **Eternal Life and Reward** — the righteous continue forever in Christ's reign.¹⁶

Theologically, the New Heaven and New Earth, reinforce the permanence of divine justice, and provide a culmination to redemptive history.¹⁷

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REFLECT & Discuss

1. Cosmic renewal: Any recent theological studies on “radical re-creation” vs. “cosmetic renovation”?
2. Curse removal: Are there canonical cross-references that we can footnote to strengthen the point?
3. Eternal fellowship: Can we cite scholars on the qualitative experience of God’s presence post-judgment?

NEW JERUSALEM

ETERNAL DWELLING AND COMPLETION

“And I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband.”

— Revelation 21:2

1. Introduction: The Eternal City

The New Jerusalem represents the culmination of God’s redemptive plan, the eternal dwelling for the redeemed. Unlike earthly cities, its origin is heavenly; it is not constructed by human hands but prepared by God Himself.¹ Its imagery is rich with wedding metaphors, underscoring the intimate relationship between God and His people.²

2. Physical and Spiritual Characteristics

Revelation 21:9-27 details the city’s features:

- **Dimensions and Structure:** The city is described as a perfect cube, 12,000 stadia in length, width, and height

(approx. 1,400 miles each side).³ This symmetry symbolizes perfection, completeness, and divine order.⁴

- **Foundations and Gates:** Twelve foundations bear the names of the twelve apostles, and twelve gates bear the names of the twelve tribes of Israel.⁵ This unites Old and New Covenant believers, highlighting continuity in God's people.⁶
- **Material Splendor:** Streets of pure gold, clear as glass; gates of pearl; foundations adorned with precious stones.⁷ These details are symbolic of spiritual beauty, glory, and purity rather than material wealth per se.⁸

3. Divine Presence and Illumination

The city has no temple, for God and the Lamb are its light (**Revelation 21:22-23**):

- **Continuous Illumination:** The city needs no sun or moon. God's presence provides uninterrupted light, a metaphor for perpetual divine fellowship.⁹
- **Holiness and Purity:** Nothing impure can enter (v.27). This represents the final removal of sin, death, and corruption.¹⁰

4. Inhabitants and Eternal Life

- The redeemed dwell permanently within the city, free from sorrow, pain, or death (v.4).¹¹
- Names recorded in the Book of Life signify secure membership in God's eternal kingdom.¹²
- The imagery of the bride emphasizes intimacy, covenant faithfulness, and eternal joy.¹³

5. Theological Significance

1. **Divine-Human Union:** The New Jerusalem manifests the eternal relationship between God and His redeemed people.¹⁴
2. **Cosmic Reconciliation:** The entire cosmos is brought into alignment with God's will, fulfilling the prophetic hope of peace and justice.¹⁵
3. **Eternal Accessibility:** The city's open gates (Rev. 21:25) indicate constant communion for all who are righteous.¹⁶
4. **Final Victory over Sin:** No trace of impurity signifies the complete eradication of rebellion and death.¹⁷

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REFLECT & Discuss

1. City imagery: What archaeological, historical, or theological insights help readers visualize New Jerusalem?
2. Absence of a temple: Can we cite exegetes on why the Lord Himself is the light?
3. Tree of Life: Are there intertextual links (Genesis 2–3, Ezekiel 47) that should be footnoted?
4. Scholarly authorities: Which modern exegetes (Heiser, Wright, Aus) support these points?

BACK COVER BLURB - THE DAY OF THE LORD (VOLUME 1)

The Day of the Lord: Volume 1 is the third book in *The Restoration Series* by Dr. Tim James.

The clock is ticking toward redemptive history's most crucial moment—the Day of the Lord. Why dwell on a brief season of turmoil when you can strengthen your faith in Jesus and prepare to reign with Him as a co-heir of God's Kingdom on earth? Did you know the righteous will judge angels, help restore creation to Eden-like perfection, and welcome the New Jerusalem as God comes to dwell with us forever? Recognize the prophetic signs and get ready for the King's arrival. Discover the Bible's truth about the new beginning—and beyond.

Jesus came. He's coming again – to stay!

APPENDIX A: KEY PROPHETIC TIMELINES

DANIEL, REVELATION, JESUS' OLIVET DISCOURSE

This appendix brings together the primary prophetic timelines revealed in Scripture, correlating key events in Daniel, the book of Revelation, and Jesus' Olivet Discourse (Matthew 24-25; Mark 13; Luke 21). These timelines provide a framework for understanding God's unfolding plan—from prophetic visions to the culmination of history.

Daniel's Prophetic Timeline

- **Daniel 2** – Nebuchadnezzar's statue vision: successive world empires culminating in God's eternal kingdom.
- **Daniel 7** – Four beasts representing kingdoms, the rise of the "little horn," and the Son of Man receiving dominion.
- **Daniel 9:24-27** – The seventy "weeks" prophecy, marking events from the decree to rebuild Jerusalem to the coming of Messiah and the final period of tribulation.
- **Daniel 12** – The time of the end: unprecedented distress, resurrection, and the final judgment.

Revelation's Prophetic Timeline

- **Revelation 6–8** – The seals: judgments leading toward the Day of the Lord.
- **Revelation 8–11** – The trumpets: escalating judgments and the declaration that “the kingdoms of this world have become the kingdoms of our Lord.”
- **Revelation 12–14** – Conflict between the dragon and the saints, the rise of the Beast, and the harvest of the earth.
- **Revelation 15–16** – The bowl judgments: God’s wrath poured out in full measure.
- **Revelation 19–20** – Christ’s return, the defeat of the Beast, the Millennial Kingdom, and the final judgment.
- **Revelation 21–22** – The new heaven and new earth.

Jesus’ Olivet Discourse Timeline

- **Beginning of Birth Pains** – Wars, famines, earthquakes, persecution.
- **The Abomination of Desolation** – A key midpoint marker, as foretold by Daniel.
- **Great Tribulation** – Unparalleled distress.
- **The Coming of the Son of Man** – Cosmic signs and the gathering of the elect.
- **Parables and Warnings** – Urging watchfulness and readiness.

Integrated Overview

When read together, Daniel’s visions, Revelation’s sequences, and Jesus’ teaching present a coherent prophetic panorama: the rise and fall of empires, a period of great deception and tribulation, the return of Christ in glory, the establishment of His reign, and the eternal state where God dwells with His people forever.



APPENDIX B: KEY BIBLICAL PASSAGES ON THE RESURRECTION

This compilation lists key Old and New Testament passages that speak directly to the resurrection of the dead, both righteous and unrighteous. These passages provide the biblical foundation for understanding the hope of life after death and the certainty of God's promised restoration.

Old Testament

- **Job 19:25-27** – Job's confidence that his Redeemer lives and that he will see God in the flesh.
- **Psalms 16:9-11** – David's assurance that God will not abandon his soul to Sheol.
- **Isaiah 25:8** – God will swallow up death forever and wipe away tears.
- **Isaiah 26:19** – The dead will live, and their bodies will rise.
- **Ezekiel 37:1-14** – Vision of the valley of dry bones, symbolizing Israel's restoration and hinting at bodily resurrection.
- **Daniel 12:2-3** – Many who sleep in the dust will awake, some to everlasting life and others to shame.

- **Hosea 13:14** – God’s promise to ransom His people from the power of the grave.

New Testament

- **Matthew 22:31-32** – Jesus affirms the resurrection using God’s declaration to Moses.
- **Matthew 28:1-10** – The resurrection of Jesus.
- **Luke 20:35-36** – The sons of the resurrection cannot die anymore.
- **John 5:28-29** – All in the graves will hear His voice and come out.
- **John 11:23-27** – Jesus declares Himself the resurrection and the life.
- **Acts 24:14-15** – Paul affirms belief in the resurrection of both the just and the unjust.
- **Romans 6:5** – United with Christ in a resurrection like His.
- **1 Corinthians 15:12-57** – The central chapter on the resurrection of the dead and the transformation of the living.
- **Philippians 3:20-21** – Transformation of our lowly body to be like His glorious body.
- **1 Thessalonians 4:13-18** – The dead in Christ will rise first at His coming.
- **Revelation 20:4-6, 11-15** – The first resurrection of the saints and the final resurrection for judgment.



APPENDIX C: CHART: MASKILIM VS. ZEALOTS VS. SAINTS VS. ANGELS

BELIEFS, ROLES, AND TIMELINE TABLES OF SECOND TEMPLE JUDAISM

Maskilim – "The Wise Ones"

Appearing in **Daniel 11–12**, the maskilim (from the Hebrew *sakal*, meaning “to be wise”) were spiritually perceptive Jews during the persecution of Antiochus IV. Not political or militant, they served as apocalyptic teachers who helped the faithful endure trials with insight. They reflect continuity with Jesus’ concept of “the wise” in parables and the early Christian emphasis on discernment during tribulation.

Zealots – "The Armed Patriots"

Zealots were first-century Jewish revolutionaries determined to expel Rome from Judea. Motivated by zeal reminiscent of Phinehas and Judas Maccabeus, they often advocated violence. Their fervor sparked the Jewish War (66–70 AD), culminating in Jerusalem’s destruction. Jesus explicitly rejected their militant approach, offering instead a kingdom ethic rooted in suffering love.

Disciples – "The Committed Followers"

From the Greek *mathētēs*, disciples were apprentices of a rabbi. In Jesus' day, discipleship meant more than study—it meant relational obedience, life imitation, and enduring hardship for the teacher's mission. Unlike Zealots, Jesus' disciples pursued transformation through servanthood, not rebellion.

Essenes – "The Holy Separatists"

Likely responsible for the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Essenes withdrew from Temple life, seeing it as corrupted by leadership. They lived in disciplined, ritual-pure communities, anticipating apocalyptic deliverance and embracing dual-messiah theology (one priestly, one kingly). Though not mentioned directly in the New Testament, they represent a distinct strand of Jewish hope during the Second Temple period.

Pharisees – "The Separated Ones of the People"

Emerging as a lay movement devoted to Torah obedience and oral traditions, the Pharisees believed holiness extended beyond the Temple into daily life. Influential in synagogues and among ordinary people, they affirmed the resurrection, angels, and divine judgment. While often rebuked by Jesus for hypocrisy, some Pharisees—like Nicodemus and Paul—embraced faith. Their legacy shaped rabbinic Judaism after the Temple's destruction.

Nazarites – "The Vowed and Consecrated"

Nazarites took special vows of dedication to God (Numbers 6), including abstaining from wine, avoiding contact with the dead, and not cutting their hair. Though not a sect, Nazarites embodied radical holiness. Samson, Samuel, and likely John the Baptist were lifelong Nazarites, highlighting a call to be set apart for God's purposes within Israel's distinct calling.

*(Table: Comparison of Jewish Groups and Titles in the Second Temple
Period is on the next page.)*

Comparison of Jewish Groups and Titles in the Second Temple
Period

Term	Meaning / Origin	Role or Function	Distinctive Features / Commitments	Scriptural or Historical Reference
Maskilim	Hebrew for “those who have insight” (cf. <i>sakal</i>)	Wise, righteous teachers or apocalyptic visionaries	Promote understanding in times of persecution; martyred for their faith	Daniel 11:33–35; 12:3, 10
Zealot	From Greek <i>zelotes</i> —“zealous one”	Political-military insurgents resisting Roman rule	Advocated violent revolt; considered Roman occupation a blasphemy	Luke 6:15; Josephus, <i>Wars</i> 2.117–118
Disciple	Greek <i>mathētēs</i> —“learner” or “apprentice”	Student or follower of a rabbi or teacher	Committed to learning and imitating the teacher’s way of life and teachings	Matthew 10:1–4; John 13:35
Essene	Probable Greek form of a Hebrew root meaning “pious” or “healer”	Separatist priestly sect with apocalyptic and purification concerns	Lived communally; observed strict purity laws; possibly responsible for DSS	Josephus, <i>Wars</i> 2.119–161; Dead Sea Scrolls
Pharisee	From Hebrew <i>perushim</i> —“separated ones”	Legal scholars and lay leaders focused on Torah obedience	Emphasized oral tradition; believed in resurrection and angels	Matthew 23; Acts 23:6–8; Josephus, <i>Ant.</i> 13.10.6
Nazirite	From Hebrew <i>nazir</i> —“consecrated” or “separated one”	Individual under a voluntary or lifelong vow to God	Abstained from wine, hair-cutting, and corpse contact	Numbers 6:1–21; Judges 13 (Samson)

(See more tables on the following three pages.)

Key Dates – Second Temple & Intertestamental Period

Date (B.C./A.D.)	Event
538 B.C.	Cyrus the Great allows Jews to return from Babylonian exile
515 B.C.	Second Temple completed under Zerubbabel
445 B.C.	Nehemiah rebuilds Jerusalem's walls
332 B.C.	Alexander the Great conquers Judea
323 B.C.	Alexander dies; Ptolemies and Seleucids divide his empire
198 B.C.	Seleucids gain control of Judea
167 B.C.	Antiochus IV desecrates the Temple (Abomination of Desolation)
164 B.C.	Temple rededicated (origin of Hanukkah); Maccabean Revolt triumphs
142 B.C.	Jewish independence under Hasmoneans begins
63 B.C.	Pompey of Rome captures Jerusalem
37 B.C.	Herod the Great becomes king under Roman appointment
20–10 B.C.	Herod renovates the Second Temple magnificently
4 B.C.	Death of Herod the Great; Jesus born around this time
A.D. 26–36	Ministry of Jesus and Roman Prefect Pontius Pilate
A.D. 70	Second Temple destroyed by Rome
A.D. 132–135	Bar Kokhba Revolt; final crushing of Jewish nationalism

Timeline: Intertestamental & Second Temple Period

Date (BC/AD)	Event/Period	Notes
538 BC	Return from Babylonian Exile	Decree of Cyrus; beginning of Second Temple period
515 BC	Second Temple completed	Zerubbabel's temple, later expanded by Herod
c. 445–432 BC	Reforms of Ezra and Nehemiah	Rebuilding of walls, religious reforms
333 BC	Alexander the Great conquers the Levant	Hellenistic influence spreads
323 BC	Alexander dies; empire divided	Seleucid and Ptolemaic rule begins
198 BC	Seleucids gain control over Judea	Antiochus III defeats the Ptolemies
167–164 BC	Maccabean Revolt	Jewish uprising against Antiochus IV Epiphanes
164 BC	Temple rededicated (Hanukkah)	Start of Hasmonean rule in practice
142 BC	Full political independence under Hasmoneans	Simon declared High Priest, military leader, and ruler
63 BC	Pompey captures Jerusalem	Judea becomes a client kingdom of Rome

Timeline of Jewish Resistance and Apocalyptic Expectation

Date	Group / Event	Notes
167–160 BC	Maccabean Revolt	Revolt against Antiochus IV; rise of Hasmonean dynasty
100s BC	Essenes (Qumran community)	Apocalyptic sect, likely linked to the Dead Sea Scrolls
Early 1st c.	Zealot movement begins	Anti-Roman sentiment grows; proto-Zealots may have formed earlier
ca. 4 BC	Death of Herod the Great	Political instability, messianic hopes intensified
6 AD	Judas the Galilean's revolt	Key Zealot figure; refused Roman census and taxation
ca. 26–30 AD	Ministry of Jesus	Apocalyptic message, messianic identity, challenge to authorities
30–33 AD	Crucifixion and resurrection claims	Jesus' followers proclaim Him as risen Messiah
66–70 AD	First Jewish–Roman War	Jerusalem and Temple destroyed in 70 AD
73 AD	Fall of Masada	Zealot stronghold falls; mass suicide according to Josephus
ca. 90s AD	Book of Revelation written	Likely during Domitian's reign; persecution and eschatology central
132–135 AD	Bar Kokhba Revolt	Final major Jewish revolt; massive Roman retaliation and diaspora
Mid–Late 200s	Rabbinic Judaism consolidates	Rise of Mishnah; shift away from apocalyptic/militant expectations

APPENDIX D: THE WRITTEN WORD, BIBLE LANGUAGES, HISTORY & MAPS, DEFINITIONS

Myth - Storytelling

Before the written word, there was myth. Mythic oral traditions passed down through generations via storytelling and song are often dismissed as mere fantasy. Yet, myths frequently contain more enduring truth than some written documents¹.

First Written Word - Cuneiform

Cuneiform, one of the earliest writing systems, predates Noah's Flood (dated 2348 BCE by Ussher's Young Earth chronology) and thus predates the Tower of Babel event (2300–2000 BCE)². The Bible indicates that pre-Flood societies had significant technological and cultural development. For example, Genesis 4:17 records Cain building a city³, while verses 20–22 describe early advances in animal domestication (Jabal), music (Jubal), and metalworking (Tubal-Cain)⁴.

Proto-cuneiform tablets from the Jemdet Nasr Period (~3100–2900 BCE) show an evolution toward more complex signs⁵. By the Early

Dynastic Period (~2900–2350 BCE), cuneiform was widely used for administrative and literary texts⁶, illustrating writing’s continuity post-Flood.

Genesis 10 lists nations descending from Noah’s sons, implying rapid cultural recovery after the Flood. If pre-Flood knowledge (including writing) was preserved by Noah’s family, cuneiform could have persisted or been reintroduced by Babel’s time (~2300–2000 BCE)⁷.

The Gudea Inscription tablets (~2100 BCE, Ur III dynasty) describe temple building—possibly paralleling the Babel narrative⁸. By 2100–1800 BCE, cuneiform encompassed law codes, literature (such as Enheduanna’s hymns), and royal inscriptions⁹. The Etemenanki ziggurat in Babylon dates to ~1800 BCE¹⁰, illustrating advanced cuneiform culture consistent with a continuous tradition from pre-Flood origins.

Summary:

Cuneiform’s origins (~3500 BCE) predate the Flood, with clear continuity through post-Flood civilizations up to and beyond the Babel event. Early tablets like Uruk IV and Kish Tablets attest to this history¹¹.

Endnotes

1. Mythic oral traditions can preserve truth beyond written documents; see comparative myth studies.
2. Ussher’s chronology dates the Flood to 2348 BCE; see *Annals of the World*, James Ussher.
3. Genesis 4:17 — Cain builds a city.
4. Genesis 4:20–22 — Early cultural advancements in animal domestication, music, and metallurgy.
5. Jemdet Nasr Period tablets (~3100–2900 BCE) show proto-

cuneiform development; see *The Cambridge Ancient History*.

6. Early Dynastic Period cuneiform texts (~2900–2350 BCE); administrative and literary continuity.
7. Genesis 10 — Nations post-Flood; cultural reestablishment.
8. Gudea Inscription tablets (~2100 BCE) describe temple building; possibly related to Babel narrative.
9. Cuneiform usage for laws and literature, including Enheduanna's hymns (~2100–1800 BCE).
10. Etemenanki ziggurat (~1800 BCE) in Babylon, showing advanced cuneiform culture.
11. Uruk IV and Kish Tablets confirm early writing systems and possible pre-Flood continuity.

Hebrew Language and Scripts

Hebrew belongs to the Northwest Semitic language family, related to Phoenician and Aramaic¹. Its alphabet comprises 22 consonants, with vowel sounds indicated later by diacritical marks².

Ancient or Classical Hebrew is the language of the Hebrew Bible (Tanakh)³. Key forms include:

- **Paleo-Hebrew:** earliest Hebrew script (~1100 BCE), derived from Phoenician⁴.
- **Biblical Hebrew:** developed around 600 BCE during the Babylonian captivity⁵.
- **Mishnaic Hebrew:** found in the Talmud, dating from the 200s AD⁶.

Aramaic

Aramaic was the common spoken language during Jesus' time⁷. Portions of the Old Testament were written in Aramaic, including

Daniel 2:4b–7:28; Ezra 4:8–6:18, Jeremiah 10:11, and a few words in **Genesis 31:47**⁸. During the Second Temple period, Aramaic was the lingua franca for daily life, while Hebrew remained the language of scripture and worship⁹.

The Hebrew script used today—the square or Ashuri script—originated from the Aramaic script¹⁰. "Targums" are Aramaic paraphrases or interpretations of Hebrew Bible texts, designed to aid understanding¹¹.

Greek and the Septuagint

The New Testament was primarily written in Koine Greek, also called Biblical Greek¹².

The Septuagint is the Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures (Old Testament), created for Greek-speaking Jews in Egypt in the 3rd–2nd centuries BCE¹³. Tradition states that 72 Jewish scholars translated the texts under Ptolemy II's patronage for his Library of Alexandria.

The Septuagint includes books not found in the Hebrew Masoretic Text and influenced the Latin Vulgate canon¹⁴.

Endnotes

1. Hebrew is a Northwest Semitic language related to Phoenician and Aramaic; see *The Semitic Languages*, Robert Hetzron.
2. Hebrew alphabet: 22 consonants with vowel marks added later; see *Introduction to Biblical Hebrew*, Thomas O. Lambdin.
3. Classical Hebrew is the language of the Hebrew Bible (Tanakh).

4. Paleo-Hebrew script (~1100 BCE), derived from Phoenician; see *Ancient Scripts and Writing Systems*.
5. Biblical Hebrew developed around 600 BCE, during the Babylonian captivity period.
6. Mishnaic Hebrew, used in the Talmud, dates back to the 200s AD.
7. Aramaic was common in the 1st century Jewish world; see *Aramaic Language and Literature*.
8. Portions of the Old Testament in Aramaic: Daniel, Ezra, Jeremiah, Genesis; see *The Hebrew Bible: A Translation with Commentary*.
9. Second Temple period linguistic context; Hebrew for scripture, Aramaic for daily use.
10. Square (Ashuri) script for Hebrew writing; standard script adopted.
11. Targums are Aramaic paraphrases/interpretations of Hebrew Bible texts.
12. Koine Greek as the New Testament language; see *Greek Grammar Beyond the Basics*, Daniel B. Wallace.
13. Septuagint translation by 72 scholars under Ptolemy II (~3rd century BC); see *The Septuagint and Its Significance*.
14. The Septuagint includes deuterocanonical books later adopted in the Latin Vulgate.

(Historic Maps begins on the next page.)

Historical Context: The Two Kingdoms of Israel

After Solomon's reign (~925 BCE), Israel split into two kingdoms: the Northern Kingdom (Israel) and the Southern Kingdom (Judah)¹. Assyria conquered Israel (~700 BCE)², and Babylon conquered Judah (~586 BCE)³.



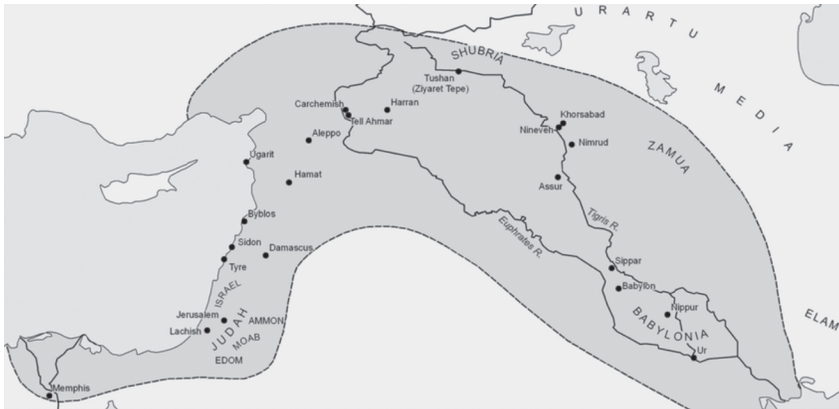
King Hezekiah of Judah faced an Assyrian siege in 701 BCE, but Jerusalem was miraculously preserved⁴⁻⁵. Later, Nebuchadnezzar besieged and destroyed Jerusalem, ending Judah's kingdom, and exiling many citizens⁶⁻⁸.

Endnotes

1. 1 Kings 12; 2 Chronicles 10
2. 2 Kings 17:5-6
3. 2 Kings 25; Jeremiah 52
4. 2 Kings 18; Isaiah 36-37
5. 2 Kings 19:35-36; 2 Chronicles 32:21; Isaiah 37:36-37

6. 2 Kings 24:10-17
7. Jeremiah 37-39
8. 2 Kings 25; Jeremiah 39
9. Jeremiah 39:6-7

Neo-Assyrian Empire



The Neo-Assyrian Empire dominated the Near East during the 8th and 7th centuries BCE¹⁰. Kings like Sennacherib expanded Assyrian control, conquering the Northern Kingdom¹¹. In 701 BCE, Assyria besieged Jerusalem but retreated after divine intervention¹².

Assyrian deportations dispersed Israel's ten tribes, leading to the "Ten Lost Tribes" concept¹³. Their policy of intermingling peoples to erase identities parallels biblical accounts of supernatural beings and their judgment^{14–18}.

Scholarly side note: Assyrian deportation tactics involved intermingling conquered peoples to erase their identity¹⁴. This practice bears a curious parallel to the biblical account of the “fallen angels” (Watchers), their Nephilim offspring, and the Elioud descendants—spiritual and supernatural beings described in Genesis and other ancient texts¹⁵.

The “fallen angels” were bound at Mount Hermon¹⁶. Jesus' transfiguration is believed by some scholars to have taken place near this location, symbolizing His victory over evil¹⁷.

The disembodied spirits of the Nephilim are identified as demons — soulless beings not redeemable by Christ’s sacrifice¹⁸.

Apollyon, the “Destroyer” and king of the Abyss, will be released during the Fifth Trumpet judgment in Revelation¹⁹. Jesus holds the key to the Abyss but delegates its opening to a mighty angel.²⁰ Satan, Azazel, Semjaza, and other “fallen” angels remain imprisoned until the final judgment and will ultimately end up in the lake of fire.²¹

Prophetically, “The Assyrian” represents not only the historical Assyrian king but also the future Antichrist (cf. **Isaiah 10:5-19; Daniel 7:19-27; Revelation 13:5-10; 2 Thessalonians 2:1-12**)²².

Endnotes

10. *Ancient Near Eastern Texts Relating to the Old Testament*, James B. Pritchard
11. 2 Kings 17; 18
12. 2 Kings 19:35-36; Isaiah 37:36-37
13. 2 Kings 17:5-6; Josephus, *Antiquities*
14. Assyrian deportation practices; see *The Bible and Archaeology*, J. Bright
15. Genesis 6:1-5; 1 Enoch 6-10; Jude 1:6; 2 Peter 2:4
16. 1 Enoch 6:6; Jubilees 7:22
17. Mark 9:2-8; *The Transfiguration*, theological commentaries
18. See *Demonic Entities in the Bible* by Michael S. Heiser
19. Revelation 9:1-11
20. Revelation 9:1-2
21. Revelation 20:10
22. Isaiah 10:5-19; Daniel 7:19-27; Revelation 13; 2 Thessalonians 2

Samaritans

The Samaritans are mixed descendants of both the remaining Israelites and the Assyrian foreign settlers. Once pure Jews of the Northern Kingdom, after the Assyrians conquered them, the populace developed a distinct identity, claiming descent from Jacob but diverging in their religious practices. They were not recognized as part of restored Israel by returning Judean exiles (**Ezra 4:1-3**)²³.

In 2017, genetic analyses of Samaritan DNA suggested partial Israelite ancestry, mixed with that of other Near Eastern groups, supporting biblical accounts of intermingling (**2 Kings 17:24**)²⁴.

Endnotes

23. Ezra 4:1-3

24. 2 Kings 17:24; Genetic studies on Samaritans, 2017

(Map and History of the Neo-Babylonian (Chaldean) Empire is on the next page.)

Neo-Babylonian (Chaldean) Empire



The Neo-Babylonian Empire (Nabopolassar seized the throne in 626 BC, dying in 605 BC; Nebuchadnezzar II succeeded him until 562 BC; followed briefly by Amel-Marduk, Neriglissar, Labashi-Marduk, Nabonidus, and finally Belshazzar) was a dominant Mesopotamian empire before the Persian conquest in 539 BC²⁵.

“So in the ninth year of Zedekiah’s reign, on the tenth day of the tenth month, Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon marched against Jerusalem with his whole army. He encamped outside the city and built siege works all around it. The city was kept under siege until the eleventh year of King Zedekiah.”

— 2 Kings 25:1-2²⁶

Nebuchadnezzar II destroyed Solomon’s Temple, stole its precious implements, and exiled many Jews, including Ezekiel, Daniel, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego. This event marked a pivotal moment in biblical history (2 Chronicles 36:15-21; Isaiah 44:28; 45:1; Jeremiah 29:10; 52:4-5; Lamentations 1:1)²⁷.

Cyrus the Great, king of Persia, “conquered” Babylon without a fight in 539 BC. Cyrus allowed the Jewish people to return to Jerusalem to rebuild the temple (Ezra 1:2-3)²⁸.

Endnotes

25. Nabopolassar to Belshazzar timeline; *Ancient Near East Historical Records*
26. 2 Kings 25:1-2
27. 2 Chronicles 36:15-21; Isaiah 44:28; 45:1; Jeremiah 29:10; 52:4-5; Lamentations 1:1
28. Ezra 1:2-3

Definitions and Terms

- **Torah:** The first five books of the Hebrew Bible (Genesis–Deuteronomy), also called the Pentateuch¹.
- **First Temple (“Solomon’s Temple”):** Built ~10th century BCE, destroyed in 587 BCE by Nebuchadnezzar II².
- **Tanakh:** The Hebrew Bible, comprising Torah, Nevi’im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings)³.
- **Second Temple Period:** The era (~516 BCE – 70 AD) during which the rebuilt temple stood, ending with the Roman siege⁴.
- **Septuagint (LXX):** Greek translation of Hebrew Scriptures, including Apocrypha, made for Greek-speaking Jews in Egypt⁵.
- **Dead Sea Scrolls (DSS):** Ancient Jewish manuscripts from the Second Temple period discovered mid-20th century, illuminating early biblical texts and Judaism⁶.
- **Masoretes and Masoretic Text (MT):** Jewish scribes (c. 500–1000 AD) who standardized Hebrew Bible pronunciation and text, producing the authoritative Masoretic Text⁷.
- **Sheol:** The underworld/realm of the dead. Holds both righteous and unrighteous compartments until resurrection.
- **Paradise / Abraham’s Bosom:** The righteous compartment within Sheol.⁸

- **Hades:** The **unrighteous** compartment within Sheol. Used in some translations as a stand-in for *Sheol*, which this work treats as imprecise.⁹
- **Gehenna:** Final judgment/destroying fire; not Sheol.¹⁰
- **Abyss / Tartarus:** Prison for rebellious spirits/angels; distinct from human Sheol.¹¹

Endnotes

1. Genesis 1–Deuteronomy 34
2. 2 Kings 25:8–10; Jeremiah 52:12–14
3. Ezra 1:1–4; Nehemiah 8; 2 Chronicles 36:22–23
4. Ezra 6:15; Josephus, *Antiquities* 11.7.1
5. Letter of Aristeas; Aquila, Symmachus, Theodotion
6. Emanuel Tov, *The Textual Criticism of the Hebrew Bible* (2001)
7. The Aleppo Codex; The Leningrad Codex
8. Luke 16:22; 23:43
9. Luke 16:23
10. Matt 10:28; Rev 20
11. Luke 8:31; 2 Pet 2:4; Rev 9:1

(An Addendum: For Terminology Clarification is on the next page.)

Addendum: For Terminology Clarification

Paradise is the righteous section of Sheol, a temporary abode distinct from heaven, where souls await resurrection.

Hades is for the unrighteous. Once in Hades, your next stop is at the White Throne judgment and incineration in the lake of fire.

While the Bible does not detail the mechanics of the (soul and spirit) at death, **1 Thessalonians 5:23** says:

“... and may your spirit and soul and body be preserved complete, without blame at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.”

Thus, it appears that at least the soul and spirit of the righteous survive mortal death and resurrection. I doubt the same can be said for the unrighteous who are forever separated from God and have no further need of a soul. **Hebrews 4:12** distinguishes between *soul and spirit* — so they’re not the same thing. (“... *piercing as far as the division of soul and spirit, of both joints and marrow...*”). Theologians take this verse as reinforcing the tripartite (body-soul-spirit) distinction.



APPENDIX E: A POTPOURRI OF
NOTES, OBSERVATIONS, AND
FOOTNOTES

WHAT THE BIBLE REALLY TEACHES ABOUT
LIFE AFTER DEATH

This corpus of miscellaneous lessons and essays provides insights, clarifications, and additional biblical references not essential to the main narrative but valuable for deeper study.

In the Beginning — Two Realms, Two Families

“In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.”
— **Genesis 1:1**¹

Scripture consistently presents creation as a unified whole — the heavens and the earth. In Hebrew, *šāmayim* (“heavens,” “sky”) usually refers to the visible sky or atmospheric heavens, not God’s dwelling place.² Genesis 1 describes the ordered, visible world where humanity lives; it does not say “God created Heaven” — as in His throne room.³

776 [e]	853 [e]	8064 [e]	853 [e]	430 [e]	1254 [e]	7225 [e]
hā·'ā·reš.	wə·'êṭ	haš·šā·ma·yim	'êṭ	'ē·lō·hîm;	bā·rā	bə·rê·šît
הָאָרֶץ:	וְאֵת	הַשָּׁמַיִם	אֵת	אֱלֹהִים	בָּרָא	בְּרֵאשִׁית 1
the earth	and	the heavens	-	God	created	In the beginning
Art N-fs	Conj-w DirObjM	Art N-mp	DirObjM	N-mp	V-Qal-Perf-3ms	Prep-b N-fs

Strong's 8064, *haš·šā·mā·yim* — “the heavens,” “the sky above,” “the expanse where the clouds move.”⁴ This detail matters. It is often blurred in English translations and creeds, but it shapes how we understand God's purposes.

God Above — Humanity Below

God is an eternal, omnipresent, omniscient, and omnipotent Spirit — everywhere, all the time, from everlasting to everlasting.⁵ Jesus stated it plainly:

*8 [23] “You are from below; I am from above.
You are of this world; I am not of this world.”
— John 8:23⁶ (Jesus)*

From the very beginning, there have been two realms — “above” (for *elohim*/angels), and “below” (for humans) — and two families:

1. The heavenly family — supernatural beings (*elohim*) dwelling in the unseen realm.⁷
2. The human family — created from the dust of the earth to bear God's image.⁸

The Deuteronomy 32 Worldview

Deuteronomy 32:8-9 reveals that God divided the nations according to the number of the “*sons of God*” — the divine council.⁹ Humanity's story unfolds alongside — and often in conflict with those divine beings.¹⁰ Redemption involves restoring God's rule in both realms.¹¹

Contrary to popular teaching, redeemed humans are not destined to “go up” and live in God's celestial heaven forever.¹² The biblical vision is resurrection life on earth under the reign of the returning King.¹³ Heaven and earth, once separated, will be united again — as they were “in the beginning.”¹⁴

Angels — Soulless and Without Salvation

Angels are spiritual beings created to serve God, but unlike humans, they do not possess souls capable of redemption. Salvation is reserved for humans alone:

“For surely it is not angels He helps, but Abraham’s descendants.”¹⁵

Though angels long to understand God’s plan of salvation,¹⁶ they remain outside its scope. They are accountable for their obedience and face judgment if they rebel. **Psalm 82** depicts divine beings subject to judgment who, upon demotion, can “die” like humans:

“God has taken his place in the divine council; in the midst of the gods he holds judgment: ... You shall die like men...”¹⁷

Jude 1:6 warns of angels who abandoned their proper dwelling and are held in eternal chains awaiting judgment.¹⁸ Unlike humans, angels have no promise of redemption or spiritual rebirth.

Spiritual Death Applies to Angels as Well as to Humans

Spiritual death means permanent separation from God’s presence and favor. Angels do not experience physical death as humans do, but when stripped of their divine status, as in Psalm 82, they can “die” like mortals.¹⁹

For angels, spiritual death is eternal estrangement from God, confirmed by Scripture:

“For if God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into hell and committed them to chains of gloomy darkness to be kept until judgment...”²⁰

...and...

“...the angels who did not keep their positions... abandoned their proper dwelling — these he has kept in darkness, bound with everlasting chains for judgment.”²¹

Humans, by contrast, receive redemption through faith in Christ, which reverses spiritual death.

The Human Soul Connects Directly With God

Both angels and humans have spirits, but spiritual death means separation from God’s presence. Isaiah says:

“But your iniquities have made a separation between you and your God.”²²

This separation is eternal for the unrepentant:

“They will suffer the punishment of eternal destruction, away from the presence of the Lord.”²³

Jesus describes final judgment as exclusion from His presence:

“I never knew you; depart from me, you workers of lawlessness.”²⁴

Spiritual death is ultimate alienation from God, the source of life and identity. Humans alone can be restored through salvation.

Spiritual Death and the Afterlife

- Paradise: rest for the righteous.
- Hades: torment for the condemned.

Scripture does not provide for repentance after death:

“...it is appointed for man to die once, and after that comes judgment.”²⁵

Once dead, we are judged righteous or unrighteous. Angels escort the righteous to Sheol's Paradise - the place of comfort, and the unrighteous to Sheol's Hades - the place of torment. It is impossible to pray a dead person to salvation. There is no such place as Purgatory.

*"When the wicked dies, his hope perishes."*²⁶

Forgiveness and New Life in Christ

God offers forgiveness through faith in Christ — a spiritual rebirth (baptism) that reverses death and separation:

*"...you, who were dead in your trespasses... God made alive together with Him, having forgiven us all our trespasses..."*²⁷

*"...the free gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord."*²⁸

Spiritual rebirth ("born again") is essential to enter God's Kingdom here on earth:

*"Unless one is born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God."*²⁹

Baptism symbolizes this new life — a burial and resurrection with Christ. The indwelling of God's Spirit reverses death and empowers a new identity.³⁰

No Human Has Ascended to God's Spiritual Realm—Except Jesus

God's spiritual realm ("heaven") is reserved for God and His angelic council. Jesus alone descended and ascended.³¹ Even King David did not ascend there.³²

Where Do the Righteous Dead Await Resurrection?

The righteous dead await in “Abraham’s bosom,” also known as Sheol’s Paradise — a subterranean place of rest separated from torment by a great chasm. The resurrection brings them back to life on earth.

Jesus said, “*Today you will be with me in Paradise*”³³ — a Paradise below, not in the celestial throne room.

Endnotes

1. Genesis 1:1.
2. Strong’s Hebrew 8064; cf. Genesis 1:8; Psalm 19:1.
3. See Isaiah 66:1; 2 Chronicles 6:18.
4. Brown-Driver-Briggs, Hebrew and English Lexicon of the Old Testament.
5. Psalm 90:2; Jeremiah 23:24.
6. John 8:23.
7. Job 38:7; Psalm 82:1.
8. Genesis 1:26-27; 2:7.
9. Deuteronomy 32:8-9, ESV; cf. Dead Sea Scrolls, LXX.
10. Daniel 10:12-21; Psalm 82.
11. Ephesians 1:9-10; Colossians 1:16-20.
12. John 3:13; Acts 2:34.
13. Revelation 5:10; 20:4-6.
14. Revelation 21:1-3.
15. Hebrews 2:16.
16. 1 Peter 1:12.
17. Psalm 82:1-2, 7.
18. Jude 1:6.
19. Psalm 82:1-2, 7.
20. 2 Peter 2:4.
21. Jude 1:6.
22. Isaiah 59:2.
23. 2 Thessalonians 1:9.

24. Matthew 7:23.
25. Hebrews 9:27.
26. Proverbs 11:7.
27. Colossians 2:13.
28. Romans 6:23.
29. John 3:3.
30. 2 Corinthians 5:17; Colossians 2:13; 1 Peter 1:3; Romans 6:4-5; John 5:24; Galatians 2:20; Romans 8:10-11.
31. John 3:13; Ephesians 4:9-10.
32. Acts 2:34.
33. Luke 23:43.

What About “Absent from the Body... Present with the Lord”?

Many use Paul’s statement, “absent from the body... present with the Lord” (2 Corinthians 5:8)³⁴ to argue that believers go directly to heaven at death. But the passage does not describe a post-mortem relocation to God’s celestial throne room. Instead, Paul contrasts life in our current mortal body with life in our future resurrected, immortal body.³⁵

Paul’s longing was for resurrection — to be “clothed” with immortality — not for a disembodied state.³⁶ His hope aligns with the consistent biblical teaching that eternal life begins with resurrection at Christ’s return, not before.³⁷

The “Second Temple” and “Intertestamental” Periods

The *Second Temple Period* refers broadly to Jewish religious, theological, and cultural development, as well as beliefs, from circa 516 BC to AD 70. That corresponds to the period during which the Second Temple stood in Jerusalem. In Second Temple thought, “Paradise” was a compartment of Sheol, below.

The same belief prevailed during the *Intertestamental Period*, from approximately 430 BC to 4 BC, commonly marked by the end of the Old Testament prophets (Malachi) and continued until around the time of Jesus' birth, which also corresponds with the death of King Herod.

The “Intermediate State” — Rest, Not Reward

Scripture indicates that the dead — righteous and unrighteous alike — are conscious in Sheol/Hades, awaiting resurrection and final judgment.³⁸ This intermediate state is not the believer's final inheritance; it is a place of waiting.

The righteous rest in Paradise (Abraham's bosom), comforted by God's promise,³⁹ while the unrighteous experience torment and separation.⁴⁰ Neither group has yet received its final reward or punishment.⁴¹

Resurrection — The True Hope of the Believer

The ultimate Christian hope is resurrection at the return of Christ.⁴² At that time, the dead in Christ will rise first,⁴³ mortality will be swallowed up by life,⁴⁴ and believers will reign with Christ on the renewed earth.⁴⁵

Paul states plainly that if there is no resurrection, then our faith is in vain.⁴⁶ This central doctrine is the climax of God's redemptive plan — the reunification of heaven and earth, with Christ reigning in both realms.⁴⁷

Eternal Life on Earth, Not in Heaven

Nowhere does Scripture teach that redeemed humanity will spend eternity in God's celestial realm.⁴⁸ Instead, heaven comes to earth —

God's dwelling will be with His people.⁴⁹ This is the restoration of Eden, where God and humanity dwell together in a unified creation.⁵⁰

John's vision in Revelation shows the New Jerusalem descending from heaven to earth.⁵¹ The redeemed will live in resurrected bodies, in a renewed world, with God Himself as their light and life.⁵²

Endnotes

- 34. 2 Corinthians 5:8
- 35. 1 Corinthians 15:42-54
- 36. 2 Corinthians 5:2-4
- 37. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-17
- 38. Luke 16:19-31; Revelation 20:13
- 39. Luke 16:22-25
- 40. Luke 16:23-24
- 41. Revelation 20:11-15
- 42. John 6:39-40
- 43. 1 Thessalonians 4:16
- 44. 1 Corinthians 15:54
- 45. Revelation 5:10; 20:4-6
- 46. 1 Corinthians 15:14-18
- 47. Ephesians 1:9-10
- 48. John 3:13; Acts 2:34
- 49. Revelation 21:3
- 50. Genesis 3:8; Revelation 22:3-5
- 51. Revelation 21:2
- 52. Revelation 21:23; 22:5

The UP/DN Confusion of Gnosticism

A significant source of confusion about the afterlife is rooted in early Gnostic falsehoods, which inverted biblical cosmology by elevating

‘up’ as divine and demonizing ‘down.’ This error has deeply influenced Christian tradition, leading many to reject the biblical truth that Paradise lies ‘below.’

Gnostic deception and false teachings (roughly 332 BC to 30 BC) were rooted in cultural conditioning and Greco-Roman cosmology that held “up” as *divine* and “down” as *demonic*.

Early Gnostic thought inverted the biblical cosmology, teaching that “up” was divine and “down” was evil. That distorted perspective infiltrated many Christian *traditions*. Our afterlife *will not be* “up there” in God’s “heavenly” realm. Our afterlife *will be* “down below” in Sheol’s Paradise.

For many, the idea of a spiritual paradise beneath our feet is jarring—even crazy. But that is biblical truth. The anxious frustration you may be feeling arises from cognitive dissonance and confirmation bias, psychological barriers shaped by traditions inherited from family, Sunday school, and pulpit teachings.

Much of the confusion around the afterlife stems from early Christian debates and teachings influenced by Gnostic ideas—beliefs later rejected as heretical by the church. These teachings, which elevated ‘heaven’ as the ultimate destination ‘up above,’ shaped many traditions that persist today. Understanding this history helps explain why the biblical vision of Paradise ‘below’ can feel counterintuitive, even unsettling, to modern readers.

The Early Debate: Christians vs. Gnostics

Name	Promoted Gnosticism?	Considered Orthodox Church Father?
Simon Magus	Yes	No
Valentinus	Yes	No
Basilides	Yes	No
Marcion	Yes (dualistic)	No
Cerinthus	Yes (proto-Gnostic)	No
Irenaeus	No – refuted it	Yes
Tertullian	No – refuted it	Yes

4 [2] “...preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, and exhort, with complete patience and teaching. [3] For the time is coming when people will not endure sound teaching, but having itching ears they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own passions, [4] and will turn away from listening to the truth and wander off into myths. [5] ... endure suffering, do the work of an evangelist, fulfill your ministry. ...[8] ...there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will award to me on that day, and not only to me but also to all who have loved his appearing.”

— 2 Timothy 4:2-8

Gnosticism emphasized the distinction between the material and spiritual worlds — gods live “up there” on mountain tops, so it was logical to aspire to be where the gods are. Gnostics believed that salvation comes through specialized knowledge (gnosis), enabling the believer to transcend the material world and reunite with the divine source.

Gnosticism was one of the obstacles Paul faced during his ministry in the eastern Mediterranean. Whereas Gnostics would consider “the

third heaven” desirable, Jesus and the Israelites rightly understood that “Paradise” is down, not up!

(Comparative Chart: Gnosticism, Stoicism, Neoplatonism is on the next page.)

Comparative Chart: Gnosticism, Stoicism, Neoplatonism

Category	Gnosticism	Stoicism	Neoplatonism
View of the Material World	Evil; prison for the divine spark	Neutral or good; governed by rational order	Imperfect image of higher realities; not inherently evil
Ultimate Goal	Escape the material world via secret knowledge (gnosis)	Achieve inner virtue and rational harmony with nature	Reunite the soul with the transcendent One through ascent
Human Condition	Divine soul trapped in a corrupt physical body	Rational beings capable of moral progress	Soul fallen into matter, seeking reunion with the divine
Knowledge/Salvation	Hidden knowledge awakens the soul and leads to salvation	Self-discipline and philosophical wisdom lead to inner peace	Intellectual contemplation leads to spiritual ascent
View of the Divine	Supreme remote God; Demiurge created flawed material world	Pantheistic or monistic; divine reason (logos) embedded in cosmos	The One (ineffable source); divine hierarchy: Nous, World Soul, etc.
Afterlife	Return to the Pleroma for the enlightened; oblivion for the ignorant	Unclear or irrelevant; virtue its own reward	Soul ascends through stages back to the One after purification
Ethics	Often dualistic: ascetic rejection of the body or antinomian license	Virtue through rational control: courage, wisdom, justice, temperance	Purification and discipline to free the soul for intellectual ascent

(Turn the page to find Paul’s “Third-Heaven” Vision.)

Paul and the “Third Heaven” Vision

Paul’s ‘third heaven’ experience was a visionary revelation, not a physical relocation. His uncertainty (‘whether in the body or out of the body I do not know’) signals this. This passage does not contradict Paradise being subterranean — it is not a literal ascent into a cosmic realm.

12 [2] “I know a man in Christ who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven—whether in the body or out of the body I do not know, God knows. [3] And I know that this man was caught up into paradise—whether in the body or out of the body, I do not know, God knows—[4] and he heard things that cannot be told, which man may not utter.”

— 2 Corinthians 12:2-4

Paul said he was “caught up to the third heaven,” but twice admitted, “I do not know whether in the body or out.” That strongly suggests a vision. In Paul’s ministry, he often confronted Gnostics, so it’s possible 2 Corinthians 12:2-4 was a satirical taunt against the Gnostics — but don’t hold me to that.

If God is omnipresent, which He is — then His presence is just as real in the depths of the earth as in the heights of the heavens.

Why is it so hard to believe that *Paradise* — the place of peace, rest, and hopeful anticipation of the righteous dead — is *downward*? And why is it so easy to assume that “the third heaven” is a dimension beyond the cosmos?

Our afterlife will not be “up there” in God’s atmospheric “heavenly” realm. Our afterlife will be “down below” in Sheol’s Paradise.

Paradise being “below” rather than “above” doesn’t make it inferior; it makes it biblical. I go in the direction the Word of God points me.

In Luke 16, Jesus places both the righteous (Lazarus) and the unrighteous (the rich man) in Sheol—the realm of the underworld. A chasm separates Paradise and Hades. This is not allegory or metaphor — it is the Messiah pulling back the curtain on the actual structure of the unseen realm.

Scholars Interpreting Paul's “Third Heaven” Experience as a Visionary Revelation

Scholar	Work / Source	Viewpoint Summary
Craig S. Keener	<i>NCBC: 1–2 Corinthians</i>	Visionary ascent in Jewish apocalyptic style.
Gordon D. Fee	<i>NICNT on Corinthians</i>	Mystical/visionary, not bodily.
F.F. Bruce	<i>Paul: Apostle of the Heart Set Free</i>	Rapture-like vision, not physical.
Richard B. Hays	<i>Moral Vision of the NT</i>	Revelatory, underscores Paul's prophetic status.
Ben Witherington III	<i>Conflict and Community in Corinth</i>	Vision for rhetorical contrast—not physical.
N.T. Wright	<i>Paul and the Faithfulness of God</i>	Apocalyptic vision, not translocation.
James D.G. Dunn	<i>Theology of Paul the Apostle</i>	Mystical, non-corporeal revelation.
Michael Heiser	<i>Podcast / Q&A</i>	Second Temple visionary motif.
Raymond E. Brown	<i>Intro to NT Theology</i>	Common apocalyptic mystical vision.

Paradise Below, Not Above

Jesus told the thief on the cross, “*Today you will be with Me in Paradise*”⁵³. That day, Jesus descended, not ascended. He went down to Sheol, then three days later was resurrected back to the earth’s surface; forty

days after that, He ascended to heaven. “Paradise” was not celestial—it is *not* the “third heaven”⁵⁴. It is subterranean.

I propose that Paradise is where the righteous dead receive their didactic and practical training, enabling and empowering them to assist King Jesus in restoring the earth.

Endnotes

53. Luke 23:43 — Jesus’ promise to the thief on the cross.

54. 2 Corinthians 12:2-4 — Paul’s reference to the “third heaven” distinguished from Paradise below.

Jesus’ Transfiguration

At Jesus’ Transfiguration (**Matthew 17**), Moses and Elijah appeared with Him, witnessed by Peter, James, and John. Many have been taught that this proves the pair descended from “up there” heaven. But what proof exists that they did not instead come up from “down there” Paradise?

Moses, Elijah, and Samuel: Visitors from Paradise?

Moses died and was buried by God in Moab: “*So Moses the servant of the LORD died there in the land of Moab, according to the word of the LORD. And He buried him in the valley in the land of Moab opposite Beth-peor; but no one knows the place of his burial to this day*”⁵⁵.

Elijah was taken up in a whirlwind—not said to ascend into God’s throne room: “*And as they still went on and talked, behold, chariots of fire and horses of fire separated the two of them. And Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven*”⁵⁶. The Hebrew *shamayim* means “sky” or “the heavens,” not necessarily the celestial realm of God. In **2 Kings 2:12**, Elisha cried, “*My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!*”—not “the chariots of heaven.”

To be clear, 2 Kings 2:12 says: *“And Elisha saw it and he cried, ‘My father, my father! The chariots of Israel and its horsemen!’ And he saw him no more.”* The Bible does not say “the chariots of Heaven.” It says “the chariots of Israel.” And in verse 11, the original Hebrew uses Strong’s H8064 (*haš-šā-ma-yim*), meaning into “the sky” or into “the heavens,” not into “Heaven” in the sense of God’s dwelling.

For those who have been led to believe that Moses and Elijah descended from Heaven to stand with Jesus, it is worth considering that perhaps the pair did not come “down” at all, but instead came “up” from Paradise.

While tradition often assumes Moses and Elijah descended from heaven to appear with Jesus, biblical language about ‘heaven’ here means ‘sky’ rather than God’s throne room. Given Moses was buried and Elijah’s ascension was to ‘the heavens’ (sky), it is plausible they appeared after being raised ‘up’ from Sheol’s Paradise, not ‘down’ from God’s celestial realm.

Endnotes

55. Deuteronomy 34:5-6 — Moses’ death and burial in Moab.

56. 2 Kings 2:11-12 — Elijah’s ascent in a whirlwind into the sky (*shamayim*).

Samuel, Saul, and the Witch of Endor

In 1 Samuel 28, Saul disguised himself, visited a medium by night, and said, *“Divine for me by a spirit and bring up for me whomever I shall name to you”*⁵⁷. When the woman asked who, Saul replied, *“Bring up Samuel for me”*⁵⁸—not “bring down.”

The woman reported, *“I see a god coming up out of the earth”*⁵⁹. Saul asked, *“What is his appearance?”* She replied, *“An old man is coming up,*

and he is wrapped in a robe.” Then Samuel said to Saul, “Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?”⁶⁰

Samuel was fully aware of Saul’s circumstances, rebuked him, and even prophesied—proof that souls in Sheol’s Paradise have conscious awareness and agency.

Samuel’s spirit coming ‘up’ from Sheol shows that the afterlife for the righteous dead is beneath the earth, not ‘up’ in heaven. This biblical account contradicts the common notion that souls ascend to God’s throne at death.

Endnotes

57. 1 Samuel 28:8 — Saul’s request to summon a spirit.

58. 1 Samuel 28:11 — Saul asks for Samuel by name.

59. 1 Samuel 28:13 — The woman sees a spirit “coming up out of the earth.”

60. 1 Samuel 28:15 — Samuel’s rebuke for disturbing him by bringing him up.

The Resurrection Is Our Hope — Not An Escape to “Heaven”

The Bible never teaches we will be raised to live in heaven. Instead:

“Blessed are the meek, for they shall inherit the earth.”⁶¹

“They came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.”⁶²

God plans to restore the earth, not evacuate humanity to the sky. At the end of the millennial reign, God will dwell with His people here on the renewed earth.⁶³

Our hope is not to escape to heaven but to be raised to eternal life on

a renewed earth, reigning with Christ as co-heirs and judges. This truth, central to biblical teaching, is lost in much modern theology.

Endnotes

61. Matthew 5:5 — The meek will inherit the earth.
62. Revelation 20:4 — The saints reign with Christ for a thousand years.
63. Revelation 21:3 — God dwells with His people on the renewed earth.

Our Future Is on Earth, Not in Heaven

No human will ever ascend into Heaven to live with God. Instead, God Himself will descend to earth to dwell with man³. The kingdom Jesus inaugurates will be earthly and eternal.

Our Blessed Hope

Our blessed hope is the resurrection—up from Sheol's Paradise, back to life on earth, clothed with immortality, reigning with Christ:

“...our blessed hope, the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ...”⁶⁴

“For the Lord Himself will descend from heaven... and the dead in Christ will rise first... and so we will always be with the Lord.”⁶⁵

“Then I saw thrones, and those seated on them were given authority to judge...”⁶⁶

“Do you not know we shall judge angels?”⁶⁷

We are heirs of Christ's kingdom—called to reign with Him on earth,

not in heaven. That was God's intent from the beginning, when He created "the heavens and the earth" and formed Adam from the dust.

We will be raised to the surface of the earth—clothed with immortality and commissioned to rule and reign with Christ. Heaven ("up there") has never been our home. The Earth is.

Endnotes

64. Titus 2:13 — The appearing of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ.

65. 1 Thessalonians 4:16-17 — The Lord's descent and resurrection of the dead.

66. Revelation 20:4 — Saints given authority to judge.

67. 1 Corinthians 6:3 — Believers will judge angels.



Addendum: Jesus the Firstfruit of the First Resurrection — We Share in This Hope

Jesus' descent into Sheol (Acts 2:31, 1 Peter 3:19) confirms that Paradise is 'below,' not 'up above.' His resurrection and eventual ascension demonstrate the path of restoration—from the depths to the earth, and then to God's throne—not a permanent residence 'in heaven.'"

References (not tied to superscripts): Acts 2:31; 1 Peter 3:19

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NOTE: This bibliography is selective rather than exhaustive, focusing on the most frequently consulted resources in the creation of this volume. They represent a range of biblical translations, theological studies, commentaries, and scholarly resources that informed the research and interpretation presented in this volume.



ABOUT THE AUTHOR: WHERE I STAND

AUTHOR'S THEOLOGICAL INTRODUCTION



I was raised in a Roman Catholic home—the eldest of five children, educated at a Catholic parochial school through eighth grade, and shaped by a family whose faith was sincere, disciplined, and devoted. My father, a Presbyterian, agreed to have his children raised Catholic as a condition of marrying my mother. That decision profoundly influenced my early spiritual formation.

Similarly, my wife was raised in the Catholic and Lutheran traditions. We raised our sons within a non-denominational evangelical Christian framework, prioritizing Christ-centered education and discipleship over denominational allegiance.

I trained as a surgeon and served as a medical missionary in Papua New Guinea, China, East Africa, and the North Africa & Middle East regions. I was fortunate to have combined gospel-driven compassion with practical service.

What began as a lifelong personal pursuit of biblical clarity has

grown into a focused mission: to help believers understand what God truly revealed in the Bible. I write today as a follower of Jesus Christ—not in the modern denominational sense, but in the biblical one. I believe in one Christian faith, whispered to the prophets, taught by Jesus and His apostles, and faithfully preserved in their original-language Hebrew, Greek, and Aramaic Testaments.

— *Tim*

PROMOTION FOR VOLUME 2

In Volume 1, I've tried to give you a panoramic view of God's plan for the end of the age — but the message I hope you grasped is that it's not the end, it's merely the beginning!

Volume 2 will take you much deeper into the dimensions of the Day of the Lord — truths they won't dare teach you from the pulpit or even in seminary. You'll see biblical prophecies come full circle — from Eden lost to Eden restored. Together, we will explore the radiant beauty and unending joy that His redeemed people will experience, dwelling with Him face-to-face.

Volume 2 is not merely the continuation of a story—it is the deep dive into the climax of redemptive history. There, every promise will be fulfilled, every shadow banished, and every tear wiped away.

Prepare to stand at the threshold of forever.

— Dr. Tim James

